A Holistic Strategy for the Evangelization of Oral Learners

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Abstract

Communicating the gospel across cultural barriers is an essential element of the Great Commission. Jesus mandated that his followers should go and make disciples of all the nations (Matt. 28:19a). The gospel was not limited to Israel, but it was good news for all peoples in all lands. Thus, beginning with Paul, Christians continue to take the gospel to πάντα τὰ ἔθνη.

Fluency in language and culture traditionally have been the benchmarks of effectively engaging cultures in the task of teaching them to observe all that Jesus commanded (Matt. 28:20a). Missionaries have endeavored to inhabit the milieus in which they labor in order to transpose the message of the gospel in such a way that indigenous Christianity resulted with minimal levels of syncretism and apostasy. In recent decades, however, missionaries have been confronted with a another facet contextualizing the gospel into a culture.

More than 80 percent of the world's population function within the orality framework. The prevalence of oral learners alone is sufficient stimulus to analyze the nature of orality. However, when one apprehends the extensive effect orality possesses in evangelization, discipleship, and church planting, impetus to address this issue becomes critical. Orality's sweeping implications for missions cannot be ignored. Efficacious engagement of oral learners reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Cross-cultural communication is a structural element of the Great Commission. Jesus plainly conveyed the central task of his followers: go and make disciples πάντα τὰ ἔθνη (Matt. 28:19a), making known God's universal intent of the salvific work of the Messiah.[1] The gospel was not limited to the dispersian of Jews living among the gentiles, but it was available to the gentiles themselves in all lands.[2] Thus, beginning with Paul's missionary journeys recorded in the New Testament, Christians continue to cross cultures with the message of the gospel. In fact, due to the explosion of short-term missions, this is occuring more than ever before in the history of Christianity.[3]

Historically, missionaries have considered language and culture to be the predominant hinderances to the task of διδάσκοντες αὐτοὺς τηρεῖν πάντα ὅσα ἐνετειλάμην ὑμῖν (Matt. 28:20a).[4] Missionaries have sought to inhabit cultures in order to

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[1]God's universal intent for the nations is first perceived in the call of Abram

[2]A. T. Robertson, *Comentario Al Texto Griego Del Nuevo Testamento: Obra Completa (6 Tomos En 1)* (Barcelona, España: Editorial Clie, 2003), 72.

[3]The advent of expansive short-term missions (STM) has caused concern among missiologists. The so-called "amateurization" of missions has led many to offer critiques of the movement (Adeney, 2006; Birth, 2006; Hesselgrave, 2005; Priest et al., 2006; Ver Beek, 2006). See especially John Plake's "Amateurization and Professionalization from the Perspective of Missionary Effectiveness" in *Missiology: An International Review* 42, no. 2 (2014): 152-166.

[4]"…of all nations." (Mat. 28:19a); "…teaching them to keep all things whatsoever I commanded you" (Mat. 28:20a).

transcribe the message of the gospel in such a way that indigenous Christianity resulted with minimal levels of syncretism and apostasy.[5] In recent decades, however, missionaries have begun to explore in earnest another facet of putting the gospel into a culture, namely cognitive framework.[6]

Grant Lovejoy, in "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," estimates "5.7 billion people in the world are oral communicators because they are either illiterate or their reading comprehension is inadequate," equaling more than 80 percent of the world's total population.[7] The prevalence of oral learners alone is sufficient stimulus to analyze the nature of orality. However, when one apprehends the extensive effect orality possesses in evangelization, discipleship, and church planting, impetus to address this issue becomes critical. Orality's sweeping implications for contextualization in communicating the gospel to πάντα τὰ ἔθνη cannot be ignored.[8]

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[5]Missionaries have confronted the problem of cross-cultural transference of the Christian faith to other cultures since the first century (see Acts 15). Not until the age of modern missions, however, did missionaries and organizations begin to develop a formalized way to deal with this issue. Early attempts resulted in what is known as accommodation (Luzbetak, 1970). Missiologists eventually settled on contextualization as the preeminent method for producing indigenous faith (Hiebert, 1987; Hesselgrave, 1995; Brown 2006).

[6]Randy Arnett, "Discipleship in the Face of Orality." A Paper Presented to Dr. David Sills, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, (May 2010), 1.

[7]Grant Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update." *Orality Journal* 1, no. 1 (2012), 29.

[8]Building on the foundations laid by Milman Parry, Albert Lord, Claude Lévi-Strauss, and A. R. Luria, Walter J. Ong ushered in the age of orality studies across multiple disciplines with his seminal work, *Orality and Literacy*. Walter Ong, *Orality and Literacy: The Technologizing of the Word*, (New York: Routledge, 1982); Milman Parry and Adam Parry, *The Making of Homeric Verse: Collected Papers* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971); Albert Lord, *The Singer of Tales* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1960); Levi-Strauss, Claude. *The Savage Mind* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1962); and A. R. Luria, *Cognitive Development: Its Cultural and Social*

Research Problem and Thesis

Due in large part to Trevor McIlwain's work in the Philippines in the early 1980s, the modern orality movement garnered acceptance and eventually adoption among evangelicals. This resulted in the formation of networks, organization of training programs, establishment of journals, and even inclusion in seminary curriculums. However, a survey of evangelical literature concerning orality reveals a paucity of in-depth treatment of the nature and implications of orality, as well as the necessary adaptations a non-oral person must make to become an effective messenger to oral cultures. The primary focus of evangelicals in the field of orality continues to be the employment of oral methodologies.

Charles Madinger defines orality as a framework of "how oral cultures receive, remember, and replicate (pass on) news, important information, and truth."[9] Yet, preparing textual messengers to engage oral folk has concentrated largely on methodologies, especially chronological Bible storying (CBS). Missionaries learn to communicate the biblical narrative through spoken word, song, dance, visual art, and other cultural appropriate media, all the while overlooking the wider orality framework. While CBS and its corresponding delivery mechanisms certainly ought to be central to any approach to reach oral learners, the activity alone is lacking. Madinger comments, "In missiological circles, 'orality' promotes reaching oral learners, but it often gets isolated to methodologies, neglecting to consider the principles and disciplines that make

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Foundations. Martin Lopez-Morillas and Lynn Solotaroff, trans., Michael Cole, ed. (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1976).

[9]Charles Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality: A Holistic Model." *Missiology: An International Review* XXXVIII, no. 2 (April 2010): 204.

those methods work."[10] Efficacious engagement of oral learners reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

This research project demonstrates that the employment oral methodologies, such as CBS, divorced from careful consideration of the orality framework for the evangelization and discipleship of oral peoples is inadequate. Because of the profound differences between orality and textuality, holistic and effective engagement of oral peoples requires a profound and nuanced adaptation of missiological philosophy and strategy, in addition to methodology.[11]

Research Method

Chapter 2 surveys, examines, and analyzes the historical presence and application of orality in the Judeo-Christian tradition. Specifically, this chapter surveys the Old and New Testaments, early church fathers, Medieval Period, Reformation Period, and Modern Missions Era.

Biblical writers recorded some of the earliest examples of oral communication.[12] Although there is renewed emphasis on the issue of orality and the use of narrative in

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[10]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality: A Holistic Model," 201.

[11]Albert Lord, "Characteristics of Orality," *Oral Tradition* 2 (1987): 54-72 and Walter J. Ong, "Worship at the End of the Age of Literacy," *Worship* 43 (1969): 478-79, list a number of characteristics which set off orally based thought and expression from chirographically based thought and expression. Many of which strike those embedded in print cultures as surprising. These characteristics will be considered in depth in chapters 3 and 4 of this work.

[12]Grant Lovejoy, "Chronological Bible Storying: Description, Rationale and Implications." (A Paper Presented at the Non-Print Media Consultation, Nairobi, Kenya, June 2000), 2.

information dissemination, the use of stories and parables as a means of communication and transmission of information is as old as the Scriptures themselves.[13] The Scriptures' accounts of oral communication, as well as their preservation through oral tradition, attest to the legitimacy and pervasiveness of orality.

Prominent figures in the early church evangelized and discipled within oral constructs. For example, Origen (184-253) recognized the importance of oral transmission of the sweeping story of God, and he believed that those who desired and committed to follow Christ must become familiar with the unfolding historical drama of Scripture immediately.[14] Similarly, Augustine (354-430) made use of a comprehensive catechism in order that all uninstructed believers would gain a thorough understanding of the comprehensive sweep of Scripture, which he referred to as "Salvation History."[15] Caedmon (d. *c*.680), upon taking up monastic life, began composing songs. Notably, his songs were narrative in nature, and he was interested in making them accessible to the illiterate population.[16]

Even the Reformation period, often pictured as print-driven, was heavily steeped in orality. R. W. Scribner states, "Since the sixteenth century, it has been a historical commonplace that [the Reformation] was largely a result of the impact of printing."[17]

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[13]J.O. Terry, "Roots of CBS," *Journal of Bible Storying* 1, no. 1 (July 2004): 3.

[14]Tom A. Steffen and J. O. Terry, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time." *Missiology: An International Review* 35, no. 3 (July 2007): 317.

[15]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story," 317.

[16]Ibid.

[17]R. W. Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements in Reformation Germany* (London: The Hambledon Press, 1987), 49.

Nevertheless, to focus solely on the printed word directs attention too narrowly at the small, if growing, elite literate group. This view ignores the vast quantity of the illiterate and semi-literate people, a segment of the population that has been estimated at ninety percent.[18]

From the dawn of the modern missions era, cross-cultural workers have found themselves endeavoring to communicate the gospel to oral cultures. William Carey (1761-1834) in India, John Nevius (1829-1893) in East Asia, Johannes Gustav Warneck (1867-1944) in Indonesia, Christian Keysser (1877-1961) in New Guinea, Georg Friedrich Vicedom (1903-1974) in New Guinea, Donald McGavran (1897-1990) in India, and many others have left testament of their confrontation with and subsequent adjustment to cultures whose learning styles did not match their own.

It was not until the early 1980s, however, that a concern for the issue of orality began to proliferate widely among evangelical missionaries. Trevor McIlwain and his family of New Tribes Mission (NTM) arrived in southern Palawan in 1965 to begin mission work. McIlwain came to the conclusion that the Palaweño people did not sufficiently understand their spiritual condition, which led to a deficient understanding of the gospel. This prompted him to teach the Palaweños chronologically, beginning with creation. Soon the Palaweños came under conviction of sin and understood the predicament in which they found themselves. With the foundation of this essential truth laid, McIlwain proceeded to the New Testament, proclaiming the coming of the Savior and the grace of God.[19]

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[18]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 49.

[19]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 7.

The success of McIlwain's methodology quickly acquired interest among other NTM personnel. From NTM, an emphasis on chronological teaching of the Bible spread into the International Mission Board of the Southern Baptist Convention under the auspices of Jim Slack and J. O. Terry. Slack and Terry eventually conceived of chronological Bible storying (CBS), an adaptation of McIlwain's original methodology. As the movement gained momentum, it placed almost exclusive focus on the CBS method. To date, little emphasis has been placed among evangelical missiologists and practitioners on the oral framework in which effective CBS yields fruit.

Chapter 3 discusses the profound and sweeping implications of orality in individuals and in societies. Storying does not equal orality. Rather, storying is an application of the principles of orality. This chapter contrasts characteristics of orality with textuality and examines the deep role of narrative in the conversion, discipleship, and church formation processes.

Walter J. Ong's seminal work, *Orality and Literacy*, illuminated the stark contrast between orality and textuality. He describes the deep-seated variant perspectives held by oral folk. For example, within oral societies words have no visual presence, but rather they are representatives of happenings or events.[20] Language is a mode of action rather than a countersign of thought.[21] Further, words are experienced as perishable. Because

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[20]Walter J. Ong, "Orality, Literacy, and Modern Media," in David Crawley and Paul Heyer, *Communication in History: Technology, Culture Society*, 3rd ed. (New York, Longman, 1999), 64.

[21]Bronislaw Malinowski, "The Problem of Meaning in Primitive Languages," in C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards (eds), *The Meaning of Meaning: A Study of the Influence of Language upon Thought and of the Science of Symbolism* (New York: Harcourt, 1923), 451, 470-81.

sound can only exist when it is going out of existence, language is "essentially evanescent, and it is sensed as evanescent."[22]

For oral peoples sound is commonly, and probably universally, considered to bear great power. In fact, sound cannot be made without the employment of power.[23] Textual people forget to think of words as primarily oral and necessarily powered. For them, words have been dissected, systematized, and categorized and therefore are, in a radical sense, dead.[24]

Be that as it may, orality is much more nuanced and sweeping than the nature of words. Madinger and others signal an extensive framework that undergirds the dissemination of information in oral cultures. This framework includes not only communication style, but also understanding of time and space, gratification, and lifestyle. Naturally, the role of narrative within the orality framework is significant, but it is more complex than the basic transference of information. Transformation is realized through the experience of narrative. Narrative operates as the primary vehicle by which conversion, discipleship, and church formation occur. This is true not simply because information can be effectively transferred via narrative, but because identity and worldview are essentially narrative constructs.

A shift on the fundamental level of worldview is tantamount to conversion. Stan May contends, "If missionaries wish to produce lasting change, they must focus on

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[22]Ong, "Orality, Literacy, and Modern Media," 65.

[23]Ibid.

[24]Walter J. Ong, *Interfaces of the Word* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1977), 230-271.

worldview transformation."[25] Chapter 3 argues that the foundation of worldview is narrative, and it is with the narrative of a people that the catalyst of change must concern himself if he hopes to effect genuine transformation in worldview, which will in turn bring about change in beliefs, values, and, ultimately, external behavior.

Likewise, continued transformation of worldview in accordance with the Scriptures (discipleship) results from recitation and reinforcement of foundational narratives or myths. A people's story serves to provide continual reinforcement of an adopted worldview. Tom Steffen confirms, "Worldview…finds its foundational meaning in myths and stories…To survive, any worldview requires the recitation of myths and stories."[26]

Further, church planting within oral cultures is acutely affected by narrative. Chapter 3 contends narrative is the preeminent and ideal homogenizing factor in the emergence and development of churches. The church is a community gathered in faith around the sacred story of God as revealed in the Old and New Testaments. Scott McClellan states, "The church is a community rooted in the story of God and indwelled by His Spirit."[27] Though the church is constituted of unique individuals, it is coalesced by the gospel story and its transforming power.

Chapter 4 explores three movements toward Christ in which the orality framework was the means by which the message flowed. Case studies are presented for

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[25]Stan May, "Cultures and Worldviews," in *Discovering the Mission of God*, Mike Barnett, ed. (Downers Gove: IVP Academic, 2012), 387.

[26]Tom Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry: Cross-cultural Storytelling at Home and Abroad* (La Habra, CA: Center for Organizational and Ministry Development, 1996), 31-32.

analysis in light of the orality framework. These case studies provide examples of seeing cultures through "oral eyes." The key to engaging oral cultures is to first comprehend oral characteristics, and then to tease out the forms that those characteristics take in any given oral context. Once these two important steps are taken, then the third step of contextualizing the gospel message into oral milieus can take place.

Three predominant oral milieus exist. Primary orality describes an oral context in which visual representation of spoken language is unknown. Literacy has virtually no presence in primary oral societies. Residual orality refers to societies where literacy has been introduced and integrated but where orality remains the primary framework in which people process and image information. Secondary orality labels traditionally textual societies that have transitioned into an oral framework due to the effects of pervasive communication technologies.

Conclusion

The incumbency upon followers of Christ to take the gospel across cultures is clear. Thus, the preparation of missionaries and contextualization of the message is unavoidable and critical. While language and culture are obviously primary concerns, the issue of orality must not be overlooked. Since the early 1980s a surge of interest in orality has emerged. The trajectory of this movement, however, resulted in a narrow and incomplete treatment of orality, focusing primarily on the methodology of CBS.

The nature and implications of orality merit the depth of scrutiny to which missionaries give language and culture. Replacing expositional communication with

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[27]Scott McClellan, *Tell Me a Story: Finding God (and Ourselves) Through Narrative* (Chicago, IL: Moody Publishers, 2013), 127.

narrative formulations is an important step toward laboring within the orality framework, but in and of itself this method falls short. Rather, efficacious engagement of oral learners reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

Chapter 2

Orality in Christian History

In 2005 the Issue Group 25 of the 2004 Lausanne Forum estimated that oral learners consisted of 4 billion people.[28] In 2012 Grant Lovejoy revised this number to 80 percent of the world's population, or 5.7 billion people.[29] Moreover, even the textual are becoming less so. Rick Brown observes, "A general trend in history has been the progress from primary orality to some literacy with residual orality, and from then in some cases [e.g., U.S. academia] to a print-oriented culture. The modern trend is to move on to secondary orality."[30] Secondary orality refers to literate persons who prefer verbal, visual, and digital means of communication.

Orality is an irrefutably critical issue in missions today, but avant-garde it is not. Certainly, there is a modern resurgence of interest in and fondness for narrative in the Western world, but for the vast majority of the world and for millennia orality has

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[28]Grant Lovejoy, ed. *Making Disciples of Oral Learners* (Richmond, VA: ION/LCWE, 2005), 3.

[29]Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," 11-39.

[30]Rick Brown, "Communicating God's Message in an Oral Culture: Communicating Effectively to Non-Readers." *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 21, no. 3 (Fall 2004), 123.

dominated the human experience.[31] It is only in the past few hundred years that textuality has gained slight ground on orality, and that ground gained is now being lost.[32]

Oral learners comprise the majority of the planet, yet modern Western missionaries have traditionally engaged other cultures with methods developed by and for literate learners. While these endeavors were successful among literate populations, they have been largely unprofitable among the oral majority.[33]

Thus, over the past quarter century, missionaries have increasingly employed oral forms of communication as a primary methodology. The preeminent oral methodology is *Chronological Bible Storying* (CBS), developed by Jim Slack and J. O. Terry of the

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[31]In fact, when the Waste Isolation Pilot Plant in New Mexico began to design some a marker that would be comprehensible tens of thousands of years into the future in order to warn humanity of the nuclear waste that is stored under ground there, they strongly considered a narrative approach. After ruling out symbols, due to their propensity to take on new meaning, Jon Lomberg argued that the only communication method that would remain static 10,000 years into the future was storytelling. After all, storytelling is the obvious common denominator throughout human history. Language and symbols, on the contrary, continually evolve. See Roman Mars, "10,000 Years," 99% Invisible, http://99percentinvisible.org/episode/ten-thousand-years/.

[32]Jonah Sachs attributes the modern shift to secondary orality to the digitalization of information and communicative processes. He reports: "The oral tradition that dominated human experience for all but the last few hundred years is returning with a vengeance. It's a monumental, epoch-making, totally unforeseen turn of events . . . our new digital culture of information sharing has so rejected the broadcast style and embraced key elements of oral traditions, that we might meaningfully call whatever's coming next the digitoral era." See Jonah Sachs. *Winning the Story Wars: Why Those Who Tell (and Live) the Best Stories Will Rule the Future* (Boston, MA: Harvard Business Review Press, 2012), 20. See also Jay Moon, "Encouraging Ducks to Swim: Suggestions for Seminary Professors Teaching Oral Learners." *William Carey International Development Journal* 2, no. 2 (Spring 2013).

[33]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 3. In 2005 Grant Lovejoy estimated that 90 percent of the world's Christian workers presented the gospel using highly literate styles of communication.

International Mission Board of the Southern Baptist Convention.[34] Nevertheless, neither orality nor the elements of CBS are new. Orality, and especially the oral and chronological communication of the Scriptures, pervades the composition and content of the Scriptures and characterizes the experience of Christians throughout history; this has surfaced as a critical issue in missions since the beginning of the modern missions era.[35]

Jonathan Gottschall contends that "thousands of years ago, when the human mind was young and our numbers were few, we were telling one another stories."[36] Throughout history cultures have valued, invented, repeated, and preserved stories. N. T. Wright contends that "story, with its pattern of problem and conflict, of aborted attempts at resolution, and final result…is, if we may infer from the common practice of the world, universally perceived as the best way of talking about the way the world actually is."[37] Although renewed emphasis on orality and oral methodologies exists, the use of stories and parables deployed within oral frameworks is as old as the Scriptures themselves.[38]

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[34]J. O. Terry defines Bible Storying as "the intentional and uninterrupted sharing of God's Word primarily as stories." See J.O. Terry, *Basic Bible Storying*, (Fort Worth, TX: Church Starting Network, 2008), 2; Further, Issue Group 25 of the 2004 Lausanne Forum states that a "storying" approach "involves selecting and crafting stories that convey the essential biblical message, in a way that is sensitive to the worldview of the receptor society. The stories are faithful to the Biblical text, and at the same time told in a natural, compelling manner in the heart language." Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 11.

[35]Lovejoy, "Chronological Bible Storying: Description, Rationale and Implications," 2.

[36]Jonathan Gottschell, *The Storytelling Animal: How Stories Make us Human* (Boston: Mariner Books, 2013), xiii.

[37]N. T. Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1992), 40.

[38]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 3.

This chapter surveys the presence of orality and application of oral methodologies in the Old Testament and New Testament, Christian history, and modern missions. Literate learners view the world abstractly in principles and concepts; oral learners, on the contrary, think in concrete terms utilizing stories, symbols, and parables.[39] The most readily observable manifestation of orality is the extensive use of spoken language to disseminate information through story, parable, proverb, and other similar linguistic mechanisms. For this reason, this chapter will lean heavily on the use of these media as indicator of the presence of orality.[40]

Old Testament

Ancient Israel was an oral culture. The Israelites "received, remembered, and replicated news, important information, and truth" within an oral framework, which manifested itself prominently in the extensive use of narrative in all arenas of Israelite life.[41] The biblical tradition, for example, evinces narration within the family unit:

> And you shall observe this event as an ordinance for you and your children forever. When you enter the land which the Lord will give you, as He has promised, you shall observe this rite. And when your children say to you, "What does this rite mean to you?" you shall say, "It is a Passover sacrifice to the Lord who passed over the houses of the sons of Israel in Egypt when He smote the Egyptians, but spared our homes" (Ex. 12:24-27).

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[39]Brown, "Communicating God's Message in an Oral Culture," 123.

[40]As Charles Madinger reports, "For many today the term orality is equated with Bible storying, but orality is rather a framework for what makes Bible storying and other such methods effective." See Charles Madinger, "Applied Orality: More than Methods," *Missions Frontiers* 36, no. 3 (May/June 2014): 6-8.

[41]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality: A Holistic Model," 204.

The Scriptures obligated every Hebrew father to recount the narrative traditions of Israel to his children. A similar injunction is made in Joshua 4:6-7.[42]

Moreover, the practice of reciting narrative was present in cultic worship. Deuteronomy 26 describes the recital of the exodus narrative tradition, which accompanied the bringing of the first fruits.[43] Further, storytelling on a tribal and national level existed in ancient Israel. Tom Boomershine explains:

> The recital of God's actions in the life of the people was also a practice at the covenant renewal festivals of the people of Israel. This tradition is reflected in Joshua 24, which records the story of the formation of the tribal amphictyony or confederation at Shechem from the original twelve tribes. As the central rite of this solemn occasion, Joshua recited the story of the actions of God in behalf of the people (Joshua 24:2-15). Joshua's story includes the stories of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the exodus, and the battles of the conquest. This account probably reflects the tradition of recital of the sacred traditions at the gatherings of the nation for covenant renewal.[44]

Israel's preference for recitation of narrative had as much to do with its worldview as its literacy level. Worldviews are, at their deepest point, shorthand formulae to express myth.[45] This is particularly conspicuous in the case of Judaism. The symbols, rituals, festivals, doctrines and traditions of Judaism are inextricably enmeshed with its

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[42]The symbols and rituals instituted by Israel served as a sort of shorthand, not for abstract theological principles, but for foundational narratives in which the nation found its identity, and in which doctrinal abstractions were embedded. The role of symbol and ritual in oral contexts is explored more fully in chapter three.

[43]Tom Boomershine, "A History of Biblical Narration," (GoTell Communications, Inc., 22 September 2014. (http://www.tomboomershine.org/writings/AHistoryOfBiblicalNarration.pdf), 3.

[44]Boomershine, "A History of Biblical Narration," 3.

[45]The role of narrative in the formation, reinforcement, and transformation of worldview is discussed extensively in chapter three.

overarching narrative and many smaller stories that fit within it.[46] The Festival of Booths, for example, is a cogent example of the ability of symbol and ritual to harness and embody foundational narrative.[47]

Oral Composition

Not only does the Old Testament contain accounts of oral communication, but also the written record itself exists as a result of preservation through oral tradition.[48] John Walton asserts:

> The ancient world was consistently hearing dominated rather than text dominant. Information was disseminated orally. Traditions were passed on by word of mouth generation to generation. The ability to read and write was not essential to be a fully functioning member of society, and literacy was not part of the basic education process, formal or informal, so no one was disadvantaged if they could not read or write.[49]

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[46]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

[47]Moses established this tradition in Leviticus: "On the fifteenth day of the seventh month, when you have gathered in the produce of the land, you shall celebrate the feast of the LORD seven days…You shall dwell in booths for seven days. All native Israelites shall dwell in booths, that your generations may know that I made the people of Israel dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt: I am the LORD your God" (Lev. 23:39–43).

[48]Because of the evanescent nature of the spoken word, principles governing oral transmission are difficult to document. The assertion that ancient documents, including much of the Old and New Testaments, were initially preserved through oral tradition, however, is well established. See Werner H. Kelber, *The Oral and the Written Gospel* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1983); Rudolf Bultmann, *The History of the Synoptic Tradition*, Eng. trans. John Marsh (New York: Harper & Row, 1963); Birger Gerhardson, *Memory and Manuscript: Oral Tradition and Written Transmission in Rabbinic Judaism and Early Christianity*, ASNU 22 (Lund: C. W. K. Gleerup; and Copenhagen: Ejnar Muskgaard, 1961).

[49]John H. Walton and B. Brent Sandy, *The Lost World of Scripture: Ancient Literary Culture and Biblical Authority* (Downer's Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2013), 18.

Hermann Gunkel (1862-1932) early considered the role of oral tradition in the composition of the Old Testament. He states:

> Now it is evident that Genesis contains the final sublimination into writing of a body of oral traditions. The tales of the patriarchs do not have the air of having been written down by the patriarchs themselves; on the contrary many passages reveal the great interval of time that lies between the period of the patriarchs and that of the narrators.[50]

Thus, the sacred story of God was orally transmitted from Adam to Noah to Abraham to Moses. The transmission of narrative was not accomplished by the careful preservation of a codex but rather by the meticulous safeguarding of the oral tradition.

J. O. Terry comments, "No doubt the patriarch fathers told and retold stories from the time of Adam and Eve until Moses was instructed by God to write them down."[51] This transference of information began just outside the garden. Through the retelling of the sacred narrative, Adam trained Cain and Abel in "religious services, that when they came to be capable of acting for themselves they may, of their own accord, bring an offering to God."[52] Subsequently, each generation retold the foundational narrative to the

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[50]Hermann Gunkel, *The Legends of Genesis*. W. H. Carruth, trans. (Chicago: The Open Court Publishers Co., 1901), 4. For example Genesis 19:38 states, "As for the younger, she also bore a son, and called his name Ben-ammi; he is the father of the sons of Ammon to this day." Gunkel's interest in revealing the oral beginnings of the Pentateuch was to demonstrate that "if the contents of Genesis is oral tradition, it is, as the preceding considerations show, legend also" (4), an assertion with which this author does not agree. On the contrary, oral composition and preservation of history is a dependable and widely-used means of historical record keeping in oral cultures. See Paul D. Wegner, *The Journey from Texts to Translations: The Origin and Development of the Bible* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1999), 130-131.

[51]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 3.

[52]Matthew Henry, *Matthew Henry's Commentary on the Whole Bible: Complete and Unabridged in One Volume* (Peabody: Hendrickson, 1994), Gen. 4:3–5.

following generation, thus preserving the words that Moses would eventually write down under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit.[53]

Narrative in Context

The Old Testament is replete with narrative, not only because ancient Israel was an oral culture but also because of the "storied structure of their worldview."[54] N. T. Wright avers, "Belief in one god, who called Israel to be his people, is the very foundation of Judaism. The only proper way of talking about a god like this, who makes a world and then acts within it, is through narration."[55] Thus, the Old Testament is itself a narration of God's actions in history, and the audience is encouraged to heed this grand narrative.[56] Further, embedded within the Old Testament chronicle exist accounts in which oral strategies are employed (sometimes unwittingly) to bring about a desired result. These are predictable, given the milieu of ancient Israel, but they are particularly

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[53]See Exodus 17:14; 34:27; 2 Peter 1:21.

[54]Fee and Stuart comment, "The Bible contains more of the type of literature called "narrative" than it does of any other literary type. For example, over 40 percent of the Old Testament is narrative. Since the Old Testament itself constitutes three-quarters of the bulk of the Bible, it is not surprising that the single most common type of literature in the entire Bible is narrative." See Gordon D. Fee and Douglas Stuart, *How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth: A Guide to Understanding the Bible*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1993), 85.

[55]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

[56]For example, the author of Psalm 78 admonishes: "Listen, O my people, to my instruction; Incline your ears to the words of my mouth. I will open my mouth in a parable; I will utter dark sayings of old, Which we have heard and known, And our fathers have told us. We will not conceal them from their children, But tell to the generation to come the praises of the Lord, And His strength and His wondrous works that He has done" (1-4). The author then recounts the major events of Israel's history.

helpful to modern day narrators of the gospel in developing strategies to reach oral learners.

Rahab, a harlot and inhabitant of Jericho, hid the spies that Joshua sent to scout Canaan, and, at great risk to herself and her household, assisted their escape from Jericho. What precipitated such potentially disastrous action? Rahab explains:

> I know that the LORD has given you the land, and that the terror of you has fallen on us, and that all the inhabitants of the land have melted away before you. For we have heard how the LORD dried up the water of the Red Sea before you when you came out of Egypt, and what you did to the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the Jordan, to Sihon and Og, whom you utterly destroyed. When we heard *it*, our hearts melted and no courage remained in any man any longer because of you; for the LORD your God, He is God in heaven above and on earth beneath (Joshua 2:9-11).

God used an unwitting narrator of his great acts to engender remarkable faith in Rahab. She later became a part of the covenant community of Israel and became the ancestor of eight prophets (including Jeremiah) and the prophetess, Huldah. Further, she is cited as a heroine of faith (Heb. 11:31) in the New Testament and is included in Jesus' ancestry by Matthew (1:5).[57]

Abimelech, the son of Gideon's concubine, conspired with his mother's family to murder the sons of Gideon and become the king of Shechem, something his father refused to do. Judges 9 recounts Abimelech's brutal slaughter of all but one of Gideon's seventy sons and his ascension to power. Upon hearing of the tragedy, Jotham, the lone survivor, stood atop Mount Gerazim and called out to the inhabitants of Shechem, warning the Schechemites of Abimelech:

> Listen to me, O men of Shechem, that God may listen to you. Once the trees went forth to anoint a king over them, and they said to the olive tree, 'Reign over us!'

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[57]Paul J. Achtemeier, Harper & Row and Society of Biblical Literature, *Harper's Bible Dictionary*, 1st ed. (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1985), 851.

> But the olive tree said to them, 'Shall I leave my fatness with which God and men are honored, and go to wave over the trees?' Then the trees said to the fig tree, 'You come, reign over us!' But the fig tree said to them, 'Shall I leave my sweetness and my good fruit, and go to wave over the trees?' Then the trees said to the vine, 'You come, reign over us!' But the vine said to them, 'Shall I leave my new wine, which cheers God and men, and go to wave over the trees?' Finally all the trees said to the bramble, 'You come, reign over us!' The bramble said to the trees, 'If in truth you are anointing me as king over you, come and take refuge in my shade; but if not, may fire come out from the bramble and consume the cedars of Lebanon.' (Judges 9:7-15)

Jotham's indictment cloaked in parable clearly exemplifies the subtlety and usefulness of oral communication to convey truth that penetrates the hearts of oral learners.[58] Jotham's parable uses familiar subject matter and draws upon common agricultural reality (uselessness of bramble). The people, however, ignored Jotham, and the curse that he uttered was fulfilled three years later.[59]

Nathan, the prophet, confronted David after his adulterous affair with Bathsheba and the murder of her husband (2 Sam. 11-12). Nathan challenged David, not with a direct accusation, but with the following story:

> There were two men in one city, the one rich and the other poor. The rich man had a great many flocks and herds. But the poor man had nothing except one little ewe lamb, which he bought and nourished. And it grew up together with him and his children. It would eat of his bread and drink of his cup and lie in his bosom. And was like a daughter to him. Now a traveler came to the rich man. And he was unwilling to take from his own flock or his own herd to prepare for the wayfarer who had come to him. Rather he took the poor man's ewe lamb and prepared it for the man who had come to him (2 Sam. 12:1-4).

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[58]The Old Testament not only employs parables, such as Jotham's, but the broader category of *mashal*. *Mashal* refers to all expressions that contain a comparison. This may be a proverb (1 Sam. 10:12), a taunt (Mic. 2:4), a dark riddle (Ps. 78:2), an allegory (Ezek. 24:3–4), or a parable. See Peter Rhea Jones, "Parables" In , in *Holman Illustrated Bible Dictionary*, ed. Chad Brand, Charles Draper, Archie England et al. (Nashville, TN: Holman Bible Publishers, 2003), 1244-45.

[59]J. D. Douglas, "Jotham," in *New Bible Dictionary*, ed. D. R. W. Wood, I. H. Marshall, A. R. Millard et al., 3rd ed. (Leicester, England; Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1996), 615.

David was infuriated by the injustice. Nathan's carefully crafted parable resulted in David's self-condemnation, and it was this confrontation through narrative that compelled David's repentance recorded in Psalm 51.

The use of parables is common in Eastern cultures, especially in the conveyance of unwelcome truth. Nathan's choice of approach was typical. The parable was based on a common custom of pastoral people who have pet lambs, which they bring up with their children.[60]

In 2 Samuel 14 David was again moved through storytelling. After David's son, Absalom, murdered Amnon, he fled to Geshur and remained there for three years. Joab knew that David longed to see his estranged son and sent for a woman from Tekoa to convince David to reconcile.[61] She recounted a fictitious circumstance that mirrored David's own situation:

> Your maidservant had two sons, but the two of them struggled together in the field, and there was no one to separate them, so one struck the other and killed him. Now behold, the whole family has risen against your maidservant, and they say, "'Hand over the one who struck his brother, that we may put him to death for the life of his brother whom he killed, and destroy the heir also."' Thus they will extinguish my coal which is left, so as to leave my husband neither name nor remnant on the face of the earth (2 Sam. 14:6-7).

Though David recognized Joab's hand in the circumstances, he was moved to action and sent Joab to invite his son back.

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[60]Robert Jamieson, A. R. Fausset and David Brown, *Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible* (Oak Harbor, WA: Logos Research Systems, Inc., 1997), 2 Sa 12:1.

[61]Tekoa was situated twelve miles south of Jerusalem, and six miles south of Bethlehem, serving two purposes. First, it would insure that the petitioner would not be familiar to David. Second, the truth of her story would be difficult to investigate.

As portions of exiled Israel returned to their homeland, Nehemiah and Ezra ushered in a renewed emphasis on obedience to the Law. Nehemiah 8-9 preserves an intriguing account of national repentance, which occurred when the people gathered for a solemn assembly. They fasted, confessed the sins of their fathers, and read from the book of the Law, after which several Levites stood before the people and, in a lengthy prayer, summarized the history of Israel (Neh. 9:5-37).

They affirmed God's glory and uniqueness, recounted God's dealing with Abram, remembered God's deliverance of Israel from Egypt and the giving of the Law, lamented Israel's rebellion, and told of God's power and guidance in leading his people into the promised land and of their subsequent rebellion, which resulted in exile. In response the people dedicated themselves to God and prepared an agreement to obey the stipulations of the law. Repentance was brought to its good and full conclusion once the sacred story was recounted and reaffirmed in the minds and hearts of the people of Israel.

New Testament

Israel's oral, storytelling nature is likewise present through the New Testament period. Gary Burge states, "Jesus lived in a storytelling world, and he was well known for his ability as a storyteller."[62] Eugene Peterson reports, "When Jesus opened his mouth and spoke, what came out, more often than not, was a story."[63]

Though literacy is a deficient measure of orality, it is helpful to consider the prevalence of reading and writing in the first century. W. V. Harris asserts that less than

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[62]Gary M. Burge, *Jesus, the Middle Eastern Storyteller* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2009), 15.

[63]Eugene Peterson, *Stories of Jesus* (Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 1999), 7.

30 percent of the first-century population could read and write.[64] Others have concluded that the first-century Jewish population enjoyed higher literacy levels because of their focus on the written Scripture. One may expect Jewish men to be literate because of their enrollment in Jewish schools.[65] However, those who engaged the written Scriptures may well have never read any other book. Further, it has been demonstrated that the ability to read does not necessarily make a literate learner.[66]

Available indicators reveal a largely oral first century middle-eastern milieu. Herbert Klem asserts the following about the state of literacy during this time:

> We may suppose that some people could read or chant the Scriptures but few people had books in their homes. Most of the use of Scriptures in the homes was done from memory. Christ could not think of reaching the masses with a new message in His century through books in Hebrew or any language. Barclay estimates that at the beginning of the fourth century the cost of having a scribe make a copy of the four Gospels would be about 91 British pounds…That is nearly $300. Similar costs in Christ's time would have prevented most people from being able to read our Lord's teachings.[67]

Further, the life and work of Jesus was initially preserved in oral tradition. Evangelical scholars contend that Jesus died around AD 30, and the first written gospel, Mark, was produced around AD 60-65.[68] The hypothetical source, known as Q, that

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[64]William V. Harris, *Ancient Literacy* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1991), 328-330.

[65]Alan Millard, *Reading and Writing in the Time of Jesus* (Sheffield, English: Sheffield Academic Press Ltd., 2000), 157-158.

[66]See Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," 11-39; and Moon, "Encouraging Ducks to Swim: Suggestions for Seminary Professors Teaching Oral Learners," 141-152.

[67]Herbert V. Klem, *Oral Communication of the Scripture: Insights from African Art* (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1982), 14.

[68]Wegner, *The Journey from Texts to Translations*, 130.

provided the information for the written accounts is not universally accepted as purely oral. Many hold suspect the possibility that an oral tradition preceded the written documents because the accuracy of oral transmission itself is regarded as deficient.[69] Terence Maurnet, however, argues the case that Q is largely oral.[70]

N. T. Wright allows for the possibility that Q may comprise both oral and written material, but he affirms that the oral would have been sufficiently static to be considered accurate source material.[71] Paul Wegner agrees and offers compelling rationale for the trustworthiness of oral transmission of the Scripture, especially the Gospels, in *The Journey from Texts to Translations: The Origin and Development of the Bible*. Facile detection of embellishments, number of eyewitnesses, the testimony of martyrdom, and negative scriptural assessments of the disciples themselves all serve to bolster the legitimacy and reliability of oral transmission of the Gospel narratives.[72]

The argument for oral pervasiveness of the New Testament context is further augmented by both the written accounts in which protagonists employ methods of

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[69]See Martha K. Stillman, "The Gospel of Peter: A Case for Oral-Only Dependency?," *Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses* 73 (1997):114-120.

[70]Terence Mournet, *Oral Tradition and Literary Dependency: Variability and Stability in the Synoptic Tradition and Q* (Tubingen, Germany: Mohr Siebeck, 2005), 203.

[71]N. T. Wright, *Jesus and the Victory of God* (London: SPCK, 1996), 133-37.

[72]See Wegner, *The Journey from Texts to Translations*, 130-131. Further, Casey argues that the relational nature of oral societies play an important role in the preservation and reliability of orally transmitted information. He states, "Personal interaction is required to enforce the informal, controlled method used to safeguard the reliability of the message." See Anthony Francis Casey, "How Shall They Hear? The Interface of Urbanization and Orality in North American Ethnic Church Planting." Ph.D. diss., The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2013.

information dissemination that are quintessentially oral (i.e. Gospels and Acts), as well as the oral framework present in the Epistles.

Jesus the Storyteller

The stories and parables of Jesus are founded in the heritage of the prophetic parables in the Old Testament.[73] When Jesus came on the scene, *mashal* was well established, as is observed in the Old Testament as well as secular sources. Jesus, however, "perfected the oral art of telling parables."[74] Nevertheless, it is rare for Christians to think of Jesus as a storyteller. Samuel Escobar speaks to this tendency:

> I challenged my readers to consider that frequently our evangelical preaching and teaching has made Jesus look more like a disciplinarian schoolteacher or a solemn professor of systematic theology than the kind of open-air peasant storyteller he was.[75]

Walter Dunnet defines a parable as "a story or situation in the human realm which is employed as a means of illustrating or defending some spiritual principle."[76] The instances of storytelling by Jesus recounted in the New Testament are far too many to

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[73]See Isa. 28:23–29; 5:1–7; 1 Kings 20:39–43; Eccles. 9:13–16; 2 Sam. 12:1–4.

[74]Jones, "Parables," 1244.

[75] Samuel Escobar, *The New Global Mission* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2003), 102. With the popularization of narrative has come a renewed emphasis on Jesus as a story teller. Caleb Suko posted, "If you to preach like Jesus did then you should tell stories, lots of them!" Caleb Suko, Twitter post, November 28, 2014 (7:50 p.m.), accessed January 2, 2015, https://twitter.com/sukofamily/status/538510212253368320. This interest is also accompanied by scholarly evaluation. Gary Burge states, "Jesus lived in a storytelling world, and he was well-known for his ability as a storyteller." See Burge, *Jesus, The Middle Eastern Storyteller*, 15.

[76]Walter M. Dunnett, *Exploring the New Testament* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2001), 21. Further, Dunnet comments, "In these three Gospels at least thirty separate parables are found, plus many other short, axiomatic statements that are parabolic in nature."

treat here. Nevertheless, the fact that Jesus made such extensive use of stories and parables should cause one to seriously consider oral means of communication in present day contexts. Jesus' use of parables was so pervasive that Mark 4:34 reports, "He did not speak to them without a parable." More than one-third of Jesus' recorded sayings are parables.[77] Further, N. T. Wright observes:

> Telling stories was (according to the synoptic gospels) one of Jesus' most characteristic modes of teaching. And…it would clearly be quite wrong to see these stories as mere illustrations of truths that could in principle have been articulated in a purer, or abstract form. They were ways of breaking open the worldview of Jesus' hearers, so that it could be remolded into the worldview which he, Jesus, was commending.[78]

Jesus used parables extensively, but Luke also recounted an instance in which Jesus presents the sweeping story chronologically, beginning with Moses and the prophets to explain the gospel (Luke 24:13-35). Jesus brought to light through chronological Bible storying the promise of the Messiah, which runs throughout the Old Testament,[79] giving two despondent disciples an overarching glimpse of God's redemptive plan as they made their way to Emmaus, a seven-mile journey.[80]

Peter at the Temple

Jesus' method of evangelism was not lost on his disciples. Luke recorded the apostles testifying of Christ. Naturally, their presentations of the good news began with

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[77]Eugene E. Carpenter and Philip W. Comfort, *Holman Treasury of Key Bible Words: 200 Greek and 200 Hebrew Words Defined and Explained* (Nashville, TN: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 2000), 355.

[78]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

[79]Biblical Studies Press, *The NET Bible First Edition Notes* (Biblical Studies Press, 2006), Lk 24:27.

[80]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 317.

God's actions recorded in the Old Testament. The communication of the sweeping story of Scripture as a means to communicate the good news of Christ is recorded as early as Acts chapter three. After God healed the lame beggar at the gate of the temple called Beautiful through Peter, a crowd gathered. Peter addressed the throng:

> …and that He may send Jesus, the Christ appointed for you, whom heaven must receive until *the* period of restoration of all things about which God spoke by the mouth of His holy prophets from ancient time. Moses said, "'THE LORD GOD WILL RAISE UP FOR YOU A PROPHET LIKE ME FROM YOUR BRETHREN; TO HIM YOU SHALL GIVE HEED to everything He says to you. And it will be that every soul that does not heed that prophet shall be utterly destroyed from among the people."' And likewise, all the prophets who have spoken, from Samuel and *his* successors onward, also announced these days. It is you who are the sons of the prophets and of the covenant which God made with your fathers, saying to Abraham, "'AND IN YOUR SEED ALL THE FAMILIES OF THE EARTH SHALL BE BLESSED."' For you first, God raised up His Servant and sent Him to bless you by turning every one *of you* from your wicked ways" (Acts 3:17-26).

Peter quoted Moses (Deut. 18:15, 18–19) reminding his listeners that Moses predicted the arrival of the Messiah.[81] Not to obey this Prophet meant condemnation in the minds of the audience. Moses, however, was not the only one who foretold the arrival of the Messiah. All the prophets were consistent and united in their witness to him.[82]

Peter directed his listeners to God's covenant with Abraham and his promise that the nations of the world would be blessed through his descendants (Gen. 12:1–3). This promise, asserted Peter, found its ultimate fulfillment in Jesus (Gal. 3:6–14).[83] Peter

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[81]See Luke 24:19; John 1:19–28; 6:14.

[82]Warren W. Wiersbe, *The Bible Exposition Commentary* (Wheaton, IL: Victor Books, 1996), Ac 3:17; See Luke 24:25–27, 44–48.

[83]Wiersbe, *The Bible Exposition Commentary*, Ac 3:17.

connects Christ to Abraham, Moses, and the prophets, placing the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus in its rightful, historical place in God's redemptive history.[84]

Stephen's Defense

In his defense before the Sanhedrin, Stephen presented an overview of the divine drama, mentioning eleven Old Testament characters. Further, he refers to two key symbols—tabernacle and temple—to identify Jesus as the coming Messiah to whom the Old Testament points.[85] Stephen, filled with the Holy Spirit, produced his chronological conveyance of the sweeping story from memory. As Matthew Henry mentions, "Those that are full of the Holy Ghost will be full of the Scripture, as Stephen was."[86] Although his hearers knew the story well, Stephen had something new to show them. Knowles explains:

> He reminds the Council of four heroes of faith: Abraham who never owned any land; Joseph who was exiled in Egypt; Moses who wandered the wilderness; and David who planned the temple. Gradually, Stephen's point becomes clear. God isn't restricted to any place or building. He is a pilgrim God who lives with his people — wherever they are. The temple is a meeting place for God and human beings. But now it is replaced by Jesus the Messiah. But the Jewish leaders have killed him! They claim to uphold the law, but they break it. They claim to serve God, but they persecute his prophets.[87]

Stephen's message evoked passionate response (disbelief and fury). Luke reports the Sanhedrin rushed at him and dragged him out of the city to stone him (Acts 7:57–58).

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[84]Luke used the plural "while *they* were speaking" (Acts 4:1), indicating that John was not silent, but also bearing witness to Christ. See John B. Polhill, vol. 26, *Acts*, The New American Commentary (Nashville: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 1995), 138-39.

[85]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 317.

[86]Henry, *Matthew Henry's Commentary on the Whole Bible*, Ac 7:1–16.

[87]Andrew Knowles, *The Bible Guide*, 1st Augsburg books ed. (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 2001), 543-44.

Paul's Discourse and Letters

In Acts 13 the synagogue rulers must have recognized the distinguished and learned character of their guest, and, for this reason, invited Paul to speak. Some have speculated that Paul may have worn his official pharisaical robes to the service. This would have immediately bolstered his status as someone who could contribute to the proceedings of the service.[88] Luke records Paul's discourse in detail revealing the manner in which Paul presented the gospel in synagogues.[89] Paul—like Jesus on the road to Emmaus, Peter at the temple, and Stephen before the Sanhedrin—lays the foundation of the sweeping story of redemption before expounding upon the coming of the Savior, Jesus.

Paul's narrative structure of doctrine did not give way to rarified abstractions in his letters. Though more compact, the components are essentially story-form theology. N. T. Wright explains:

> But what of Paul? Surely he forswore the story-form, and discussed God, Jesus, the Spirit, Israel and the world in much more abstract terms? Was he not thereby leaving behind the world of the Jewish story-theology, and going off on his own into the rarefied territory of abstract Hellenistic speculation? The answer is an emphatic no. As has recently been shown in relation to some key areas of Paul's writing, the apostle's most emphatically 'theological' statements and arguments are in fact expressions of *the essentially Jewish story now redrawn around Jesus*.[90]

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[88]Kenneth O. Gangel, vol. 5, *Acts*, Holman New Testament Commentary (Nashville, TN: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 1998), 214.

[89]Richard C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of the Acts of the Apostles 1-14* (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress, 2008) 513.

[90]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 79.

Akio Ito contends the New Testament letters, in regards to genre, ought to be situated somewhere between oral and literate in terms of content and cognition. In general, the letters comprise a synthesis of that which had been delivered orally through preaching and teaching conjoined with Greek literary rhetoric.[91]

New Testament letters directly relate orally preserved content known as *agraphe*, which are recorded statements of Jesus not found in the written Gospels. Paul encourages the Ephesians in Acts 20:35 to "remember the words of the Lord Jesus, how he himself said, 'It is more blessed to give than to receive.'" 1 Corinthians 7:10 contains a reference to a saying of Jesus regarding marriage. Further, in 9:14 he writes, "In the same way, the Lord commanded that those who proclaim the gospel should get their living by the gospel." Paul's instructions on taking the Lord's Supper found in 1 Corinthians 11 likely came from oral tradition as well because of the early date of the letter, around 54-55, before Mark's Gospel was written.[92]

Church Fathers through the Middle Ages

The Gospel narratives held an important place in the gatherings of early Christians. According to Eusebius, the recitation of the Gospels was the predominant form of preaching in early Christianity. He reports:

> And so greatly did the splendor of piety illumine the minds of Peter's hearers that they were not satisfied with hearing once only, and were not content with the unwritten teaching of the divine Gospel, but with all sorts of entreaties they

[91]Akio Ito, "The Written Torah and the Oral Gospel: Romans 10:5-13 in the Dynamic Tension between Orality and Literacy." *Novum Testamentum* XLVIII, no. 3 (2006), 245-46. Ito points to he progression for confessing one's faith found in Romans 10 as one example.

[92]David E. Garland, *1 Corinthians* (Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 2003), 20.

> besought Mark, a follower of Peter, and the one whose Gospel is extant, that he would leave them a written monument of the doctrine which had been orally communicated to them. Nor did they cease until they had prevailed with the man, and had thus become the occasion of the written Gospel which bears the name of Mark.[93]

Clement quotes the story, and Papias, the bishop of Hierapolis, confirms him. Whether the story is altogether accurate is not nearly as important as the fact that Eusebius, Clement, and Papias found the story believable and within the norm of early Christian corporate gatherings.[94]

Origen details the use of the stories of Jesus by early Christians. In his treatise, *Against Celsus*, he reports the early church used these stories in healings and exorcisms:

> [I]t is not by incantations that Christians seem to prevail (over evil spirits), but by the name of Jesus, accompanied by the announcement of the narratives which relate to Him; for the repetition of these has frequently been the means of driving demons out of men, especially when those who repeated them did so in a sound and genuinely believing spirit.[95]

Prominent church leaders during the first four centuries of Christianity taught new Christians in preparation for baptism, some taking up to three years to do so.[96] Origen (185–254) prepared many believers for baptism, several of whom, according to Eusebius,

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[93]Eusebius of Caesaria, "The Church History of Eusebius," trans. Arthur Cushman McGiffert in *A Select Library of the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, Second Series, Volume I: Eusebius: Church History, Life of Constantine the Great, and Oration in Praise of Constantine,* ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1890), 116.

[94]Boomershine, "A History of Biblical Narration," 4.

[95]Origen, "Origen Against Celsus," trans. Frederick Crombie in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers, Volume IV: Fathers of the Third Century: Tertullian, Part Fourth; Minucius Felix; Commodian; Origen, Parts First and Second*, ed. Alexander Roberts, James Donaldson and A. Cleveland Coxe (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Company, 1885), 398.

[96]Clinton E. Arnold, "Early Church Catechesis and New Christians' Classes in Contemporary Evangelism." *JETS* 47, no. 1 (March 2004): 45.

were martyred. Among others, Eusebius mentions Serenus: "[T]he second martyr among the pupils of Origen was Serenus, who gave through fire a proof of the faith which he had received."[97] The fact that Eusebius dedicated a chapter to the martyrs that learned under Origen is testimony to the number of new believers he taught.[98]

In his discipleship methodology Origen placed importance on the oral communication of the sweeping story of the Scriptures. During daily services he read aloud large portions of Scripture. Further, he contended those who desired to follow Christ must become familiar with the unfolding historical drama of Scripture immediately.[99]

Augustine (354-430) also emphasized an apprehension of the unfolding narrative of Scripture. Augustine was the director of a catechumenate in Hippo, North Africa. In fact, he wrote so extensively concerning the catechumenate that William Harmless dedicated a 400-page monograph to this aspect of Augustine's ministry.[100]

Augustine made use of a comprehensive catechism so that all uninstructed believers would gain a thorough understanding of the comprehensive sweep of Scripture; this he referred to as "Salvation History."[101] He contended that since the coming of Christ occurred on a timeline in history, the overarching narrative must be taught to new believers so that they may fully appreciate the gospel. Augustine states:

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[97]Eusebius, "The Church History of Eusebius," 252.

[98]Arnold, "Early Church Catechesis," 45.

[99]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 317

[100]William Harmless, *Augustine and Catechumenate* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1995).

[101]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 317.

> The narration is full when each person is catechised in the first instance from what is written in the text, "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth," on to the present times of the Church. This does not imply, however, either that we ought to repeat by memory the entire Pentateuch, and the entire Books of Judges, and Kings, and Esdras, and the entire Gospel and Acts of the Apostles, if we have learned all these word for word; or that we should put all the matters which are contained in these volumes into our own words, and in that manner unfold and expound them as a whole. For neither does the time admit of that, nor does any necessity demand it. But what we ought to do is, to give a comprehensive statement of all things, summarily and generally, so that certain of the more wonderful facts may be selected which are listened to with superior gratification, and which have been ranked so remarkably among the exact turning-points (of the history); that, instead of exhibiting them to view only in their wrappings, if we may so speak, and then instantly snatching them from our sight, we ought to dwell on them for a certain space, and thus, as it were, unfold them and open them out to vision, and present them to the minds of the hearers as things to be examined and admired. But as for all other details, these should be passed over rapidly, and thus far introduced and woven into the narrative. The effect of pursuing this plan is, that the particular facts which we wish to see specially commended to attention obtain greater prominence in consequence of the others being made to yield to them; while, at the same time, neither does the learner, whose interest we are anxious to stimulate by our statement, come to these subjects with a mind already exhausted, nor is confusion induced upon the memory of the person whom we ought to be instructing by our teaching.[102]

Columba (521-597) and his monks are well known for their literate abilities and development of remarkable Christian books.[103] The Celtic monastic mission, however, exhibited a clear commitment to engaging the oral contexts of their hosts. In particular, the Iona community and their mission to the Picts revealed an early, contextualized

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[102]Augustine of Hippo, "On the Catechising of the Uninstructed," trans. S. D. F. Salmond in *A Select Library of the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, First Series, Volume III: St. Augustin: On the Holy Trinity, Doctrinal Treatises, Moral Treatises*, ed. Philip Schaff (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Company, 1887), 285.

[103]For example, the Book of Kells, the Book of Durrow, and the Lindisfarne Gospels. The Book of Kells in its entirety is now viewable in the Trinity College Dublin's Library Digital Collections online repository, provided by the Library's Digital Resources and Imaging Services. See http://digitalcollections.tcd.ie/home/.

approach to crossing the orality barrier with the gospel.[104] Still extant in Iona is St. Martin's cross, a large stone sculpture formed between 750 and 800. Edward Smither describes it in this way:

> At the center of the cross, the birth of Christ is depicted with Mary holding the baby Jesus. Continuing down the cross, the stories of Daniel in the lions' den, Abraham raising his sword to sacrifice Isaac, David fighting Goliath, and David playing his harp are also communicated. The latter image seems especially contextual as David is joined by another musician playing triple pipes. In short, in viewing St. Martin's cross, Pictish visitors to Iona could contemplate the meaning of the cross and also engage in a visual Bible study.[105]

Caedmon (d. *c*.680), an illiterate cow herder at the monastery at Whitby, received in a vision the gift of composing verses in the praise of God and as a result became a monk.[106] Upon taking up monastic life he continued composing songs. His songs were narrative in nature, and he was interested in making them accessible to the illiterate population.[107] Steffen comments:

> To help illiterates better understand the sacred Story, Caedmon translated his works into Latin Vulgate. Some of the topics his poems addressed included: the creation of the world, the origin of man, history of Genesis, fall of angels, Exodus, Daniel, the incarnation, the passion and resurrection, ascension, the coming of the Holy Spirit, the preaching of the Apostles, heaven and hell.[108]

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[104]Edward Smither, "A Celtic Approach to Reaching Oral Learners: A Survey of the Oral and Visual Strategies Used by the Iona Community ca. 600-800," *Global Missiology* 1, no. 12 (September 2014).

[105]Smither, "A Celtic Approach to Reaching Oral Learners."

[106]F. L. Cross and Elizabeth A. Livingstone, *The Oxford Dictionary of the Christian Church*, 3rd ed. rev. (Oxford, New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 262. Caedmon was the first Anglo-Saxon producer of popular religious poetry. Though many works are attributed to him, their veracity is doubtful. Probably Caedmon's singular extant work is a hymn, which he is said to have composed in a dream. It appears in an 8th century hand as an addition to the Moore manuscript of Bede.

[107]The principle source of Caedmon's life is contained within Bede, *Historia Ecclesiastica* (Londini: Sumptibus Societatis, M.DCCC.XXX.VIII).

[108]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 318.

What is striking about these prominent figures in Christian history is their emphasis on concrete, narrative type teaching as opposed to abstract, systematic theological frameworks.

One final instance of oral type dissemination of information was the popular Medieval Cycle Play. These dramatizations of Bible stories began to be widely practiced in the 5th century, portraying scriptural stories from creation to consummation for the purpose of teaching the large number of illiterate parishioners the narratives of the Bible.[109] One of these plays entitled "Harrowing of Hell" depicted the defeat of the powers of evil when Christ descended into hell after his death (cf. 1 Peter 3:19), which was a particularly popular theme of art and drama in the Middle Ages.[110]

The Reformation Period

The Reformation movement owes a great debt to Johannes Gütenberg's contribution to Europe through his manufacturing and popularizing of the movable type printing press.[111] R. W. Scribner states, "Since the sixteenth century, it has been a

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[109]Steffen and Terry report, "One such play was held in June during the days of longest light. To give punctuation to the Creation story they started at 4:30 a.m. when the first light penetrated the darkness, and ended in twilight with the story of the judgment of God…By the late 16th century, many of the mystery plays were suppressed by the Protestant Reformation to curtail any Catholic doctrine. At the Council of Trent (1545-1563), the Catholic Church called for the abandonment of religious plays due to their secular and anti-Catholic nature." See Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 319.

[110]Cross, *The Oxford Dictionary of the Christian Church*, 742.

[111]The first known movable type printing technology was invented in China by the Han Chinese printer Bi Sheng between 1041 and 1048. In Korea, movable metal type printing was invented in the early thirteenth century during the Goryeo Dynasty. Though the Gutenberg Bible was certainly the first mass-produced printed work, it was not the

historical commonplace that [the Reformation] was largely a result of the impact of printing."[112] The views of Luther and others were made accessible to the masses as soon as they were written, resulting in a new and determined public opinion.[113]

To focus exclusively on the printed word, however, directs attention too narrowly to the small, elite literate group. This view ignores the vast quantity of illiterate and semi-literate people, a segment of the population that has been estimated at 90 percent.[114] The great majority of people in the late Medieval period were functionally illiterate.[115] It is an undeniable fact that the Reformation emerged in a milieu heavily steeped in and dependent upon oral dissemination of information. Because the Reformation yielded a religion of literate Bible-reading laymen, one can too quickly surmise that the religious revival took root principally by literate means.[116] It is an error, however, to identify the Reformation too closely with textuality. Engelsing estimates the literacy levels during the Reformation period were between 10 and 30 percent in urban areas, but nationally they

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first printed book. See Robert Lechêne, "Printing," in *Encyclopædia Britannica*, http://www.britannica.com (accessed 04 Oct 2014).

[112]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 49.

[113]Ibid.

[114]Ibid.

[115]James Atwood Freeman, "Orality Versus Textuality in the Reformation: The Origin and Influence of Textuality on Theological Perpectives in the Sixteenth Century" (Ph.D. diss. Rice University, 1990), 1.

[116]R. W. Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994), 2.

did not surpass 5 percent.[117] Moreover, access to the printed word was likely restricted to an expanding but small educational elite.[118]

Concentration on the printed word alone, thus, offers only a limited view of the process by which the new movement spread across Europe. Rather, one must see print in relation to the orality framework that prevailed in that context.[119] In order to comprehend the diffusion of Reformation ideas, one must set the printed word in the context of the entire scope of information media available to and used by the people of that period. Apart from printed text were visual forms of communication such as woodcuts, participational forms such us festivals, and above all, oral forms such as the sermon, ballad and hymn, and mouth-to-ear transmission.[120]

Printing was only one of the modes through which the Reformation was transmitted. Indeed, when literacy rates for the late Medieval period are considered, one can convincingly argue that it may not have been the primary mode. A pamphlet from 1524 lucidly exemplifies the process of information dissemination during the Reformation. The pamphlet is entitled *A Dialogue Between a Christian and a Jew . . . concerning Christ the Cornerstone*:

> A Jew and evangelical Christian fall into conversation in an inn, and the Jew produces a woodcut he has picked up on his travels. The Christian uses the woodcut to explain to the Jew the main points of evangelical belief as the woodcut depicts them. When they part, the inn servant, who has listened to them

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[117]See R. Engelsing, *Analphebetentum und Lekture*. Zur Sozialgeschichte des Lesens en Deutschland Zwischen Feudaler und Industrieller Gesellschaft (Stuttgart, 1973), 6-38.

[118]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk,* 2.

[119]Ibid., 3.

[120]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 50.

> with interest, promises to set their conversation down in print, along with the woodcut. The case shows the ideal balance of oral, visual, and printed means of communication as it is found during the reformation.[121]

The sixteenth century, though dominated by the advance of the Protestant Reformation, was distinguished by the Catholic Reformation as well. Francis Xavier (1506-1552) was a charter member of the Jesuit order founded by Ignatius Loyola. Stephen Neill argues that the formation of this order "is perhaps the most important event in the missionary history of the Roman Catholic Church."[122] The Jesuits were famous for religious zeal, preaching, and their care for the sick. Catholic princes from across the continent sought Jesuits to labor among their people. Eventually, Jesuits were requested to go to the orient. Mark Galli recounted the circumstances surrounding the beginning of Xavier's missionary career in in the East:

> When Portugal's King John III asked for six Jesuits for colonies in the Orient, founder Ignatius Loyola replied that he could only send two. At the last minute, however, one fell ill. His replacement, Francis Xavier, was given time only to mend his cassock before shipping out. Such was the beginning of one of the most wide-ranging and successful of missionary endeavors.[123]

On August 15, 1549, after nine years in India and Malacca (Malaysia), Xavier began work in Japan and witnessed rapid movement of Japanese people to Christianity.[124]

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[121]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 6.

[122]Stephen Neill, *A History of Christian Missions* (New York: Penguin, 1964), 148.

[123]Mark Galli and Ted Olsen, *131 Christians Everyone Should Know* (Nashville, TN: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 2000), 236.

[124]Richard Drummond reports that after "a short period of hesitancy, the numerical success of the missionary activity was remarkable. By 1582 the total number of Christians in Kyushu was about 130,000 and roughly 20,000 in the area in and about Kyoto. The highest relatively reliable figure for the number of Christians in Japan during this century of Roman Catholic activity is 300,000 in the year 1614. The missionary Fernao Guerreiro in his report of 1605 claimed a total of 750,000 for this date, and later

He taught new believers the Apostles' Creed, the Lord's Prayer, and the Ten Commandments. Notably, Xavier and the Jesuits taught an exposition of Christian doctrine in chronological order from the creation story through consummation. Richard Drummond explains, "[The catechetical teaching] was an exposition of Christian doctrine in essentially historical order from the fact of the triune God and divine creation of the world, the fall of Lucifer, and the sin of Adam."[125]

In the New World, a Dominican named Bartolomé de las Casas (1474-1576) not only evangelized the indigenous peoples, established new churches, and ministered to the conquerors, but he also used his education and influence to defend new Christians from exploitation and oppression.[126] Further, the Dominicans were more concerned with depth of discipleship than mass conversions. Mario Rodriguez León reports, "They were more interested in quality than quantity and sought to give those converted a grounding in the new faith."[127] Notably, the methods of the first community were centered around four pillars: "understanding of Indian language and religion, doctrinal teaching in the form of stories rather than theological abstractions, frequent preaching from the Scriptures, and the witness of the missionary's own poverty and life of prayer."[128]

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writers have set even higher figures, all in a population of about twenty million." See Richard Drummond "Missiological Lessons – Events New and Old," *Missiology: An International Review* 22, no. 1 (January 1994), 20.

[125]Drummond, "Missiological Lessons – From Events New and Old," 23.

[126]Escobar, *The New Global Mission*, 48.

[127]Mario A. Rodriguez León, "Invasion and Evangelization in the Sixteenth Century," in *The Church in Latin America 1492-1992*, Enrique Dussel, ed. (Burnes &Oates, Orbis, 1992), 44-45.

[128]León, "Invasion and Evangelization in the Sixteenth Century," 44-45.

The influx of Roman Catholic missions during the sixteenth-century Catholic Counter-Reformation was not a response to Protestant missions, nor was it met with a Protestant mission rejoinder.[129] Ralph Winter laments, "Despite the fact that the Protestants won on the political front, and to a great extent gained the power to formulate anew their own Christian tradition and certainly thought they took the Bible seriously, they did not even talk of mission outreach."[130] Some anomalies, however, prevailed.

Nikolaus von Zinzendorf (1700-1760), leader of the Moravian church, "launched a worldwide missionary movement that set the stage for William Carey and the 'Great Century' of missions that would follow."[131] Zinzendorf's initial movement toward direct involvement in foreign missions came about in 1730 when he met a converted slave from the West Indies named Anthony Ulrich, who pleaded for someone to take the gospel to his homeland.

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[129]Some argue that the Protestants were consumed with fending off Catholic backlash, had precious little access to seafaring routes and vessels, and lacked the ready-made missionary force that the Catholic Church had. See Ruth A. Tucker, *From Jerusalem to Irian Jaya: A Biographical History of Christian Missions*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2003), 97.

[130]Ralph D. Winter, "The Empire Strikes Back: Ten Epochs of Redemptive History," in *Perspectives on the World Christian Movement*, 3rd ed., Ralph D. Winter and Stephen C. Hawthorne, eds. (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1999), 210. Winter reports, "But why did the Protestants not even try to reach out?…Some scholars point to the fact that the Protestants did not have a global network of colonial outreach. Well, the Dutch Protestants did. And, their ships, unlike those from Catholic countries, carried no missionaries. This is why the Japanese—once they began to fear the Christian movement Catholic missionaries planted—would allow only Dutch ships into their ports. Indeed, the Dutch even cheered and assisted the Japanese in the slaughter of the budding Christian (Catholic) community" (210).

[131]Tucker, *From Jerusalem to Irian Jaya*, 100.

Zinzendorf placed the challenge before the believers at *Herrnhut*. The response was immediate and enthusiastic.[132] Within a year two Moravian men, Leonard Dober and Tobias Leupold, were commissioned and sent to the Virgin Islands. They were the first Protestant missionaries of the modern era. William Carey would not sail to India for another sixty years.[133] Herbert Kane reports the missionaries were men of passion and piety, and "what they lacked in knowledge they made up for in zeal."[134] They served the slaves who worked in the cane fields by meeting their various physical needs, and they met the spiritual needs of the slaves by telling them Bible stories.[135]

It appears that Zinzendorf himself sensed the consequence of the way in which the gospel was structured and delivered to these oral peoples. He argued that the missionaries ought not "be blinded by reason as if people had to, in order, first learn to believe in God, after that Jesus. It is wrong because that God exists is obvious to them. They must be instructed of the Son; there is salvation in no other . . . you must go straight to the point and tell them about the life and death of Christ."[136]

A few decades before the birth of William Carey, David Brainerd (1718-1747) labored unto death among the Delaware Indians of New Jersey. He "longed that God

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[132]J. Herbert Kane, *A Concise History of the Christian World Mission* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1982), 79.

[133]Charles H. Robinson reports, "Within twenty years of the commencement of their missionary work the Moravian Brethren started more missions than Anglicans and Protestants had started during the two preceding centuries." See Charles H. Robinson, *History of Christian Missions* (New York: Scribners, 1915), 50.

[134]Kane, *A Concise History of the Christian World Mission*, 80.

[135]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 320.

[136]Christian History Institute, *Christian History* 1, no. 1, (Worcester, PA: Church History Institute, 1949), 26.

should take hold of their hearts, and make them spiritually alive." But, he believed that they must hear and understand the message for that to happen. Thus, Brainerd "studied what was most plain and easy, and best suited to their capacities."[137] By "capacities" Brainerd signaled the presence of the oral framework in which the Delaware received, processed, imaged, and disseminated information. After learning their language and beginning translation work, Brainerd initiated the process of teaching the Delaware using oral media. In his journal, he states:

> When my people had gained some acquaintance with many of the simplest truths of Christianity, so that they were capable of receiving and understanding others, I gave them an historical account of God's dealings with his ancient professing people…Afterward I proceeded to give them a relation of the birth, life, miracles, sufferings, death, and resurrection of Christ.[138]

Modern Missions Era

When William Carey (1761-1834) acted upon his conviction that the Lord's command to take the gospel to all nations applied to all believers, he sparked what would become the great century of mission expansion. This explosion of Great Commission endeavor led many cross-cultural laborers into oral contexts. Some responded with humility and love by adjusting their communication preferences to transmit the gospel.

Johannes Gustav Warneck (1867-1944) labored among the peoples of Sumatra, Nias, Borneo, and New Guinea in the 1890s. Warneck argued that the best way to communicate the gospel message is by proclaiming the deeds of God, not by delivering

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[137]Jonathan Edwards, *Life & Diary of David Brainerd* (Lafayette, IN: Sovereign Grace Publishers, Inc., 2001), 31.

[138]Edwards, *Life & Diary of David Brainerd*, 31.

intellectual lectures on his existence and character. In his volume, *The Living Christ and Dying Heathenism*, he reasons:

> What kind of preaching must the missionary employ to set God's might and majesty before the dulled eyes of the heathen? It will not be done by intellectual instruction; the missionary will get no audience for learned lectures about God. Life is not begotten by enlightenment; it passes from person to person, from God to man, by living contact. The sole function of preaching is to mediate a personal acquaintance with God. That is done by depicting the deeds of the living God before the eyes of the heathen. Persons are made known by their acts. Mission preaching proclaims the deeds of God; it explains nothing at first, expounds nothing; it simply narrates what God has done.[139]

Warneck argued that proper missionary preaching consists of telling the Bible stories that speak most directly to the specific needs of the people. He was convinced that communicating God's deeds of "power and love" through a sweep of selected stories would make a great impression on the hearts of animists.[140]

John Nevius (1829-1893), missionary to China and Korea, was a pioneer in indigenous church planting principles. His "Nevius Plan" helped shaped modern mission thought and methodology.[141] He made extensive use of a narrative approach to discipleship. Nevius states:

> We have the Scripture story exercise. Someone previously appointed tells the story; the leader of the meeting then calls on different persons one after another to reproduce it in consecutive parts, and afterward all present take part in drawing practical lessons and duties from it. There is never time for more than one story, and often that one has to be divided and has two Sundays given to it.[142]

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[139]Johannes Warneck, *The Living Christ and Dying Heathenism*. (New York: Fleming H. Revell Co., 1954), 224.

[140]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 321-322.

[141]See Everett N. Hunt, Jr., "The Legacy of John Livingston Nevius," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* (July 1991): 120-124.

[142]John Livingston Nevius, *The Planting and Development of Missionary Churches* (Hancock, NH: Monadnock Press, 2003), 172-173.

Christian Keysser (1877-1961) labored among the Papuan in New Guinea between 1900-1920 and made considerable contributions to an understanding of group conversion. He saw the value in converts having a grip on the sweep of the sacred story, giving particular emphasis to the teaching of forty stories from the Bible. Candidates for baptism were required to know all of these stories by heart in order to ensure that the illiterate understood the meaning behind the ritual. Keysser believed this activity was extremely beneficial for baptismal candidates.[143] Georg F. Vicedom comments on the value of the stories that Keysser used:

> They tell men what God does for them in a quite definite situation, and what he requires of them. They explain more fully the relationship in which men stand to God. They make plain the response of God to the action of men. In this way they make it easier of the seeker after God to reach the decision which is required of him. Many of the people of the Bible became for the Papuans patterns of the way in which they themselves are expected to behave.[144]

In the early 1900s George and May Ingram began ministry among tribal peoples in North India. They saw little progress teaching the Apostle's Creed, the Ten Commandments, and the Lord's Prayer. Though they were unsure why, it was clear the indigenous peoples "found it difficult to profit from the common method of Christian teaching."[145] In response, they developed teaching material they called *Twelve Bible Stories* and began to give a narrative presentation of the Scriptures, "as our Lord

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[143]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 6.

[144]G. F. Vicedom, "An Example of Group Conversion," *Practical Anthropology* 9, no. 3 (May-June 1962): 123-128.

[145]George and Mary Ingram, *30 Bible Stories for Church Planters* (Madras, India: Revision Committee, 1997), 1.

taught."[146] After a short time, they began to see fruit as spiritual eyes were opened upon hearing the truths of Scripture in narrative form. The Ingrams continued to modify and hone the story set, eventually developing *24 Bible Stories,* which was published in 1920.[147]

Donald McGavran (1897-1990), father of the modern Church Growth movement, began ministry as a missionary in India. Facing the challenges of an oral culture, he came to the realization that contextualized Scripture stories were the most effective way to evangelize, and thus he began employing eight Bible stories to communicate the gospel. In *The Satnami Story*, McGavran explains:

> Eight Bible stories were generally used. The first was of the creation of the world and the fall of man. Then skipping the entire Old Testament we told about Christ's birth. The third story was Christ's curing the leper, His tremendous mercy. Then came the stilling of the storm, His tremendous power. Or that story might be changed to His healing people and casting out evil spirits and to heal the sick was emphasized…A fourth story was Christ's forgiving the woman taken in adultery. In Satnami village…adultery was common. Gonorrhea and syphilis were everywhere…A fifth story was that of Christ's teaching good conduct… Another story was that of the rich young ruler…Then came the story of the crucifixion…The last story was Christ's resurrection and His present rule throughout the world.[148]

Jacob Loewen (1922-2006), missionary to Panama in the 1950s, argued for the value of biblical narrative in the early witness in "face-to-face" societies. Loewen contended that biblical narrative was a form of communication "that can be handled rather early in the missionary's experience and which can also be of immediate use in the

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[146]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 323.

[147]George and Mary Ingram, *24 Bible Stories for Village Workers* (Burma: C. L. S., 1947); and, eventually, *30 Bible Stories for Church Planters* (Madras, India: Revision Committee, 1997).

[148]Donald A. McGavran, *The Satnami Story: The Thrilling Drama of Religious Change* (Pasadena, CA: William Careyt Library, 1990), 55-56.

witness of the new convert."[149] Further, he asserted that the biblical narrative was a "framework within which the individual truths of the message can be anchored contextually."[150]

Loewen and his co-workers went through a series of experiments and revisions of Bible story sets as they sought to discover the most effective means of communicating the gospel to the illiterate indigenous peoples in Panama, eventually settling upon a core list of twenty-six stories. The list began with the origin of Satan in order to distinguish the devil of Scriptures from the many evil spirits of whom the indigenous feared on a daily basis. The story set places primary emphasis on the life of Christ and includes only seven stories on the Old Testament.[151]

Loewen explains that four factors were considered as criteria in determining the inclusion or exclusion of Bible stories in the core set. First, each story should naturally give a kind of overview of the Biblical passage. In Loewen's words, it should give a "bird's eye view of the span of Biblical history."[152] Second, the stories, especially those dealing with origin, were chosen to qualify local mythological traditions in which both similarities and fundamental differences were exploited. The third criteria had to do with the matter of introducing core biblical concepts and truths. Finally, Loewen chose stories from the life of Christ with emphasis placed on death, burial, and resurrection.[153]

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[149]Jacob A. Loewen, *Culture and Human Values: Christian Intervention in Anthropological Perspective* (Pasadena, California: William Carey Library, 1975), 370.

[150]Loewen, *Culture and Human Values*, 370.

[151]Ibid., 371.

[152]Ibid.

[153]Ibid.

Hans-Ruedi Weber (1923-present), Dutch missionary and theologian, published *Communication of the Gospel to Illiterates* in 1957. Weber worked in Central Celebes, Indonesia. He arrived in 1950, and in 1952 was asked to find a way (with the help of existing manpower and without money) to disciple workers who for the most part had only three years of elementary education. Tasked with providing some 30,000 Christians the basics of the power of Scripture—even though they themselves had little if any grasp of the Scriptures—Weber began a five-day Bible course in the area.[154] He quickly perceived that if the people were to learn the Scriptures, "they must first be released from the obligation to learn through abstract ideas of western catechisms and doctrine."[155]

Weber asks, "How can the Biblical message be communicated to illiterates, and what lessons can be learnt from this missionary encounter with illiterates which have a bearing on Christian communications in general?"[156] Weber argues that missionaries should use teaching methods that emphasize concrete dimensions through group interaction.[157] He recounted that many Christians from the people group could not attend the Bible course because they were illiterate. Weber explains:

> We spoke the same language as the illiterates, yet we did not understand each other. Our methods of thought and communication were entirely different. When we asked the meaning of a word unknown to us, the illiterate would not give a synonym, or a more or less abstract transcription, but he would "paint" in words, quickly and unfailingly, a picture that illustrated the exact meaning. In describing

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[154]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 324.

[155]Weber, Hans-Ruedi. *The Communication of the Gospel to Illiterates: Based on a Missionary Experience in Indonesia* (London, SCM Press, 1957), 19.

[156]Weber, *The Communication of the Gospel to Illiterates*, 9.

[157]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 324.

> a person the illiterate would not talk about his character but rather tell significant stories about them.[158]

Weber adjusted his pedagogy to employ means of communication that would speak to the oral learner. In addition to teaching the Bible narratively and chronologically, Weber utilized simple chalk drawings to illustrate the story. He also used dramatic portrayals of the stories. Weber believed that the spoken word needed to be made concrete with symbols, pictures, or drama to prevent syncretization with local mythologies.[159] He later argues:

> It is fundamentally wrong to treat illiterates as children and merely to tell them Bible stories. They are much better equipped than many Western intellectuals to see the whole: the complete redemptive history – creation and eschatology, Christ the centre of redemption, and linked with this centre the history of Israel and of the mission…Every Bible story that is told must be set within the framework of the whole history of redemption. Every Biblical figure must be shown as having a part in the great drama of salvation.[160]

Father Vincent J. Donovan (1926-2000) began laboring among the Masai in 1955. Due to a number of factors, Donovan saw very little progress in his mission's work. In 1966 he confessed to his superiors, "The best way to describe realistically the state of this Christian mission is the number zero. As of this month, in the seventh year of this mission's existence, there are no adult Masai practicing Christians from Loiondo mission."[161] He continues:

> As I began to ponder the evangelization of the Masai, I had to realize that God enables a people, any people, to reach salvation through their culture and tribal,

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[158]Weber, *The Communication of the Gospel to Illiterates*, 19.

[159]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 324.

[160]Hans-Ruedi Weber, *Power: Focus for Biblical Theology* (Geneva: WCC Publications, 1981), 44.

[161]Vincent J. Donovan, *Christianity Rediscovered* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1983), 15.

> racial customs and traditions. In this realization would have to rest my whole approach to the evangelization of the Masai.[162]

Donovan concluded that a foundation for the gospel must be given to the Masai before an accurate explanation of the gospel could be realized. By using an indirect method of teaching Bible stories (he rarely commented on the stories), he began telling contextualized stories from the Old and New Testaments, focusing on helping the Masai along in discovering the truth for themselves as they encountered the sacred narratives of Scripture.[163] For Donovan, the gospel was "not a philosophy or set of doctrines or laws. That is what culture is. The gospel is essentially a history at whose center is the God-man born in Bethlehem, risen near Golgotha"[164]

Trevor McIlwain

The Palaweños of southern Palawan, Philippines awaited the arrival of a messenger carrying a black book. Their tradition told them this person would bring God's message, and with this message would come hope. The Palaweños had suffered for many years. A fierce Muslim group living on the smaller islands off the coast of Palawan oppressed the more timid, fearful Palaweños. Palaweño folklore is filled with stories of

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[162]Donovan, *Christianity Rediscovered*, 30.

[163]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 7.

[164]Donovan, *Christianity Rediscovered*, 31. Terry and Steffen report, "Today, little if any of Christianity exists among this group of people. One of the major reasons for this may be Donovan's separation of evangelism from follow-up. With no follow-up, what had taken root soon withered and sadly was blown away by the wind." See Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 328.

massacre and persecution at the hands of these marauding sea warriors known as Moros.[165]

This people also suffered due to Filipino settlers migrating to Palaweño land to exploit natural resources upon which the indigenous peoples depended. The migrants sought farming land and timber and found the Palaweños easily intimidated and coerced. Many lost their ancestral lands and moved to the less desirable foothills and mountains of the island.[166]

Even greater suffering befell the Palaweños during World War II when the Japanese invaded the Philippines and occupied Palaweño territory. Japanese soldiers raped women, murdered children, and destroyed livestock and rice crops. This suffering was far greater than any other they had endured. U.S. liberation forces landed in Palawan in 1944, bringing freedom and ending suffering at the hands of the Japanese.[167] U.S. forces engendered such good will that the Palaweños were ready and willing to accept whatever Americans might offer them for years to come. It was into this context that the first Christian missionaries arrived to share the gospel with the Palaweños. And, it is not surprising that they were met with enthusiastic acceptance of Christianity and submission to baptism.[168]

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[165]Trevor McIlwain. *Building on Firm Foundations*. (Sanford, FL: New Tribes Mission, 2001.), 11.

[166]McIlwain, *Building on Firm Foundations*, 12.

[167]Ibid.

[168]Edward A. Buchanan, "Chronological Bible Teaching—A Means to Teach the Truth," (A Paper Presented at Evangelical Theological Society), 7.

When Sigfried Sandstrom of New Tribes Mission (NTM) arrived in Palawan in 1955, he fit the prophecy, and he was an American.[169] Sandstrom saw rapid exterior response to Christianity. Trevor McIlwain comments on their readiness:

> When we arrived [in Palawan] years later, we questioned the Palawanos as to why they had so readily submitted to baptism. One man answered, "We would have done anything for that first missionary. If he had asked us to cut our fingers off, we would have gladly done it for him."[170]

During his short ministry Sandstrom used English, broken Tagalog, and a smattering of Palaweño to present the gospel message. The Palaweño people, anxious to please and express gratitude, responded enthusiastically. Steffen reports, "Sandstrom asked them to believe in Christ; to be baptized; to attend church; and to stop smoking, drinking, and chewing betel nut."[171] The Palaweños responded willingly, being baptized by the hundreds, and carrying the message to other Palaweños in remote areas. By all accounts, a people movement had begun. After a year of ministry, however, the Sandstroms left due to family illness.[172]

Despite apparent progress, the Palaweños had believed a form of Christianity that was inconsistent with the biblical gospel, believing instead salvation depended upon works. More missionaries followed the Sandstroms, but the Palaweños persisted in their conviction that baptism, prayer, church attendance, and avoiding sinful activities would

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[169]Tom A. Steffen. *Passing the Baton: Church Planting that Empowers*. (La Habra, CA: Center for Organization and Ministry Development, 1993), 133.

[170]McIlwain, *Building on Firm Foundations*, 12.

[171]Steffen, *Passing the Baton*, 134.

[172]McIlwain, *Building on Firm Foundations*, 14.

make them acceptable before God.[173] It was into this context Trevor McIlwain and his family arrived in southern Palawan in 1965. McIlwain's primary mission was to mature the leaders of the Palaweño churches. He recounts:

> Extensive hiking over the trails with the more zealous church elders was the only way I could reach and teach the more than forty small churches scattered among the mountains and jungle. Through these visits to the Palawano churches, it soon became evident that the majority of the professing believers were confused and uncertain about the basic foundations of the Christian faith.[174]

McIlwain realized serious problems existed among the Palaweño Christians. Many had reverted to pre-Christian lifestyles, willfully practicing sin. Those who continued in their commitments to Christian activities manifested no joy.[175]

McIlwain discovered the Palaweños had believed a false gospel, and after several failed attempts at correcting their beliefs, he perceived they did not sufficiently understand their sinful condition, which led to an insufficient understanding of the gospel. He began to teach the Palaweños in a chronological manner, beginning with creation, and he emphasized the sovereignty of God, man's broken relationship due to sin, God's punishment of sin, and man's inability to save himself. Once the foundation of these essential truths was laid, McIlwain moved into the New Testament, proclaiming the coming of the Savior and the grace of God.[176]

In 1975 Bob Gustafson, NTM Field Director in the Philippines, spoke with McIlwain about his reasons for returning to Genesis to establish foundational biblical

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[173]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 7.

[174]McIlwain, *Building on Firm Foundations*, 14.

[175]Ibid., 13.

[176]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 7.

truths among Palaweños who professed to follow Christ but seemed to base their eternal salvation on works. McIlwain's answer fascinated Gustafson. He asked McIlwain to lead a discussion on his methodologies at the South East Asia Leadership Conference, which was already in session, hosted by the NTM Philippine field in Manila.[177] Syncretism was a key obstacle during this time in South East Asia (SEA). When Gustafson heard McIlwain's report, he realized that his methodologies could prove valuable and effective in a wider context, especially given that McIlwain, like many other SEA missionaries, was combating syncretism.[178]

In January 1981 McIlwain spoke to NTM personnel serving in the Philippines at the annual conference and spoke again later that year at the SEA Leadership Conference held in Thailand. He emphasized the importance of conveying the panoramic story of God beginning in the Old Testament in order to accurately communicate the comprehensive Christian message. He argued the gospel is best understood when it is delivered as a progressive, unfolding, panoramic story.[179] McIlwain's chronological Bible teaching (CBT) method spread among NTM personnel.

George and Harriet Walker began working among the monolingual Bisorios living in East Sepik province of Papua New Guinea in 1978. They attended McIlwain's seminar in Thailand and were convinced his methodology was the key to reaching the Bisorios. They began to teach the people five days a week using CBT. The number of

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[177]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 315.

[178]Tom A. Steffen, "Chronological Communication of the Gospel Goes from Country to City." (A Paper Presented at Evangelical Missiological Society, Southwest at Biola University, March 2011), 2.

[179]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 316.

listeners grew from forty to around 100. They taught for up to three hours a day for twenty-four weeks, using drama to improve comprehension of the Bible stories.[180]

In 1983 John and Shirley Birkin commenced work among the Tala-andig, an animistic, nomadic, monolingual tribal people residing in the mountains of Mindanao, Philippines. After learning the language and reducing it to writing, they developed CBT lessons for the Tala-andig. Steffen reports, "After years of building friendships, one person braved the onslaught of the spirits and listened to Bible stories from Genesis to the Ascension (Phase 1). His faith in Christ opened the door to the Tala-andig."[181]

Early in the spread of the gospel among the Tala-andig, illiterate believers used traditional songs and chants to transmit the Bible narratives that were eventually introduced into the fellowship meetings. Eventually, gifted believers became responsible to train others in the art of composing Bible songs and putting them to music.[182]

In 1984 Ron and Michelle Jennings labored among the Higaunon, an animistic, tribal people, in Mindanao, Philippines.[183] The Jennings comprehended the Higaunon tribal teachers needed accompanying illustrations of the CBT stories in order to effectively assimilate and promulgate the material. When a tribal man showed artistic ability, he was commissioned to copy the pictures brought from Australia on smaller paper for teaching use. Women in the church were taught to make copies and to color

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[180]See George Walker, *Evangelizing Cross-Cultural: The Bisorio Example* (Sanford, FL: New Tribes Mission, 1989).

[181]Steffen, "Chronological Communication," 4.

[182]Ibid.

[183]See "Manobo, Higuanon in Philippines," Joshua Project, http://joshuaproject.net/people_groups/12092/RP (Accessed 06 October 2014).

them with wax crayon.[184] These Bible stories and accompanying stories served as the physical presence of the Scriptures for the Higuanon for many years.[185]

In the 1980s Mark and Gloria Zook began laboring among the Mouk residing in West New Britain. They taught the Old Testament Bible stories chronologically for over two months before mentioning Christ. In December of 1986 Zook presented Christ to the 310 Mouk with whom they were sharing. Many turned to Christ, and the gospel spread to surrounding areas.[186]

In 1983 interest in McIlwain's CBT spread beyond NTM to the Southern Baptist missions entity—the Foreign Mission Board (presently International Mission Board). Jim Slack, Southern Baptist church growth consultant in the Philippines, had previously read Weber's *The Communication of the Gospel to Illiterates* with Cal Guy at Southwestern Baptist Theological Seminary and was intensely interested in McIlwain's methods among the Palaweños. Slack invited McIlwain to present his work to IMB personnel.[187]

In 1983 and 1984 McIlwain trained around 600 IMB missionaries and nationals in the Philippines. The IMB adopted the methodology, but they soon began to modify it. Many felt McIlwain's model was still too literate.[188] In 1992, under the leadership of Jim

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[184]Steffen, "Chronological Communication," 5.

[185]The Higaunon New Testament was completed by NTM and delivered in 2009. See "New Testaments Arrive in Village," New Tribes Missions, http://uk.ntm.org/ (accessed October 6, 2014).

[186]Steffen, "Chronological Communication," 5.

[187]Ibid.

[188]An early attempt at further "oralizing" CBT included a collaboration between NTM and IMB to produce 105 visual representations of key Bible stories. The IMB put up $100,000 for the project. A Filipino artist, Caloy Gabuco, was commissioned. The original artwork is stored in a fire-proof, climate controlled room at NTM headquarters in

Slack and J. O. Terry, the IMB shifted the methodology to be fully centered around the story.[189] Terry and Slack devised a standard pattern for missionaries to follow in storying settings. Grant Lovejoy explains the IMB philosophy:

> Chronological Bible Storying is a method of presentation that tells selected biblical stories in chronological order in the power of the Holy Spirit so as to bring people to genuine faith in Christ, mature discipleship, and fruitful Christian service. Ordinarily CBS includes a time of dialog after the story. In the dialog the storyteller uses questions to guide listeners to discover the meaning and significance of the biblical story. The formulation of this method has been relatively recent, but the basic elements of the method are ancient.[190]

Beginning in the early 1990s intense interest in storying as a methodology for teaching the Bible began to prevail in both mission agencies as well as Western ministry settings. In 1995 Bible storying courses were initiated at Southwestern Baptist Theological Seminary and Biola University. In the late 1990s orality networks came into existence and began to increase rapidly.[191] Scholars, missionaries, storytellers, and laymen have contributed to a glut of resources concentrating on aspects of telling Bible stories.

Telling Bible stories, however, does not equal orality. Narration, rather, is an application of orality theory. Charles Madinger explains, "[S]torytelling or 'storying' uses the principles of orality but is more precisely an application of its principles. Thus,

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Sanford, FL. Color copies, as well as black and white line drawings, are available through NTM. See Steffen, "Chronological Communication," 7.

[189]Terry, "Roots of CBS," 8.

[190]Lovejoy, "Chronological Bible Storying: Description, Rationale and Implications," 1.

[191]For example Bridges Global Training Network (1998), Scriptures in Use (1998), Oral Bible Network (2001), and International Orality Network (2005).

orality is not equivalent to storytelling."[192] While the focus on this aspect of orality is understandable (story, after all, is valued even in textual societies), it remains inadequate.

When one surveys training and publications related to the field, the paucity of treatment of orality beyond telling Bible stories becomes evident. While abundant information exists related to crafting Bible stories and tracks, developing personal Bible storying skills and starting Bible storying groups, material that addresses holistic engagement of oral cultures is lacking. Some missions organizations and seminaries have even incorporated Bible storying training into their curriculums. These are positive developments. They are not, however, sufficient. Indicators point to a heightened awareness of orality, but a narrow comprehension thereof remains.

Conclusion

Orality has been the prevailing cognitive framework throughout human history. Though textual thinkers, due to the popularization of the moveable type printing press, have gained slight ground, oral folk continue to comprise the majority of the world's population. The Old Testament is replete with manifestations of orality, especially narrative. Jesus himself may be best characterized as a storyteller. The early church through the modern missions period, from Augustine to the Moravians, is rife with accounts of the Christians adjusting their teaching in order to make it comprehensible to oral learners. The issue of orality in missions surfaced with renewed vigor in the early 1980s as Trevor McIlwain's chronological methodology spread from NTM to the IMB, eventually finding applications in sundry ministry contexts.

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[192]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 204.

Inauspiciously, the modern surge of interest in orality among evangelicals centered almost exclusively on the oral methodologies, especially Bible storying. Efficacious engagement of oral learners, however, reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

What distinctives, besides preference for narrative, set oral populations apart from textual populations? What deep structures within societies provide a context for narrative in evangelism, discipleship, and church formation? These questions are critical for those who originate from a textual context endeavoring to engage oral folk.

Chapter 3

The Orality Framework

The preceding chapter that traces the presence of orality throughout Judeo-Christian history is admittedly narrow, focusing nearly exclusively on the prevalence of narrative as evidence. Two reasons exist for this bias. First, an orality framework is not easily detected in hindsight due to the fleeting nature of oral language.[193] Much of the meager remnant is only that which can be preserved through memorized oral tradition, which is generally narrative in nature.[194] Second, renewed interest in orality among evangelicals has been dominated by attention to storytelling, which has governed the course of orality studies.[195] Narrative, however, is only a fragment of a robust and

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[193]Sound relates to time unlike that of the other fields that register human sensation. Sound can only exist when it is going out of existence. Ong states, "It is not simply perishable but essentially evanescent, and it is sensed as evanescent." It is impossible to halt sound and continue to have sound. One can freeze visual stimuli, but the same is not achievable in the realm of sound. If the movement of sound is stopped, what is left is nothingness. "All sensation takes place in time, but no other sensory field totally resists a holding action, stabilization, in quite this way." See Ong, *Orality, Literacy, and Modern Media*, 65.

[194]Many extant languages have yet to be reduced to writing. These oral-only languages are endangered due to evanescent nature of the spoken word. This reality has occasioned initiatives to preserve them, such as the Center for Endangered Languages Documentation (http://celd.uni-koeln.de/) based in Indonesia.

[195]Even Issue Group 25 summarizes the means by which to reach oral learners orality in terms of narrative, stating: "A large proportion of the world's populations are either unable to or unwilling to absorb information through written communications. Therefore, a need exists to share the 'Good News' and to disciple new Christians in story form and parables." See Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 129.

nuanced reality. By extracting the discipline of storying and rendering it equal to orality itself, one misses the proverbial forest for the tree.

Walter J. Ong, Albert Lord, Millman Parry, *et al* pioneered modern research in the field of orality. Regrettably, their innovative work did not set the trajectory for evangelical engagement with oral cultures. Evangelicals' attention to the reality that the technologies of reading and writing profoundly affect the cognition of textual societies has been parenthetical at best. Effective engagement of oral peoples requires a wide view of the complexity of orality and the intricacies of narrative in conversion, discipleship, and church formation processes. As Charles Madinger states, "We thus need a more comprehensive model for understanding orality."[196]

This chapter seeks to provide remedy to these deficiencies by exploring several foundational questions concerning orality. First, what is the nature of the oral framework in which narrative becomes effective? Further, how does narrative relate to the process of conversion and discipleship? Finally, what is the role of narrative in church formation?

Orality and Textuality

Origin of Writing

Discussions of orality often concentrate on the advent of literacy. After all, it is the restructuring of consciousness through the technologies of writing and reading that result in a transition from orality to textuality.[197] Though oral peoples ought not be

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[196]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 204.

[197]Douglas Fields comments, "For example, learning to read restructures the brain—we can see it with human brain imaging. Children with dyslexia have developmental differences in the brain pathways activated by the process of reading. Eventually most children with reading difficulties learn to cope, which means that in doing so they to some extent rewire their brain; but this can take years." See R. Douglas

characterized by a lack of reading and writing technologies, it is helpful to understand how and why these technologies develop within oral cultures.[198]

Humans are expressive, assigning meaning to symbols in order to evince feelings, ideas, and values. These forms of expression, or symbols, are means by which humans transmit information. For effective, consistent communication to take place societies have developed conventional systems of signs and symbols, which, when used according to common rules, convey information comprehensible by others within the society,[199] making it possible to create complex cultures.[200] Samuel Hayakawa comments, "There are few things that men do or want to do, possess or want to possess, that have not, in addition to their mechanical or biological value, a symbolic value."[201]

Emission and reception comprise the fundamental elements of information transmission. Models of human communication generally include four components: senders, receivers, messages, and media.[202] The means by which information is sent are

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Fields, "Genius across Cultures and the 'Google Brain,'" *Scientific American* guest blog. http://blogs.scientificamerican.com/guest-blog/2011/08/20/genius-across-cultures-and-the-google-brain/ (Accessed 15 November 2014).

[198]A danger exists, however, in making literacy central in this discussion. It easily becomes the primary indicator and characterization of oral learners. This is a grave misrepresentation and is generally unprofitable in the quest to fully apprehend the milieu of oral peoples. It is included here for the sake of the giving the reader a full-orbed understanding of the nature of orality.

[199]I. J. Gelb, *A Study of Writing* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1963), 1.

[200]Paul G. Hiebert, *Cultural Anthropology* (Philadelphia: J. B. Lippencott Company, 1976), 3.

[201]Samuel I. Hayakawa, "The Symbolic Process." *Consumer Behavior and the Behavioral Sciences*, Steuart H. Britt, ed.(New York: John Wiley & Sons, Inc., 1968), 364.

[202]Hiebert, *Cultural Anthropology*, 122.

innumerable. Reception, however, occurs via the senses alone, especially hearing. In fact, oral language is universal. No group of people lacking a fully developed spoken language is known to have existed.[203]

Oral communication, nevertheless, has two critical disadvantages. First, as soon as information is spoken it immediately falls out of existence. Nothing exists to anchor the information to reality save repetition. Oral communication is of momentary value and is therefore restricted to time. Second, oral communication can be executed only between persons who are within auditory proximity to each other. Christopher Woods states, "Speech is temporally fleeting and spatially anchored. Writing frees speech of these constraints, giving it permanence and allowing it to be transmitted over space far beyond the place of discourse."[204]

At one time the common belief was that humanity owed the existence of writing to Adam himself. Josephus (37 AD – *c*. 100) found this idea plausible.[205] Blaise de Vigenere (1523-1596) asserted a script existed from the beginning of the world, which

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[203]Gelb, *A Study of Writing,* 2-3.

[204]Christopher Woods, "The Earliest Writing Systems," in *Visible Language,* Christopher Woods, ed. (Chicago: Oriental Institute Museum Publications, 2010), 15.

[205]Josephus wrote that Seth inscribed information on stone pillars in order to preserve his discoveries in astronomy and Adam's prediction that calamity would come upon the earth. Josephus' claim, however, was based on the erroneous assumption that the erector of the pillars was Seth, the son of Adam, when in reality it was Seth (Sesostris, king of Egypt). Nevertheless, Josephus' writing demonstrates that it was entirely plausible in his mind that writing existed in the time of Adam. See Flavius Josephus and William Whiston, *The Works of Josephus: Complete and Unabridged* (Peabody: Hendrickson, 1987), 1.67.

Adam had deciphered through the process of naming the animals Yahweh presented him.[206] John Wilkins (1614-1672) argues:

> Though the Scripture doth not mention any thing concerning the invention of these; yet 'tis most generally agreed, that Adam (though not immediately after his creation, yet) in the process of time, upon his experience of their great necessity and usefulness, did first invent the ancient Hebrew character.[207]

Edmond Fry (1754-1835) claimed the angel Raphael revealed two Chaldean alphabets to Adam.[208]

Nevertheless, archeological evidence attributes the invention of writing to the Sumerians between 3000 and 3500 BC.[209] Sumerian cuneiform derives its name from the wedge-shaped marks used to form its signs, and was employed to write a dozen different languages between the thirty-fourth century BC and the first century AD.[210] Samuel Kramer reports, "The first written documents were found in a Sumerian city named Erech. They consist of more than a thousand small pictographic clay tablets inscribed primarily with bits of economic and administrative memoranda. But among them there

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[206]Blaise de Vigenere, *Traité des Chiffres: ov Secretes Manieres D'ecrire* (Paris, 1586).

[207]John Wilkins, *An Essay towards Real Character and Philosophical Language* (London, 1668), 1.3.1.

[208]Edmond Fry, *Pantographia*, (London, 1799). Jean-Jacques Glassner, however, notes that this idea was already popular. See Jean-Jacques Glassner, *The Invention of Cuneiform* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 2003), 2.

[209]Samuel N. Kramer, *History Begins at Sumer* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday Anchor Books, 1959), 1.

[210]Some of these languages were Indo-European, others were Semitic; Hittite, Old Persian, Akkadian, Eblaite, and Amorite to name a few. Further, cuneiform was utilized by other spoken languages that were part of no known language group and had no relation to each other (i.e. Sumerian, Elamite, and Hurrian). See Glassner, *The Invention of Cuneiform*, 2.

are several which contain word lists intended for study and practice."[211] Cuneiform evolved from pictographic writing thanks to Sumerian scribes who succeeded in producing simple, standard signs, which eventually ceased to closely represent their pictographic originals.[212]

How Written Language Relates to Oral Language

Aristotle states, "Now spoken words are symbols of affections in the soul, and written marks symbols of spoken sound."[213] The classical view of writing is positioned as an attempt to reflect, as accurately as possible, what is spoken. According to this view, an ideal writing system accurately and comprehensively represents oral language. Leonard Bloomfield, for example, asserts, "Writing is not language, but merely a means of recording language by visible marks."[214]

In the classical view, developments in writing—from pictures to consonants and vowels—are believed to reflect the progressive advances toward the goal of exact representation of the ultimate units in speech.[215] The classical view understands the evolution of writing as intimately tied to the progressive civilization of mankind, which

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[211]Kramer, *History Begins at Sumer*, 1

[212]Glassner, *The Invention of Cuneiform*, 2; Samuel N. Kramer, *The Sumerians: Their History, Culture, and Character* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1963), 302.

[213]Aristotle, *Categories and De Interpretatione*, trans. with notes by J. L. Ackrill (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1963), 43.

[214]Leonard Bloomfield, *Language* (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1933), 21.

[215]David R. Olson, "How Writing Represents Speech," *Language and Communication* 13, no. 1 (1993): 1.

culminated with the Greek alphabet.[216] Rousseau conceives of this evolutionary perspective:

> These three ways of writing correspond almost exactly to three different stages according to which one can consider men gathered into a nation. The depicting of objects appropriate to a savage people, signs of words and of prepositions, to a barbaric people, and the alphabet to a civilized people.[217]

Peter Damerow, however, disputes the classical view stating, "We should, in particular, not rely on the plausibility of the assumption that writing was created in order to enhance or to substitute for spoken communication."[218] The alternative view calls into questions the assertion that physical representation of oral language was the only motive that occasioned the invention of writing.[219] Gelb insists there must be a broader

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[216]Eric Havelock propounds, "At a stroke the Greeks provided a table of elements of linguistic sound not only manageable because of economy, but for the first time in the history of *homo sapiens*, also accurate." See Eric Havelock, *The Literate Revolution in Greece and its Cultural Consequences* (Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1982), 11. David Diringer described writing as the "main currency of man's civilization." He states, "Wherever there has been civilization there has been writing and reading, in the remote past as in the present day. Written language has become the vehicle of civilization, and so of learning and education. Writing is thus one of the main aspects of culture which clearly distinguishes mankind from the animal world." See David Diringer, *The Alphabet: A Key to the History of Mankind* (London: Hutchinson's Scientific and Technical Publications, 1949), 17.

[217]Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *On the Origin of Language*. Alexander Gode, ed. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1966), 17.

[218]Peter Damerow, "The Origins of Writing as a Problem of Historical Epistemology," *Cuneiform Digital Writing Journal* (2006:1), 4.

[219]David Olson signaled two flaws in the classical view. First, it may be argued that symbol systems were conceived to communicate information, not represent speech. The relation to oral language was indirect. Second, the classical view underestimates the excellency of alternative writing systems. The Chinese logographic script and the mixed logographic and alphabetic script employed in Japan have proven not to be significant inhibitory factors in the development of modern society, including in the field of technology and medicine. See Olson, *How Writing Represents Speech*, 2.

understanding of the history of writing beyond merely a recording device for speech. He affirms:

> Even though all the early writings are inefficient in expressing speech adequately, some of them, like the Maya and Aztec writings, reached a level of systemization and convention which in some way may be compared with such fully developed writings as Sumerian or Egyptian.[220]

Orality and Textuality Contrasted

The invention of writing signaled a new mode of thinking. It was almost a millennium, however, before literate cognition would come to full maturity.[221] This restructured consciousness permeates all modern, literate cultures. [222] The Sumerian's invention of cuneiform profoundly influenced Western civilization. Without the technology of writing, the literate mind could not think as it does. Ong asserts, "More than any other single invention, writing has transformed human consciousness."[223]

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[220]Gelb called the classic evolutionary perspective an "illusion." See Gelb, *A Study of Writing*, 12.

[221]Glassner, *The Invention of Cuneiform*, 3.

[222]From very early on, many had misgivings about the concomitants of writing. Plato's Socrates in the *Phaedrus* warns, "You offer your pupils the appearance of wisdom, not true wisdom, for they will read many things without instruction and will therefore seem to know many things, when they are for the most part ignorant and hard to get along with, since they are not wise, but only appear wise." Of course, Plato, in order to make his demurs persuasive, put them into writing. He, however, was not alone in his reservations about this new technology. Hieronimo Squarciafico, in 1477, insisted that an abundance of books impedes study. He argued that writing impairs memory and weakens the mind by depriving it of necessary exercise. See Plato, *Plato in Twelve Volumes*, Harold N. Fowler, trans., vol. 9 (Medford, MA: Cambridge, MA, Harvard University Press; London, William Heinemann Ltd., 1925), 275a-b. Martin Lowry, *The World of Aldus Manutius: Business and Scholarship in Renaissance Venice.* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1979), 29-32.

[223]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 77.

Orality-Textuality Continuum

Writing is a technology unnaturally human. The invention of writing seems almost accidental given that no genetic compulsion for man to write exists. In fact, the appearance of a new and fully developed mode of communication besides oral language has eluded many societies.[224] Writing is entirely artificial. It requires the use of equipment: styli or brushes or pens, prepared writing surfaces, as well as a transferrable marking substance, such as ink. By contrast, oral language is fully natural in the sense that every human in every society learns to communicate orally if not physiologically or psychologically impaired.[225]

Although decided dissimilarity exists between oral and textual cultures, they are not antithetical concepts; but, rather, they occur on a continuum that moves from purely oral to purely textual.[226] Most people and societies exist between the two extremes. Even in lettered cultures, residual orality remains a prevailing reality. John Harvey indicates,

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[224]Glassner, *The Invention of Cuneiform*, 5.

[225]Giorgio Buccellati argues that writing ought to be viewed as an intellectual innovation and should be compared with tools and mechanical devices in order to truly understand its nature and effect on humanity. Giorgio Buccellati, "The Origin of Writing and the Beginning of History." in *The Shape of the Past* (1981), 7. Moreover, Ong states, "Like artificial creations and indeed more than any other, it is utterly invaluable and indeed essential for the realization of fuller, interior, human potentials. Technologies are not mere exterior aid but also interior transformations of consciousness, and never more than when they affect the word. Such transformations can be uplifting. Writing heightens consciousness." Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 80-81.

[226]Wolfgang Raible connotes, "Orality and literacy are dialectical concepts, the meaning of one term depending on the assessment of the other one. In addition, both have two aspects: a medial and a conceptual one. While mediality is trivial, the conceptual aspect is best conceived of as a continuum, thus blurring any clear-cut distinction between orality and scripturality." See Wolfgang Raible, "Literacy and Orality," in *International Encyclopedia of Social and Behavioral Sciences*, Smelser, N. J. and Baltes, Paul B., eds. (Pergamom, 2002), 8967-71.

"Orality continues its influence long after the introduction of the alphabet and writing."[227]

Moreover, Ong avers:

> Oral expression can exist and mostly has existed without any writing at all, writing never without orality… Indeed, language is so overwhelmingly oral that of all the many thousands of languages—possibly tens of thousands—spoken in the course of human history only around 106 have ever been committed to writing to a degree sufficient to have produced literature, and most have never been written at all… The basic orality of language is permanent.[228]

Thus, at one end of the continuum are primary oral learners who cannot read or write, and at the other end are highly print learners.[229] In between exists a range of learning preferences.[230] Though linguists are apt to picture societies on the continuum moving from unlettered to lettered,[231] Madinger reasons, "literacy is far more than the technologies of writing and reading. It is also the ability to understand and use the information conveyed through the terms and concepts that comprise a message."[232] Thus,

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[227]John Harvey, "Orality and Its Implications for Biblical Studies: Recapturing an Ancient Paradigm," *JETS* 45, no. 1 (March 2002): 101.

[228]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 288, 7.

[229]Eric Havelock approaches the question of transition from primary orality to primary literacy using a grid of literacy and proposes a continuum which begins with pre-literate culture and extends through craft-literacy, recitation-literacy, and script-literacy to type-literate culture. See Havelock, *The Literate Revolution in Greece and Its Cultural Consequences* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1982).

[230]Moon, "Encouraging Ducks to Swim," 4-5.

[231]Grant Lovejoy faced the daunting task of assessing the state of orality in the world using data that defined literate folk with a variety of measures, some simply requiring that the person have the ability to sign their name. Lovejoy explains, "This makes it difficult to get accurate descriptions of the levels of literacy (and thus the extent of orality). What makes matters even worse for international statisticians is the fact that each country is free to define 'literate' for its own purposes." See Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," 18.

[232]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 206.

the evangelization and discipleship of oral folk requires the missionary to apprehend the complexity of the orality framework, which goes far deeper than the issue of literacy. Arnett maintains, "This challenge is greater than language and culture because it requires, not a new skill, but a radically different thought process."[233]

Issue Group 25 of the 2004 Lausanne Forum drew from James B. Slack's work in describing a continuum of orality and textuality. [234]

Illiterates	They cannot read or write and have never "seen" a word. Words do not exist as letters but rather as sounds related to images of events and to situations.
Functional illiterates	They have attended some school but do not continue to read and write regularly. They can read only simple sentences and can no longer receive, recall or reproduce concepts, ideas, precepts, and principles through literate means. They prefer to get their information orally.
Semi-literates	They understand and handle information such as ideas, precepts, concepts, and principles by literate means. They function in a gray transitional area between oral communication and literacy. Despite being classified in every country of the world as literates, they learn primarily by means of narrative presentations.
Literate	They tend to rely on printed material as an aid to recall.
Highly literate	They usually have attended college and are often professionals in the liberal arts fields. They are thoroughly print-culture individuals.

Slack's categorizations reflect the gradation of orality and textuality found within societies.[235] His classifications are helpful, but his nomenclature betrays a biased

[233]Arnett, "Discipleship in the Face of Orality," 4.

[234]The five categorizations and descriptions are found in Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 20-21, quoting James B. Slack.

[235]Lynne L. Abney's "Orality Assessment Tool" allows for evaluators to respond to cognitions indicators on a scale of 0-4. See International Orality Network, http://www.orality.net/sites/default/files/Orality_Assessment_Tool_Worksheet.pdf. (accessed October 21, 2014).

perspective.[236] While literacy is a positive skill for cultures to acquire, it is not the goal of missions. Moreover, Arnett asserts, "The refusal of orality as a valid domain undermines the effort to find legitimate approaches to disciple oral people."[237]

Characteristics of Orality

Despite the confluence of orality and textuality, a striking contrast exists between the two. If oral cultures are to be effectively engaged by textual messengers, it is of vital importance that methodologies, processes, and procedures embedded within the oral culture itself are considered and taken captive in order to be employed by the messenger in the work of communicating the message. If oral learners are not taught within the framework of their cognition, media, and structures, then they will remain largely unaffected by the message, and will assuredly be hampered in passing it along.

This aspect of communication is as critical as the physical symbols into which messages are encoded. Just as Chinese symbols are incomprehensible to those familiar with the Roman alphabet, so is textual presentation of information foreign to those that function within the orality framework.

The following table presents an overview of key characteristics of the orality complex by contrasting the preferences of oral cultures with textual cultures.[238]

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[236]The idea that societal stratification is closely correlated to literacy has been a recurring theme throughout recorded human history. A more recent example is found in Sid Fleischman's *The Whipping Boy*. When one of the protagonists of the tale, a prince nonetheless, admits that he has not learned to write, his captor exclaims, "And crows can't fly!…You're a prince! Kings and such-like are learned to write and read as they tumble out of the cradle. Don't think you can pull the wool over our eyes. Hop to it!" See Sid Fleischman, *The Whipping Boy* (New York: Troll Associates, 1987), 20.

[237]Arnett, "Discipleship in the Face of Orality," 7.

Oral Cultures		Textual Cultures
Spoken Storyline Concrete	*Communication*	Written Outline Abstract
Communal	*Lifestyle*	Institutional
Social Dimensions	*Time and Space*	Mathematical Dimensions
Immediate	*Gratification*	Deferred
Circular Conceptual	*Life Perspective*	Linear Historical
Group Oriented Apprenticeship Teacher is Valued Mnemonic Devices	*Learning Patterns*	Individually Oriented Textbook Information is Valued Archived Text
Words are Events/Alive/Attached	*Lexicon*	Words are Objects/Dead/Detached

Communication

Dissemination of information occurs primarily through spoken language in oral cultures. Even in societies where writing has been introduced, it is often the case that the majority of information continues to be transferred through oral means. This is clearly seen, for example, in the spread of ideas during the Reformation. Despite the growing popularity of the moveable type printing press, according to Scribner, the oral masses learned about reformation ideas and news through sermons, dialogue, and music.[239] Gerald Strauss, for example, reports, "When we consider the work of scholars who have

[238]Adapted from multiple sources, but especially Chalres Madinger and William Parker. See Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 203; and William C. Parker, "Cultural and Academic Stress Imposed on Afro-Americans: Implications for Educational Change," Princeton: E.R.I.C., #ED134646 (www.eric.ed.gov), 5.

[239]See Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*.

dealt with the phenomenon of the spread of the Lutheran message, we find that the dissemination of Lutheran ideas was due largely to oral means of transmission."[240]

Further, oral cultures tend toward concrete, tangible constructs, such as narrative, instead of abstractions or propositions in outline form.[241] Recounting his rearing in an oral milieu, Tex Sample describes:

> My world was not one of discourse, systematic coherence, the consistent use of clear definitions, and the writing of discursive prose that could withstand the whipsaws of academic critique. Rather, it was a world made sense of through proverbs, stories, and relationships.[242]

Gabriel Fackre further explains, "Narrative speaks in the idiom of the earth. Reality meets us in the concretions of time, place, and people, not in analytical discourse or mystical rumination."[243] The concrete media of narrative is that which oral peoples use to teach, remember, and process information. Steffen remarks, "People with partial or no

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[240]Gerald Strauss, *Luther's House of Learning: Indoctrination of the Young in the German Reformation* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1978).

[241]The phonetic alphabet favors left-hemisphered activity in the brain, which fosters abstract, analytic thought. See Derrick de Kerckhove, "A Theory of Greek Tragedy," *Sub-Stance* 29 (Summer 1981): 23-36.

[242]Tex Sample, *Ministry in an Oral Culture—Living with Will Rogers, Uncle Remus, and Minnie Pearl* (Louisville, KY: Westminster/John Knox Press, 1994), 3.

[243]Gabriel Fackre, "Narrative Theology: An Overview," *Interpretation* 37, no. 4 (October 1983), 345. A. R. Luria argued for and tested the premises that literacy enabled people to use abstractions. Anthony Casey reports, "Luria's classic study on cognitive development among pre-literate Uzbeks is still one of the best insights into the minds of oral peoples. It was Luria who explored the limits of abstract thinking among oral peoples and provided many examples from the field on how utility and usage drive cognition among oral peoples." See Anthony Francis Casey, "How Shall They Hear? The Interface of Urbanization and Orality in North American Ethnic Church Planting." Ph.D. diss., The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2013; Ellen Spolsky, "Literacy after Iconoclasm in in the English Reformation," *Journal of Medieval and Early Modern Studies* 39, no. 2 (Spring 2009): 305-330; A. R. Luria, *Cognitive Development: Its Cultural and Social Foundations*, trans. M. Lopez-Morallis and L. Solotaroff (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1976).

literary background tend to express themselves more through concrete forms than abstract concepts."[244] Achebe remarks, "Proverbs are the palm oil with which words are eaten."[245]

Oral cultures' preference for the concrete over abstraction is why Christian Keysser, a laborer among the oral Papuans, argued that missionaries should explain to the target group "what God does for them in a quite definite situation."[246] Moreover, Warneck argues effective communication of biblical truths will not be realized through "intellectual preaching" among oral cultures. Rather, he asserts:

> That is done by depicting the deeds of the living God before the eyes of the heathen. Persons are made known by their acts. Mission preaching proclaims the deeds of God; it explains nothing at first, expounds nothing; it simply narrates what God has done.[247]

Ong comments, "Oral cultures know few statistics or facts divorced from human or quasi-human activity."[248] This is why Nathan, the prophet, confronted David with a story of a family and a lamb (2 Sam. 12), Abimelech spoke of trees and bramble (Judg. 9), and more than one-third of Jesus' sayings were parables.[249]

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[244]Steffen, *Passing the Baton.* Further, in *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry*, Steffen asserts, "Approximately two-thirds of the world's population prefer the concrete mode of learning" (27). "People with such backgrounds tend to express themselves through concrete forms (stories, symbols, rituals) rather than abstract concepts (propositional thinking and philosophy)" (29).

[245]Chinua Achebe, *Things Fall Apart* (New York: Fawcett Press, 1959), 10.

[246]Vicedom, "An Example of Group Conversion," 128.

[247]Warneck, *The Living Christ and Dying Heathenism*, 224.

[248]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 43.

[249]Carpenter, *Holman Treasury of Key Bible Words*, 355. A parable is story or situation rooted in everyday human life employed to illustrate or defend some an abstract principle. See Dunnett, *Exploring the New Testament,* 21.

Lifestyle

Oral societies are "relational, group-oriented, face-to-face cultures."[250] Because the utterances of speech are tied to the time continuum, oral persons must be spontaneous, acting and reacting simultaneously. Parker states, "As a consequence oral man is, at all times, emotionally involved in, as opposed to intellectually detached from, his environment through the acts of communication."[251] This emotional involvement creates the quality of community. Ong asserts:

> Primary orality fosters personality structures that in certain ways are more communal and externalized, and less introspective than those common among literates. Oral communication unites people in groups. Writing and reading are solitary activities that throw the psyche back on itself.[252]

Individuals in group-oriented societies find identity through being a part of the community.[253] Their sense of identity is not shaped by individual autonomy, but is conferred to them by the community. Instead of personal choice, they have belonging. Rather than knowing who they are by knowing their personal preferences, oral folk know who they are by knowing the group to which they belong.[254] Madinger states, "Oral

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[250]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners,* 5.

[251]Parker, "Cultural and Academic Stress Imposed on Afro-Americans," 6.

[252]Ong, *Orality and Literacy,* 67.

[253]Donald K. Smith states, "A minority of the world's peoples live in cultures where individual interest (individualism) prevails over group interest (collectivism). Individualism is strong in the United States, Canada, Great Britain, Australia, New Zealand, Italy, and Western European societies." See Donald K. Smith, "Individualism and Collectivism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of World Missions,* A Scott Moreau, ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2000), 485.

[254]Amy S. Choi, "How Cultures around the World Make Choices," http://ideas.ted.com (accessed 15 October 2014).

culture peoples place a high value on consensus and corporate action, raising the expectation for collective conformity and accountability."[255] This phenomenon especially is important in the processes of conversion, discipleship, and church formation.

For example, Alan Tippett, while attempting to organize and interpret data concerning conversion among peoples of Oceania, reports that conversion "has been group-oriented throughout, but never at any point has the individual been disregarded. It required four months of multi-individual deliberation to bring about unanimity and to permit the group action of decision-making."[256]

Again Christian Keysser proved to be perceptive in his engagement of the Papuans, considering the community orientation of this oral people. Vicedom reports:

> Some adults wished to be baptized. Keysser was delighted by this evidence that the blessing of God rested on his labors: but he advised the candidates to wait, and to go on working among other members of the tribe until the whole tribe was ready to accept the gospel…When Keysser judged the people to be ready, he would call a great assembly of the tribe. According to tribal custom, he himself provided a feast for those who assembled. This gave him a right to intervene with decisive effect when the people came to discuss the question of giving up paganism and accepting the gospel.[257]

Oral cultures tend toward group-orientation; and it is in the context of community that the discipline of storying is often employed. Corporate gatherings are ideal situations for recounting news, histories, and mythologies. Ancient Israel, for example, recited the

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[255]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 207.

[256]Alan Tippett, "Conversion as a Dynamic Process in Christian Mission," *Missiology: An International Review* 5, no. 2 (April 1977), 217.

[257]Vicedom, "An Example of Group Conversion," 124.

Exodus narrative when they gathered for the celebration of first fruits (Deut. 6) and recounted the history of the nation during the covenant renewal festivals (Josh. 24).[258]

Time and Space

Interiorized writing creates a time-bound consciousness. Those living in oral contexts, however, have no newspapers, wristwatches, or computers to impinge location in time and space upon the consciousness. Early charters transferring land in England, for example, were originally left undated. M. T. Clanchy holds the lack of dating was due to the fact that "dating required the scribe to express an opinion about his place in time."[259] Most scribes would have been overwrought about finding a point of reference. Moreover, most people in medieval or Renaissance Europe would not be aware of the calendar year or even of the year they were born.[260]

In highly literate cultures everyone lives life with an acute awareness of abstract computed time imposed by millions of printed calendars, timepieces, cell phones, and computers. These mechanisms that bombard modern, literate societies with a time-bound frame of reference were non-existent in twelfth century England and are scarce in oral societies today.[261] Ong relates, "Before writing was deeply interiorized by print, people

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[258]Boomershine, "A History of Biblical Narration," 3.

[259]M.T. Clanchy, *From Memory to Written Record* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1993), 238.

[260]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 97.

[261]In an email to the author on December 24, 2014 J. O. Terry related, "One time lightning struck a large oak tree across the road from their house. The tree was split into two. So my mother would begin: 'It was the year before lightning struck the oak tree...' Another marker she used referred to the time when certain relatives died. The date was not important, but the event was."

did not feel themselves situated every moment of their lives in abstract computed time of any sort."[262]

For oral folk, time and space are anchored to human interaction and community, whereas textual societies picture time and space as mathematical divisions detached from the human world.[263] Time is a linear progression of quantifiable moments, and space is a mathematical assessment of intervals between points. Time and space are abstract concepts independent of human will and interaction. These concepts for oral societies are felt experiences. As one African professed, "Time is a time of meaning not a time of chronology or clock hours. What is important is how you feel at this moment."[264]

Gratification

The advent of writing accompanies a reckoning of time and a certain kind of societal advancement. For example, as Western society converted to textuality, they developed what Norbert Elias called a "network of interdependence," which included

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[262]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 96.

[263]Daniel Kahneman, winner of Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences, distinguishes between the "remembering self" and the "experiencing self." He asserts the remembering self is a master storyteller. He comments, "The biggest difference between them is in the handling of time. From the point of view of the experiencing self, if you have a vacation, and the second week is just as good as the first, then the two-week vacation is twice as good as the one-week vacation. That's not the way it works at all for the remembering self. For the remembering self, a two-week vacation is barely better than the one-week vacation because there are no new memories added. You have not changed the story. And in this way, time is actually the critical variable that distinguishes a remembering self from an experiencing self; time has very little impact on the story." See Daniel Kahneman, "The Riddle of Experience Vs. Memory," *TED*, http://www.ted.com/talks/daniel_kahneman_the_riddle_of_experience_vs_memory (Accessed 01 December 2014).

[264]Quoted in Parker, "Cultural and Academic Stress Imposed on African-Americans," 6.

arable regions of the earth as well as oceans.[265] Elias continues, "Corresponding to it, too, is the strength of self-control and the permanence of compulsion, affect-inhibition and drive-control, which life at the center of this network imposes." Jack Goody agrees, "There is certainly more planning, and hence delayed gratification, in such societies, associated with the reckoning of time."[266]

Among other consequences, gratification tendencies change the way societies formulate narrative. Textual cultures prefer a climactic linear plot, commonly known as Freytag's pyramid,[267] while oral storytellers plunge their audience *in medias res* and then explain precipitating events.[268] In this conception of storytelling the narrator eschews strict chronology and begins by quickly introducing the audience into the action, eventually explaining the pretext.

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[265]Norbert Elias, *The Civilizing Process: Power and Civility* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1982), 457.

[266]Jack Goody, *The Theft of History* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2006), 168.

[267]Ong explains, "Persons from today's literate and typographic cultures are likely to think of consciously contrived narrative as typically designed in a climactic linear plot often diagramed as the well-known 'Freytag's pyramid' (i.e. an upward slope, followed by a downward slope): an ascending action builds tension, rising to a climactic point, which consists often of a recognition or other incident bringing about a *peripeteia* or reversal of action, and which is followed by a dénouement or untying—for this standard climactic linear plot has been likened to the tying and untying of a knot." See Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 139.

[268]John Miles Foley, "'Reading' Homer through Oral Tradition," *College Literature* 34, no. 2 (Spring 2007): 19. Further, for more information on the shape of stories see Kurt Vonnegut's work. He argued that the shape of a societies are just as important as important as the shapes of their potshards. See Josh Jones, "Kurt Vonnegut Diagrams the Shape of All Stories in a Master's Thesis Rejected by U. Chicago," Open Culture, http://www.openculture.com/2014/02/kurt-vonnegut-masters-thesis-rejected-by-u-chicago.html (accessed January 30, 2015).

Life Perspective

Oral cultures' cognitive processes are corporate, circular, and traditional, whereas textual cultures tend toward individualistic, linear, and logical contemplation.[269] Paul Hiebert states:

> In the West we assume that time runs like a straight line from a beginning to an end, that it can be divided into uniform intervals such as years, days, minutes and seconds, and that it never repeats itself. Other cultures see time as cyclical: a never-ending repetition of summer and winter; day and night, and birth, death and rebirth.[270]

The cyclical character of human experience is a profound feature of oral cultures. Oral cultures have a cyclical view of history, which is augmented by narrative.[271] David Leeming propounds:

> The purpose of religious traditions is the retelling of sacred stories and the reenacting of sacred events is precisely that participation in the myth of the eternal return, participation in cyclical, that is ever-repeating eternal time, rather than linear, inevitably ending, time."[272]

In traditional Chinese groups, for example, life is viewed as cyclical, with a tendency to "look forward to the past."[273]

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[269]Casey W. Davis, "Hebrews 6:4-6 From an Oral Critical Perspective," *JETS* 51, no. 4 (December 2008), 756.

[270]Paul G. Hiebert, "Conversion and Worldview Transformation," *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 14, no. 2 (Apr-June 1997), 85.

[271]Florovsky argues in textual societies' history is "conceived as a meaningful and purposeful process, leading to a goal, and not as a perennial rotation, leading nowhere." See Georges Florovsky, *Christianity and Culture*, Vol. 2 (Belmont, MA: Nordland Publishing Company, 1974), 26.

[272]David Adams Leeming, *Creation Myths of the World: An Encyclopedia*, 2nd ed. (Santa Barbara, CA: ABC-CLIO, 2010), 410.

[273]John Bryan Starr, *Understanding China* (New York: Hill and Wang, 2001), 49.

Learning Patterns

Oral cultures have distinct learning patterns to which literate messengers must adjust, but often fail to do so. Tom Steffen relates his own misguided engagement of the Ifugao in the Philippines. He describes, "The Ifugao wanted stories; I gave them systematic theology. They wanted relationships; I gave them reasons. They wanted a cast of characters; I gave them categories of convenience. They wanted events; I gave them explanations."[274] Oral cultures prefer to learn in participatory groups. Jay Moon states, "A close, emphatic, communal participation with the speaker helps the oral learner to connect with the topic in a memorable manner."[275]

Apprenticeship is an integral element of learning in oral contexts. Oral learners find textbooks and manuals useless or uninteresting. Ong explains this tendency:

> They learn by apprenticeship—hunting with experienced hunters, for example—by discipleship, which is a kind of apprenticeship, by listening, by repeating what they hear, by mastering proverbs and ways of combining and recombining them, by assimilating other formulary materials, by participation in a kind of corporate retrospection—not by study in the strict sense.[276]

In apprenticeship, learning occurs through observation and practice. Verbalization is minimized, serving only to buttress modeling actions.[277]

Similarly, in oral cultures the teacher is valued above curriculum. In textual contexts teacher and student defer to curriculum as authoritative, making it the focal

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[274]Tom Steffen, "Pedagogical Conversions: From Propositions to Story and Symbol," *Missiology: An International Review* 38, no. 2 (April 2010), 148.

[275]W. Jay Moon, "Discipling Through the Eyes of Oral Learners," *Missiology: An International Review* 38, no. 2 (April 2010), 139.

[276]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 8.

[277]Ibid., 42.

point.[278] Conversely, oral persons consider the teacher the authority and focal point. Thus, elders of the oral community are esteemed and revered as authoritative because of their knowledge and experience.[279] Due to the constraints of oral language and human memory, knowledge is a precious commodity in oral contexts.[280]

Finally, an oral person only knows what he can recall. The dissemination of information relies upon "the durability, affordability, range of reception, copying, and storage capacity" of the medium.[281] For oral people the storage construct is memory. Thus, mnemonics are of utmost importance in oral learning contexts. Jerry Camery-Hoggatt explains, "Oral cultures tend to be somewhat compact and insular, with personal loyalty and personal memory as the north and south poles around which the group's

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[278]Studies have shown that in literate contexts, children learn from an early age to assign more authority to written language than spoken language. Once children learn to read they trust print-based instructions over oral instructions. See Kathleen H. Corriveau, Shiri Einav, Elizabeth J. Robinson, and Paul L. Harris, "To the letter: Early readers trust print-based over oral instructions to guide their actions," *British Journal of Developmental Psychology* 32, no. 3 (September 2014): 345-358.

[279]J. A. Loubser, "Orality in Pauline 'Christology,'" *Scriptura* 47 (1993): 43.

[280]Arnett asserts, "The time-knowledge values are inverse. Among non-oral peoples, knowledge is freely disbursed, but time is costly. Among oral peoples, time is freely disbursed, but knowledge is costly." See Arnett, "Discipleship in the Face of Orality," 8.

[281]J. A. Loubser, "Moving Beyond Colonialist Discourse: Understanding Oral Theory and Cultural Difference in the Context of Media Analysis," in *Orality, Literacy, and Colonialism in Antiquity*, ed. Jonathan Draper (Atlanta: Society of Biblical Literature, 2004), 78.

language-world turns."[282] Thus, information must be delivered in forms that are memorable if it is to be retained and repeated.[283]

Lexicon

In oral societies words reflect the happenings or incidents of the culture. Ong states, "Without writing, words as such have no visual presence, even when the objects they represent are visual. They are sounds."[284] Bronislaw Malinowski was prodding this idea when he made the point that primitive peoples viewed language as a mode of action instead of a countersign of thought.[285] In textual societies words are dead things that can be manipulated. The existence of an alphabet implies that a word is a thing rather than an event passing out of existence. It can be captured, manipulated, and cut up into parts, transforming the ephemeral world of sound to the inert, static world of space.[286]

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[282]Jerry Camery-Hoggat, ""The Word of God from Living Voices: Orality and Literacy in the Pentecostal Tradition," *Pneuma* 27 (2005): 240.

[283]The work of Milman Parry and Albert Lord proved revolutionary in assessing the nature of verbal memory in primary oral cultures. See Millman Parry, *The Making of Homeric Verse*, Adam Parry, ed. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971) and Albert Lord, *Singer of Tales*., 2nd ed. (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2000). For further discussion of memory see Werner H. Kelber, *The Oral and the Written Gospel: The Hermeneutics of Speaking and Writing in the Synoptic Tradition, Mark, Paul, and Q* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1983); John D. Harvey, "Orality and Its Implications for Biblical Studies: Recapturing an Ancient Paradigm," *JETS* 45 (2002): 99-109; D. C. Duling, "Memory, collective memory, orality and the gospels," *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies* 67, no. 1 (2011): 11 pages; Francis A. Yates, *The Art of Memory* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1966).

[284]Ong, "Orality, Literacy, and Modern Media," 64.

[285]Malinowski, "The Problem of Meaning in Primitive Languages," 451, 470-81.

[286]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 90.

Moreover, in textual societies words have layers of meanings garnered through history, many of which are presently irrelevant. Because of the invention of the dictionary, textual societies' vocabularies far outpace those of oral societies. According to Ong, "Oral cultures have no dictionaries and few semantic discrepancies."[287] For oral folks word meaning is controlled by concrete situations that are actually relevant. No distinction between symbol and referent exists. Goody and Watt refer to this as "direct semantic ratification." They state:

> There can be no reference to "dictionary definitions," nor can words accumulate the successive layers of historically validated meanings which they acquire in a literate culture. Instead the meaning of each word is ratified in a succession of concrete situations, accompanied by vocal inflections and physical gestures, all of which combine to particularize both its specific denotation and its accepted connotative usages.[288]

For oral peoples sound is commonly considered to bear great power.[289] In fact, sound cannot be made without the employment of power. Moreover, the fact that oral people consider words to have magical potency is closely connected to their understanding of words as necessarily spoken, and therefore, power-driven.[290]

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[287]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 46.

[288]Jack Goody and Ian Watt, "The Consequences of Literacy," *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 5, no. 3 (April 1963), 306.

[289]Bruce A. Rosenberg, in his tome about American folk preaching, states, "Whites in Kentucky today hum after each line of their spiritual sermons so as to establish rhythm. The congregation is moved to religious ecstasy by this style, which embodies the emotional power of music and the (ostensibly) rational power of the spoken word. Musical instruments are not needed; the preacher's voice is the full orchestra." See Bruce A. Rosenberg, *Can These Bones Live?: The Art of the American Folk Preacher* (Chicago: University of Illinois Press, 1970), 23.

[290]Ong, *Orality, Literacy, and Modern Media*, 65.

Print-based people forget to think of words as primarily oral and necessarily powered.[291] For them, words have been dissected, systematized, and categorized. A word is a thing that can be viewed, broken down into basic parts, and manipulated.[292] Words are not readily associated with power and magic, for they are not actions or mysteries but rather are controlled objects. They are in a radical sense dead.[293]

In oral contexts spoken words are pictured as having the faculty to render the presence of the realities to which they signify. William Frawley refers to this as the "iconic function" of oral language in which words are a psychological catalyst for engendering icons of experience, which thus awakens a complete emotive response.[294] Words are, in essence, equated with that which is named. Thus, utterances are mysteriously entwined with the reality signified. In fact, in oral cultures words do not signify, they embody. It is for this reason that in oral cultures names have great significance and power.

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[291]The onset of literacy impacts societal structure and norm. Writing, at first, is often deemed an instrument of secret, magic power. For example, the runic alphabet of medieval Northern Europe was regarded as magical; and scraps of paper that contained writing were frequently used as magic amulets. Chinua Achebe, a Nigerian novelist, described an Ibo man who was the only person in his village who could read. In his home he hoarded every piece of writing that he came across. It all seemed too wonderful to discard. See Jack Goody, "Restricted Literacy in Northern Ghana," in *Literacy in Traditional Societies* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1968), 236; and Chinua Achebe, *No Longer at Ease*, (New York: Ivan Obolensky, 1961), 120-121.

[292]John Steinbeck, in 1965, advised aspiring writers with this: "If you are using dialogue—say it aloud as you write it. Only then will it have the sound of speech." Steinbeck recognized the loss of power when dialogue is coded into visible symbols. Interviewed by George Plimpton and Frank Crowther, "John Steinbeck, The Art of Fiction No. 45" *The Paris Review* 63 (Fall 1975).

[293]Ong, *Interfaces of the Word*, 230-271.

[294]William Frawley, *Text and Epistemology* (Norwood, NJ: Ablex Publishing Co., 1987), 16-21.

Conclusion

The orality framework includes the use of narrative, but also encompasses cognitive processes, media selection, relational networks, and content structure. Madinger comments:

> The framework for our communication strategies must take on everything you think of when "oral" comes to mind: cultural traditions, language, the commonly used words, how a message travels through social networks, the types of art people use to express themselves (music, dance, proverbs, story, etc.), how people best store information for recall, and even what channels of communication function best. Every message, lesson, curriculum program and strategy will succeed partly to the degree it takes this framework into account.[295]

Thus, orality is a robust and comprehensive framework, which provides a means by which one may apply narrative-based methodologies within oral societies. It is only when the messenger addresses the oral framework that he may effectively employ storying strategies.

Conversion and Discipleship

By laboring within the constraints of the orality framework, textual messengers may effectively present the gospel. It is at this point that narrative becomes germane to the orality question. How does one share the good news of Jesus with an oral person? Unequivocally, the gospel must be delivered in contextualized narrative forms. An important question, however, remains. Why is it necessary to share the good news of Jesus as a story with oral peoples? To simply state that narrative is their preference lacks

[295]Mandinger, "Applied Orality: More than Methods," 6.

the depth and nuance that this fundamental query necessitates. The answer begins with an exploration of the concept of worldview.[296]

Worldview

Conversion and discipleship consist of transformation at the deepest level of human experience. David Hesselgrave states, "Conversion and Christian growth involve a worldview change in which the follower of Christ comes to understand and embrace God's revelation of truth and reality."[297] For this reason the New Testament speaks of the gospel in terms of profound metamorphosis. Descriptors like "born again" (John 3:3, 6-7) and "new creature" (2 Cor. 5:17) reveal the depth of metamorphosis that Jesus came to bring about in the hearts of people. Paul Hiebert asserts, "If the Gospel does not have to do with worldview matters, it remains surface and transitory."[298] Similarly, Stan May argues, "If missionaries wish to produce lasting change, they must focus on worldview transformation."[299]

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[296]Ken McElhanon relates, "The expression 'worldview' (from *Weltanschauung*) has its origins in eighteenth-century German philosophy in the sense of ideology or system of thought, and this is the sense in which contemporary theologians use it. For most evangelical theologians a worldview constitutes a systematic approach to theology. Their focus is on the fundamental beliefs about the nature of God as Creator and Redeemer and the nature of humanity in its fallen state in need of a redeemer. They regard the Christian (biblical) worldview as in opposition to such ideologies as empiricism, humanism, naturalism, positivism, scientism, and secularism, as well as world religions such as Buddhism, Hinduism, and Islam." See Ken A. McElhanon, "Worldview," in *Evangelical Dictionary of World Missions*, A Scott Moreau, ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2000), 1032.

[297]David J. Hesselgrave, "Worldview, Scripture, and Missionary Communication," *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 14, no. 2 (Apr-June 1997): 79.

[298]Hiebert, "Conversion and Worldview Transformation," 84.

[299]May, "Cultures and Worldviews," 387.

It follows then that worldview transformation is the essence of the missionary vocation, representing both conversion and discipleship.[300] Strikingly, narrative is a structural element of worldview and is inherently essential in the transformation thereof. Story, therefore, is the critical element in the process of worldview formation, reinforcement, and transformation. Samuel Chiang asserts:

> When heart language links with a good story that is well told, it is the direct way to the heart…To change people at the deepest level, we must change their stories…Using heart language of the mother tongue, together with an oral approach to learning (e.g., storytelling, drama, etc.), transforms hearts and communities around the world.[301]

Worldview Defined

Simply put, worldview is a person's *view* of reality. Robert Redfield states worldview "is the way a people characteristically look outward upon the universe… It is the way we see ourselves in relation to all else."[302] Similarly, Michael Kearny contends, "The worldview of a people is their way of looking at reality."[303]

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[300]Wright contends, "[Worldviews] can, however, be challenged; they can, if necessary be discussed, and their truth-value called into question. Conversion, in the sense of radical shift in worldview, can happen, whether in the case of a Saul on the road to Damascus or in the case of a member of a North American Indian or Inuit people who moves to the city and adopts the Western way of life." See Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 125.

[301]Samuel E. Chiang, "The Passion for Orality," in *Orality Breakouts: Using Heart Language to Transform Hearts*, Samuel E. Chiang, ed. (Hong Kong: ION/LCWE, 2010), 5.

[302]Robert Redfield, *The Primitive World and Its Transformations* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1957), 85-86.

[303]Michael Kearney, *World View* (Novato, CA: Chandler and Sharp, 1984), 41.

An animist sees the world as a realm teeming with mystery and supernatural activity.[304] A naturalist, conversely, perceives the world as a series of chemical reactions. One's worldview may or may not be accurate and may live on a subconscious level.[305]

One's view of reality, however, does not arise *ex nihilo*. Every person and culture, whether consciously or subconsciously, holds to a set of assumptions about reality, which determines his view of reality. Paul Hiebert describes worldview as "the basic assumptions about reality which lies behind the beliefs and behavior of a culture."[306] Similarly, Charles Kraft states, "A people's worldview includes the most basic assumptions, values and allegiances of that people. This deep level of culture affects and underlies all surface level behavior."[307]

These assumptions shape one's view of reality. To again refer to the example of Animism, the animist views the world as teeming with spiritual activity because he assumes that the world is in essence a supernatural sphere replete with spiritual beings to which he is subject.[308]

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[304]Dean C. Halverson explains, "The term 'animism' comes from the Latin word *anima*, which means 'soul' or 'breath.' As such, it refers to that which empowers or gives life to something. It follows, then, that animism is the religion that sees the physical world as interpenetrated by spiritual forces—both personal and impersonal—to the extent that objects carry spiritual significance and events have spiritual causes. See Dean C. Halverson, "Animism: The Religion of the Tribal World," *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 15, no. 2 (Apr-June 1998): 59-67.

[305]McElhanon, "Worldview," 1033.

[306]Paul Hiebert, *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries* (Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 1985), 45

[307]Charles Kraft, *Worldview for Christian Witness* (Unpublished Manuscript, 2002), 1:10-11.

[308]A person's assumptions about reality live, for the most part, on a subconscious level. Carol McKinney affirms worldview is "the basic underlying assumptions, whether

Worldviews provide a grid by which a person interprets the happenings all around him. Norman Geisler states, "It is the framework through which or by which one makes sense of the data of life."[309] Similarly, Orville Boyd Jenkins describes worldview as "a coherent thought-system that helps make sense of [shared] experiences and maintains the values developed over the history of that group."[310] When the child of the animist falls ill, he will interpret it in a fundamentally divergent way than the naturalist, believing an evil spirit is plaguing his child, or perhaps an enemy has employed the services of a witch doctor.

May expounds, "Worldview binds people together and provides the basic mental and cultural framework by which individuals and groups understand and respond to reality."[311] Once interpretation of reality is complete, response takes place. If the cause of sickness is supernatural activity, a supernatural solution is in order.

Thus, the animist will seek out the witch doctor to provide guidance for his son's sickness. The naturalist, however, will turn to modern medicine, because he views the cause of his son's sickness as the result of a virus. Interpretation of and response to reality based on underlying assumptions ultimately engenders cultural expression. This interpretation of reality is apprehended through the grid of worldview.

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on tacit or overt levels, that people hold about reality." The unspoken hypothesis is no less influential than the explicit. See Carol V. McKinney, *Globetrotting in Sandals: A Field Guide to Cultural Research* (Dallas: SIL International, 2000), 197.

[309]Norman L. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics*, Baker Reference Library (Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 1999), 785.

[310]Orville Boyd Jenkins, *Dealing with Differences: Contrasting African and European World Views* (Nairobi: Communication Press, 1991), 13.

[311]May, "Cultures and Worldviews," 381.

Two Metaphors for Worldview.[312]

Worldview is the way people *see* the world based on *assumptions* about the world, which gives them a means to *understand* and *respond* to the world. Stan May likens worldview to a road atlas. He comments:

> Driving in the United States, when we enter Tennessee we turn to the Tennessee map. When we enter the cultural setting for greetings, we innately turn to the worldview map page for greetings, and our mental map guides us through the ritual of greetings appropriate to our culture. This wonderful gift of worldview interprets the proper, learned behavior for every area of life and allows us to function effectively in our culture.[313]

Norman Geisler compares worldview to glasses. He states, "One not only reads [interprets] through his worldview glasses, but also he *lives* by means of them. For a worldview is really a world and *life* view. It includes within it value indicators or principles by which one makes value judgments."[314] Unlike literal glasses, however, worldview glasses are virtually impossible to remove. Hesselgrave comments, "Once put on, it is as though they were secured by super glue. Any attempt to remove one's original worldview glasses and try to put on the glasses of a different worldview will necessarily involve considerable effort and even pain."[315]

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[312]Paul Hiebert illustrates culture and worldview thusly, "Culture is like an iceberg. Behavior and beliefs are what we see above the surface of the ocean. The worldview is the large hidden mass beneath the surface that holds the whole iceberg up." See Hiebert, "Conversion and Worldview Transformation," 84.

[313]May, "Cultures and Worldviews," 382.

[314]Norman L. Geisler and William D. Watkins, *Worlds Apart: A Handbook on Worldviews* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 2003), 12.

[315]David J. Hesselgrave, "Putting on Worldview Glasses," in *World Mission: An Analysis of the World Christian Movement*, Johnathan Lewis, ed. (Pasadena: William Carey Library, 1994), 13-13.

Worldview and Foundational Narrative

No culture is without its foundational narrative. Indeed, the existence of culture is impossible apart from the story in which it can grow roots and receive nourishment.[316] Phrased concisely, a people's foundational narrative is the collection of myths about a particular religious or cultural tradition. The collection of stories arises and is codified as a result of existential examination.[317]

Bruce Bradshaw notes, "Narratives are both the templates through which we interpret reality and the means through which we seek continuity in our lives. They emerge from our history and we could not tolerate life without them."[318] G. K. Chesterton was prodding at this idea in Orthodoxy when he states, "I had always felt life first as a story: and if there is a story there is a story-teller."[319]

Bradshaw's description of foundational narrative reads surprisingly similar to the definition of worldview. Worldview's function is to provide a means by which one interprets reality, and good reason exists for this semblance. A culture's worldview and foundational narrative are necessarily and hopelessly ensnarled. To make sense of this

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[316]It was the storied-structure of human identity that led Muriel Rukeyser, American poet, to pen, "The universe is made up of stories, not of atoms." See Muriel Rukeyser, *The Speed of Darkness* (Vintage, 1971).

[317]Other terms that refer to the same concept are "meta-narrative," "mythology," "oral tradition," "legend," "folklore," "narrative," and "story."

[318]Bruce Bradshaw, *Change Across Culture: A Narrative Approach to Social Transformation* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2002), 21.

[319]Gilbert K. Chesterton, *Orthodoxy* (New York: John Lane Company, 1910), 110.

ravel N. T. Wright provides a helpful discussion of what worldviews characteristically do. He states:

> [W]orldviews provide the *stories* through which human beings view reality… from these stories one can in principle discover how to answer the basic questions that determine human existence… the stories that express the worldview, and the answers which it provides to the questions of identity, environment, evil and eschatology, are expressed in cultural *symbols*.[320]

Thus, story and worldview are intimately related and depend heavily upon each other for continued existence. It is vital to recognize the storied structure of worldviews, as it were. In fact, in a very real sense "worldviews are at the deepest level shorthand formulae to express stories."[321] To distill a set of abstract propositions as though one were getting to a more foundational statement of truth is actually to misreport the worldview at its core.

It is useful to employ shorthand phrases to point to an intricate story-form worldview that would be time consuming to fully convey otherwise. Hence, the term "omnipotent" in itself is not complete, but it points to a narrative (or set of narratives) that exists in space and time. The abstraction is a means to summon the broader structure of worldview, namely the story.[322]

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[320]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 123. Further Jonathan Gottschall comments, "Humans live in a storm of stories…Without personal life stories to organize our experience, our own lives would lack coherence and meaning." See Jonathan Gottschall, "The Science of Storytelling: How Narrative Cuts through Distraction Like Nothing Else," *Fast Company*, http://fastcocreate.com/3020044/the-science-of-storytelling-how-narrative-cuts-through-distraction (Accessed 05 December 2014).

[321]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

[322]Ibid., 123.

Formation and Reinforcement of Worldview

Worldview and culture are not developed immediately, but rather they are acquired over time. A person's perspective and interpretation of reality are utterly dependent upon the environment in which he is reared. Hesselgrave comments, "One comes to perceive the world—God, man, nature, history, values, and so forth—in a way prescribed by one's own culture and/or subculture."[323] From earliest childhood, humans are both directly and indirectly indoctrinated with all the elements that make up worldview, which engenders culture.

Worldview Formation

If worldviews are acquired, then how may one precisely describe the acquisition process? Hesselgrave contends that worldviews are formed "by the telling of a story (and stories within a story) and drawing inferences from it. That's why all peoples have their story (myth, legend, history—in one sense it makes little difference) and draw upon it to sustain their values."[324] Thus, a people's foundational narrative precedes and occasions its worldview. This raises the question, however, what occasions the foundational narrative?

James Sire states, "Another way to get at what a world view is is to see it as our essential, rock-bottom answers to the following seven questions."[325] Sire lists seven

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[323]Hesselgrave, "Putting on Worldview Glasses," 13-12.

[324]David J. Hesselgrave, *Scripture and Strategy: The Use of the Bible in Postmodern Church and Missions* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 50.

[325]James W. Sire, *The Universe Next Door*, 2nd ed. (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1988), 18.

existential questions that have been subsequently reshaped and reformulated. His basic assertion, though, is important. Sire points to the reality that these questions play a critical role in the formation of worldview. Lovejoy clarifies:

> A culture houses its central convictions in its fundamental narrative, whether its narrative is implicit or explicit. The ancient mythologies that we find in cultures around the world are explicit examples of this. Those stories answer four fundamental worldview questions: Who am I? Where am I? What has gone wrong? What can be done about it?…Every culture uses stories to tell us what it means to be human, what kind of world we live in, why there is suffering and pain, and what, if anything, we can do to deal with that suffering and pain.[326]

Thus, human culture finds its origins in its quest for answers. Every person and society pants for answers to foundational questions. A society's mythology supplies answers to its deepest existential questions.

No culture is without its foundational narrative because no culture is without its questions. Wright reasons, "Worldviews have to do with the presuppositional, pre-cognitive stage of a culture or society. Wherever we find the ultimate concerns of human beings, we find worldviews."[327] Every society responds to the existential questions, not with abstract principles, but with an overarching narrative. This mythology provides societies with their doctrines of the meaning of life, the kind of world in which they live, the provenance of their pain, and the remedy for that pain.

Therefore, the story with which a people answer the existential questions engenders worldview. Hesselgrave contends:

> Worldviews, after all, are not a composite of complementary but poorly integrated notions and values. Rather, they are seamless garments with an unbroken pattern. They are blueprints with every feature of the building intact and in place. They

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[326]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 33.

[327]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 122.

> are big stories—and stories within that story—with a plot and its resolution, with a beginning, a middle, and an end.[328]

Worldview, then, is formed by the overarching story a society tells itself to answer existential questions.[329] Subsequently, worldview finds its full expression in culture (beliefs, values, behavior).[330] Plotting these essential elements—culture, worldview, foundational narrative, and existential questions—in sequential order provides a useful depiction of how they relate.

Thus, the crucial function of narrative comes into focus. Far more than a clever communication tool, storying is a communication form unique in its ability to satisfy foundational questions, challenge existing mythology, and engage worldview. The following illustration may be used to portray this interaction as it occurs within societies.

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[328]Hesselgrave, "Worldview, Scripture, and Missionary Communication," 81. Similarly, LaNette W. Thompson likened worldview to a complex of learned schemata. She states, "Schemata are created through personal experience, by hearing others' stories, and by fantasizing." Interestingly, all three of Thompson's creators of schemata are narrative in nature, signaling the principle that foundational narrative conceives worldview. See LaNette W. Thompson, "Tell His Story so that All Might Worship," in *Discovering the Mission of God*, Mike Barnett, ed. (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2012), 394.

[329]MacIntyre, Bruner, Hauerwas and Jones, and Fisher all argue story as foundation for worldview. See Alasdair MacIntyre, *After Virtue: A Study in Moral Theory*, 3rd ed. (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 2007); Jerome Bruner, *The Culture of Education* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996); Stanley Hauerwas and L. Gregory Jones, *Why Narrative?: Readings in Narrative Theology* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 1997); Walter R. Fisher, *Human Communication as Narration* (Colombia, SC: University of South Carolina Press, 1989).

[330]Thus, modifications of readily observable behavior originates with the deeper reality of foundational narrative. Jonathon Gottschall states that "stories aren't just fun escapism—they have an almost spooky ability to mold our thinking and behavior. See Gottschall, "The Science of Storytelling: How Narrative Cuts through Distraction Like Nothing Else."

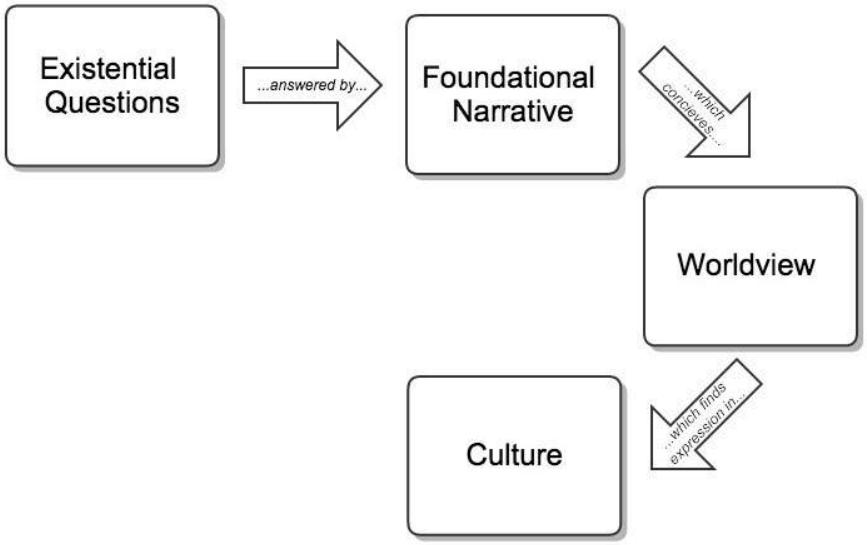

Figure 1: Formation of Worldview

A clear understanding of how worldviews come into being provides helpful insight into development of evangelism and discipleship strategies for oral peoples. Missionaries, however, do not have the prerogative to be a part of the formation of worldviews of individuals and societies. Rather, they are tasked with transforming existing worldviews. The process for how worldviews are reinforced provides further clarity.

Worldview Reinforcement

Foundational narrative not only serves to form worldview, but it also reinforces worldview assumptions through the recitation of story, which ensures survival of and strengthens worldview. Because worldview "finds its foundational meaning in myths and stories," survival of worldview "requires the recitation of myths and stories."[331] That is why, as McKinney states, "The transmission of values occurs through various means such as advice given by elders, including parents to children, customs, taboos, gossip,

[331]Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry,* 31-32.

songs, education, the media, and oral traditions."[332] Similarly, Hiebert contends, "People express their religious beliefs in creeds and stories and in ritual behavior."[333]

A society's foundational narrative, along with smaller narratives that comprise it, makes its appearance in innumerable forms. Some manifestations are direct recitations and symbolizations of the story while others are veiled visages.[334] As a society reinforces its foundational story, the worldview that springs from the story is strengthened, which finally reinforces culture. The cycle then begins anew. *Figure 1* may be reconfigured to reflect this reality.

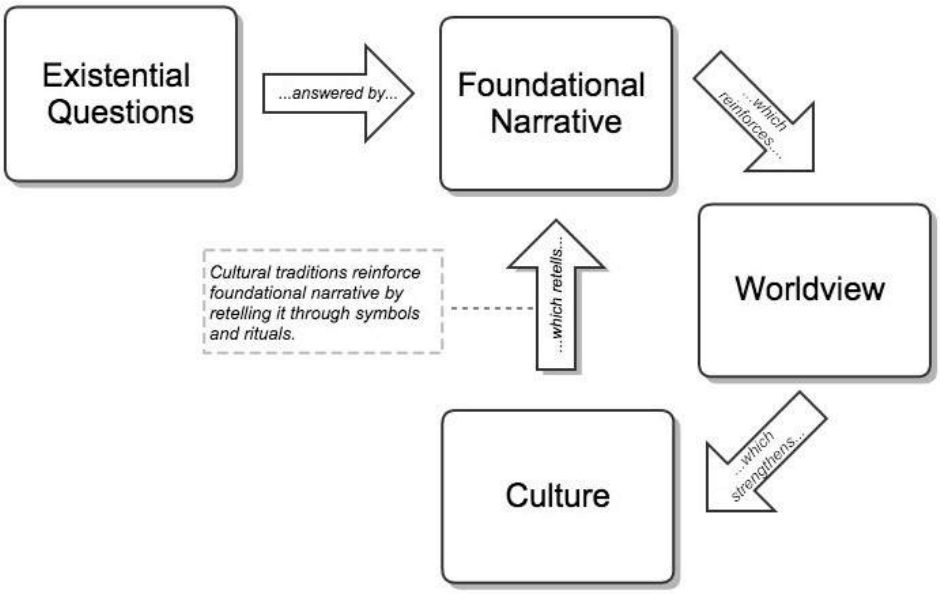

Figure 2: Cycle of Reinforcement

[332]McKinney, *Globetrotting*, 222.

[333]Ibid.

[334]Dori Penjore, oral traditions specialist, underscores the importance of story in the reinforcement of values in Bhutanese children. He states, "Distilled folk wisdoms like proverbs for example validate values and beliefs, which are reinforced practically in adult life. . . Child is exposed to knowledge, experiences, morals, customs, rituals, and belief that they are supposed to live through as adults through tales." See Dorji Penjore, "Folktales and Education: Role of Bhutanese Folktales in Value Transmission," *Journal of Buhtan Studies*, Vol. 12 (Summer 2005). Thimpju: The Center for Bhutan Studies.), 54.

Oral traditions as well as written literature, for example, serve as powerful strengtheners of worldview because they recount and reflect foundational narratives. For this reason Charles Kraft recommends missionaries gather oral and written literature produced by communities to unearth deeper realities of worldview.[335]

Much of meaningful cultural expression directly represents and recalls the foundational story of that society. Through ritual, music, dance, theatre, costume, and pilgrimage, the mythology that sustains and nourishes both worldview and culture is recited. Consider Christianity's most hallowed holidays and rituals. Christmas is a remembrance and retelling of the birth of Jesus. Holy Week recounts his entry into Jerusalem, betrayal, death, and resurrection. The Lord's Supper commemorates the broken body and spilled blood of Jesus on the cross. Baptism pictures his death, burial, and resurrection.

Similarly, Muslims recite key stories through ritual and pilgrimage. Muslims are obligated to make the *Hajj*, a pilgrimage to the holy city of Mecca.[336] A basic function of the rituals performed during the pilgrimage is to commemorate and identify with

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[335]Kraft indicated seven ways in which oral and written literature serve to reinforce worldview: "provides a basis of common origins and identity, answers questions about human destiny and what may help or alter it, reinforces basic assumptions of authority, respect, and rights to land or other material possessions, clearly pictures who are to be included and who are to be excluded, who are the 'we' and who are the 'they,' teaches and reinforces moral values, serves to illustrate ideal and sub-ideal behavior and the rewards and punishments that go along with either, serves as encouragement in times of difficulty and uncertainty." See Kraft, *Worldview for Christian Witness*, 13:7-8.

[336]The authoritative description of the *Hajj* is found in *Qur'an,* Surah 2.

important foundational narratives in Islam tradition.[337] One ritual recalls the story of the infant Ishmael and his mother, Hagar. According to Muslim tradition, they were stranded in the desert, and Ishmael was dying of thirst. Hagar ran back and forth between the hills of Safa and Marwa in search of water to save the child when Gabriel finally touched down to earth and created a spring of fresh water. In remembrance of this story, pilgrims walk back and forth between these hills seven times during the *Hajj*.[338]

The Jewish practice of the Festival of Booths is a further example of cultural expression reinforcing story. Moses established the tradition in Leviticus:

> On the fifteenth day of the seventh month, when you have gathered in the produce of the land, you shall celebrate the feast of the LORD seven days…You shall dwell in booths for seven days. All native Israelites shall dwell in booths, that your generations may know that I made the people of Israel dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt: I am the LORD your God (Lev. 23:39–43).

By dwelling in tents for seven days the Jewish nation recalled and retold an important chapter in the story of God's redemption of the nation.

Transformation of Worldview

Values, beliefs, and behaviors are readily visible in societies and often become the target of transformation. When William Carey was confronted with a culture that burned widows, for example, he naturally aspired for the transformation of that practice, and he

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[337]C. George Fry and James R. King, "Islamic Religious Practices: The Pillars of Faith," in *Encountering the World of Islam*, Keith Swartley, ed. (Colorado Springs: Biblica, 2005), 96.

[338]Alyssa Fetini, "A Brief History of the Hajj," Time World, http://content.time.com/time/world/article/0,8599,1864624,00.html#ixzz2grYuZTZJ (accessed October 7, 2013).

was right to maintain its sinfulness.[339] However, the manner in which a missionary should seek transformation of such behaviors and beliefs may not be as obvious.

Missionaries have measured conversion and discipleship in terms of orthodoxy (correct beliefs) and orthopraxy (correct behavior).[340] While behavioral and doctrinal transformations certainly should be expected, these indicators can be misleading. Further, worldview is not addressed when missionaries seek transformation by concentrating on these two indicators. Should the missionary then target worldview? Certainly worldview is the level at which transformation is desired, but achieving that transformation requires a still deeper engagement.

Worldview cannot be transformed by direct engagement, because worldview is a reflection of a more profound reality. As Wright remarks, "Worldviews are at the deepest level shorthand formulae to express stories."[341] One does not destroy the sun by attacking the moon. True transformation of worldview, and eventually culture, transpires when foundational narrative is exchanged. Lovejoy argues:

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[339]Scott Allen reports, "[William Carey] was the first man to stand against the ruthless murders and widespread oppression of women. Women in India were being crushed through polygamy, female infanticide, child marriage, widow burning, euthanasia, and forced illiteracy—all sanctioned by religion." See Scott Allen, "William Carey: A Missionary Who Transformed a Nation," *Missions Frontiers* (Sept.-Oct. 2011): 15-18.

[340]Paul Hiebert reports: "From 1542 to 1544 Francis Xavier evangelized the Paravas on the East coast of South India. For baptism he required new converts to recite after him the twelve items of the catechism, the ten commandments, a memorized prayer and a confession... Many Protestant missionaries assessed Christian faith in terms of public confessions of faith, regular church attendance, abstinence from strong drink and immoral behavior, and wearing clothes." See Hiebert, "Conversion and Worldview Transformation," 83.

[341]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

> When we tell biblical stories chronologically, we are offering a powerful alternative worldview from the very beginning of our presentation. Biblical stories and the view of the world embedded in them, can replace or refine the cultural stories and the worldview embedded in them."[342]

Similarly, Steffen contends:

> To change a people group's worldview so that Christ becomes central requires the hearing and/or seeing of stories from Scripture. Unlike some myths and stories, Bible stories find themselves rooted in history and the Supernatural. Their authenticity stands the test of time and legitimate contextualization. Through these powerful stories and our faith stories which connect them, the Holy Spirit transforms the worldviews of peoples and communities.[343]

Worldview cannot be transformed without exchanging the foundational narrative in which it is embedded. Thus, engagement must take place at the foundational narrative level. Wright asserts, "Stories thus provide a vital framework for experiencing the world. They also provide a means by which views of the world may be challenged."[344] For, as Steven Evans contends, "Storytelling in particular, is a catalyst that can bring about substantial changes in worldview, culture, and values."[345] Wright asserts:

> If stories anchor people's existing perspective on the world, then the best thing Christians can do in order to displace that perspective is to tell better stories, and we have them! Our stories must provide biblical answers to the essential questions of life. The more biblical stories people know and can fit into a single comprehensive story of God's saving work, the more completely they are able to embrace a biblical worldview. By changing their fundamental view of the world, we hope to influence a wide array of beliefs and practices which grow out of that fundamental core.[346]

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[342]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Leaners*, 34.

[343]Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry*, 32.

[344]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 39.

[345]A. Steven Evans, Matters of the Heart: Orality, Story and Cultural Transformation—The Critical Role of Storytelling in Affecting Worldview," *Missiology: An International Review* 38, no. 2 (April 2010): 185.

[346]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 37. Similarly, Jonah Sachs contends, "Stories are a universal human communication tool. They are designed to

Returning to *Figure 2,* one can clearly see the access point at which the missionary may contextually engage oral cultures with the gospel. As recitation of foundational narrative occurs naturally in cultural forms within a society, opportunity exists to insert the gospel. Here strategies of contextualization should be employed to communicate the gospel in oral cultures.[347]

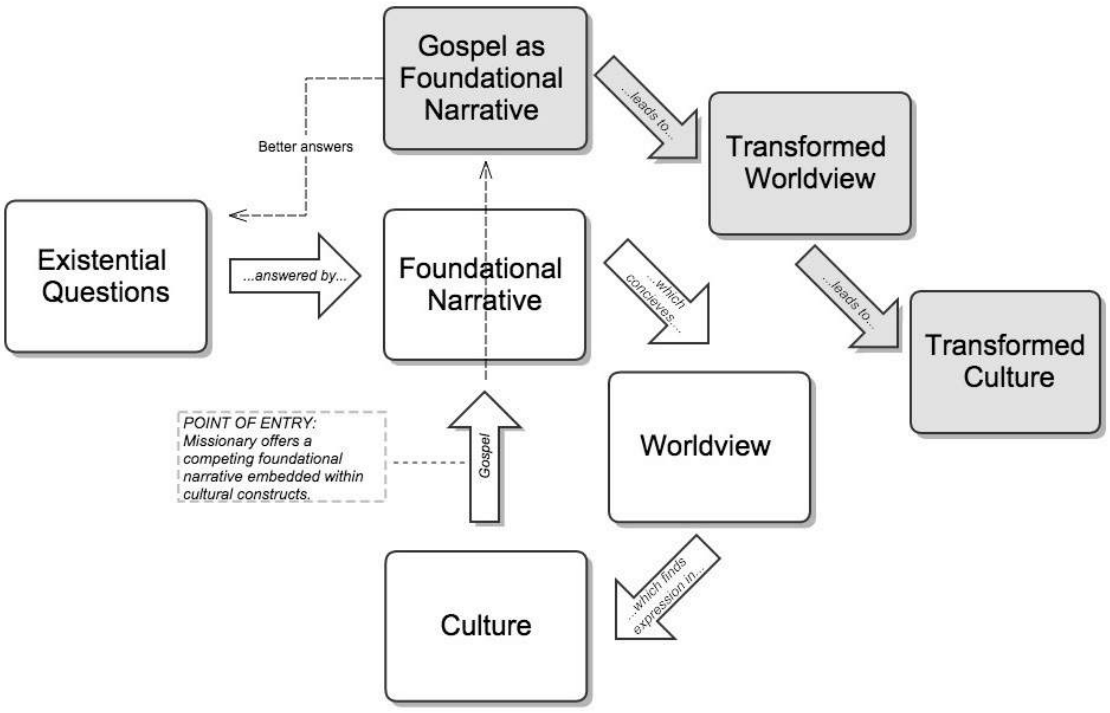

Figure 3: Transformation of Worldview

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persuade an audience of a storyteller's world view. The storyteller does this by placing characters onto a stage and showing what happens to them over a period of time. Each character pursues a goal in accordance with his or her values, facing difficulty along the way, and either succeeds or fails according to the storyteller's view of how the world works." See Sachs, *Winning the Story Wars*, Preview Booklet, http://winningthestorywars.com (accessed 11 November 2014).

[347]Hiebert asserts, "Not only must missionaries and ministers learn how to exegete humans, they must also know how to put the gospel into human contexts so that it is understood properly but does not become captive to these contexts. The gospel is not simply information to be added to current cultural understandings. It is a transforming power that changes individuals and societies into signs and witnesses of the kingdom of God. See Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 13.

When the gospel is contextually presented, oral cultures can respond without having to cross unnecessary barriers or overcome superfluous offenses and obstacles.[348] This results in a transformed foundational narrative, which leads to transformed worldview and, eventually, a transformed culture.

Conclusion

Missionaries no longer measure conversion and discipleship solely in terms of orthopraxy, as that standard of measurement was found to be deficient. While behavior is certainly important, it is deceiving as a primary indicator; and, therefore, many missionaries have since looked to orthodoxy for a more dependable measure. However, these two layers of a society do not comprise the core of culture. Culture may be compared to an iceberg. While behavior and beliefs appear above the surface of the ocean, the large hidden mass beneath the surface that holds the whole iceberg up is worldview.[349] In time, worldview will take any converted beliefs or behaviors captive. Therefore, the transformation of worldview is essential in conversion and discipleship.

Worldview, however, cannot be engaged directly because it is, in essence, a reflection of a still deeper reality—foundational narrative. The missionary must endeavor

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[348]In an email to the author on December 26, 2014 J. O. Terry shared a cogent example of situating narrative in media that is native to the culture. He related, “One disadvantage for cultural outsiders is that we often can't model well various folk art presentations. Sometimes these things happen spontaneously. In the Kulu oral Bible school project (Tell the Generations) the men had run aground trying to digest five new stories a week. So the teachers backed off to three stories a week which the men could handle learning. But there was still not the enthusiasm in telling the stories. One day a hyena happened to come near the school. The men were able to kill the hyena. Then the men began to dance and sing telling about their exploit. The teacher asked the men, ‘Why don't you sing about the Bible stories?’ The men asked, ‘Can we?’ So they began to compose story songs and sing them as they learned the new stories.”

[349]Hiebert, “Conversion and Worldview Transformation,” 84.

to transform worldview by the telling of a new and better story that more satisfactorily answers the existential questions to which all people crave answers.[350] Hesselgrave summarizes:

> How does the worldview change or "exchange" implicit in Christian conversion take place? How does one go about reconstructing a Christian worldview that has fallen upon hard times: Not first by stressing appropriate behavioral patterns or building Christian institutions. Not necessarily by enumerating Christian values or outlining the basics of a Christian worldview. Not even by taking bits and pieces, the "little stories" of the Bible and dealing only with them. Worldview change is best accomplished by studying and telling or retelling the biblical "big story" that enshrines Christian worldview. That is why…some of the most successful Christian missionizing has been done by missionaries who resorted to telling the big story that unfolds from Genesis to Revelation.[351]

Similarly, Christopher J. Wright argues:

> As has been well documented, every human worldview is an outworking of *some* narrative. We live out of the story or stories we believe to be true, the story or stories that "tell it like it is," we think. So what does it mean to live out of *this* story? Here is *The Story*, the grand universal narrative that stretches from creation to new creation, and accounts for everything in between. This is The Story that tells us where we have come from, how we got to be here, who we are, why the world is in the mess it is, how it can be (and has been) changed, and where we are ultimately going.[352]

Thus, the role of and reason for narrative in conversion and discipleship is more complex than "preference." But, what of church formation? How does foundational narrative relate to the process of creating homogenous units under the banner of the gospel?

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[350]Andy Bannister, apologist with Ravi Zacharias International Ministries, posted, "It's vital to remember that the Gospel is primarily a story; not just a set of bullet points." Andy Bannister, Twitter post, January 12, 2015 (10:07 a.m.), accessed January 30, 2015, www.twitter.com/andygbannister/status/554670894057259008.

[351]Hesselgrave, *Scripture and Strategy*, 50.

[352]Christopher J. Wright, *The Mission of God: Unlocking the Bible's Grand Narrative* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2006), 533.

Church Formation

The planting of new churches has long been a primary focus of evangelical missions. This emphasis is based on the New Testament pattern in addition to more recent impetus from church growth proponents. C. Peter Wagner, Win Arn and Elmer Towns propound, "The Great Commission implies that church planting is the primary method to evangelize the world."[353] Further, Wagner asserts, "The single most effective evangelistic methodology under heaven is planting new churches."[354]

The use of narrative in engaging oral peoples is not limited to evangelism and discipleship, but is also central to church formation. What is the role of narrative in church planting among oral learners? What is the essence of church and how do transformed foundational narratives affect it? The answer begins with the homogenous unit principle, an evangelistic concept originally proposed by Donald McGavran.

Homogenous Unit Principle

McGavran conceived of the homogenous unit principle (HUP) after years of examination of conversion trends in India. He ascertained that Indians more readily converted to Christianity when they were engaged by groups that were similar to themselves. In short, the HUP holds that people are more likely to join units with which they are homogenous. A homogenous unit is a segment of people that identifies its self as a separate entity based on a common, homogenizing factor. Homogenous units benefit

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[353]C. Peter Wagner, Win Arn and Elmer Towns, *Church Growth: State of the Art* (Wheaton, IL: Tyndale, 1988), 143.

[354]C. Peter Wagner, *Church Planting for a Greater Harvest: A Comprehensive Guide* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Publishers, 2002), 11.

from a common bond of solidarity while viewing themselves as distinct from other groups.[355]

The HUP interfaces the realities of homogenous units with the challenges of evangelism. McGavran reasoned that conversion rates will increase if cultural, racial, and linguistic barriers decrease. Conversions proliferate when the gospel is allowed to promulgate within homogenous units.

Homogenous unit theory, however, may be brought to bear beyond McGavran's original application. Homogenous unit theory may be applied further to the emergence and development of Christian communities—that is, churches. Moreover, foundational narrative is the preeminent and ideal homogenizing factor in the emergence and development and survival of churches. In fact, narrative is singularly suited for church formation because the church, in essence, is a community gathered around the sacred narrative revealed in the Scriptures.[356]

Evangelism is the crux of Donald McGavran's conception of the HUP. McGavran maintains, "Christianity ought to flow into every ethnic unit. Christ has commanded us to disciple *ta ethne* – the ethnic units of the world."[357] Furthermore, "After it has flowed in and a substantial part of the unit has been churched, the Christians, led by Christ their

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[355]C. Peter Wagner, *Our Kind of People: The Ethical Dimensions of Church Growth in America* (Louisville, KY: J. Knox Press, 1979), 64.

[356]Stan May expounds, "Worldview binds people together and provides the basic mental and cultural framework by which individuals and groups understand and respond to reality." Given that worldview is a shorthand for foundational narrative, what may was getting at was the homogenizing factor of a mutually believed foundational narrative. See May, "Cultures and Worldviews," 381.

[357]Donald A. McGavran, *Ethnic Realities and the Church* (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1979), 21.

Lord and guided by the Bible which they have accepted as their sole Scripture, purify, and beautify and transform such elements of that culture as they themselves perceive need to be transformed."[358] McGavran recognized that multitudinous barriers unnecessarily prevented people from following Jesus when missionaries create a context of conversion in which cultural, economic, or other impediments must be overcome. With the HUP McGavran aspired to help missionaries remove these impediments by allowing people to respond to Christ within a context that was familiar and comfortable, free of unnecessary barriers.

McGavran was a relentless exponent of considering sociological factors in the endeavor of people group evangelization. He states, "When we see clearly how much social structure contributes to personal and group dignity and self-esteem we will cease to pass it off as so much of a nuisance and harness its positive dynamics for the spread of the gospel."[359] McGavran, in *Understanding Church Growth*, states, "People like to become Christians without crossing racial, linguistic, or class barriers,"[360]

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[358]McGavran, *Ethnic Realities and the Church*, 21.

[359]Donald A. McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1990), 162.

[360]Ibid. The HUP has made Donald McGavran the center of much controversy, as many have considered the HUP to be essentially racist and discriminatory. These accusations, however, did not precipitate McGravran to acquiesce his position. The importance of the principle in effective evangelism could not be discarded no matter how negatively it had been perceived. For McGavran, there was too much at stake. McGavran was well aware of the dissension surrounding the principle and sought to dispel the misunderstanding in *Understanding Church Growth*. Though he did not give much attention to a rejoinder, he did call for a common sense approach to an understanding and use of the HUP. He states, "The homogenous unit principle is certainly not the heart of church growth, but nevertheless has great applicability to situations in America and other lands all around the world. Apply with common sense is the rule." See McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth*, 162.

Clarification of the Homogenous Unit Principle

Donald McGavran defines a homogenous unit as "a section of society in which all the members have some characteristic in common."[361] Charles Kraft states, "Human beings show an overwhelming predisposition to band together with 'their own kind,'" and, "People cluster with those with whom they have something in common."[362] Further, Wagner asserts, "The members of a homogenous unit think of themselves as enjoying a common bond of unity, simultaneously feeling different from others."[363] A homogenous unit can be a culture, language, tribe, caste, clan, or geographical unit.[364]

Conception of the Homogenous Unit Principle

In 1917 Cameron Townsend was in such a hurry to get to the foreign mission field that he did not bother to finish college. Once in Guatemala, Townsend comprehended the majority of Guatemala's population did not speak Spanish. As he

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[361]McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth*, 85.

[362]Charles H. Kraft, "An Anthropological Apologetic for the Homogenous Unit Principle in Missiology," *Occasional Bulletin* (October 1978): 121

[363]Wagner, *Our Kind of People*, 164.

[364]Ibid. Interestingly, the psychology community first formalized the notion that people have a natural, often unconscious, affinity for that with which they are familiar. In 1910 Edward B. Titchener documented what he referred to as the "glow of warmth" felt in the presence of something that is familiar. See E. B. Titchener, *Textbook of Psychology* (New York: Macmillan, 1910). Continued experimentation eventually led to the origination of the mere-exposure effect, pioneered by R. B. Zajonc. The mere-exposure effect is a psychological phenomenon by which people tend to develop a preference for things merely because they are familiar with them. Zajonc and subsequent researchers determined "that repeated, unreinforced exposure is sufficient to enhance attitude toward a stimulus." See Robert F. Bornstein and Paul R. D'Agostino, "Stimulus Recognition and the Mere Exposure Effect," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* Vol. 63, No. 4 (1992): 545.

travelled from village to village to distribute literature in the Spanish language, he realized that Spanish evangelism was futile in reaching the majority of Guatemala's people. His concern turned to conviction when an indigenous man inquired, "If your God is so smart, why can't he speak our language?"[365]

At age 23 he began to strategize and work based on the idea that people should not be segmented based on geo-political borders, but by cultural homogeneity. Townsend tirelessly advocated for the unreached frontiers made up of overlooked tribal peoples across the globe. Frustrated by lack of interest from existing boards, Townsend ended up establishing his own mission, Wycliffe Bible Translators, which continues to be dedicated to engaging new frontiers.[366]

At the same time Townsend was contemplating in Guatemala, Donald McGavran was beginning to recognize the significance of India's social barriers. He realized that a greater number of people would convert to Christianity if they were allowed to do so within the constraints of the caste system. McGavran championed a universal category he labeled "homogenous units." Today, homogenous units are called "people groups."[367]

Assessment of the Homogenous Unit Principle in Evangelism

The legitimacy of the homogenous unit principle has been evinced by verified outcomes in an array of cultural contexts. Wagner reasons, "Where Christianity is taking root in different nations and cultures of the world, it seems to develop most vigorously

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[365]Ralph D. Winter, "Four Men, Three Eras, Two Transitions: Modern Missions," in *Perspectives on the World Christian Movement* 3rd edition (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1999), 260.

[366]Winter, "Four Men, Three Eras, Two Transitions," 260.

[367]Ibid.

when it is allowed or even encouraged to grow in specific homogenous units rather than forced to include different groups."[368]

In the 1970s Donald Hohensee reported that Christian churches flourished among the Hutu and the Tutsi in Burundi, but converts among a third group, the Twa, were negligible. The Twa, a despised race of pygmies, were not permitted to form their own homogenous fellowships, but they were instead forced to join the Hutu or Tutsi groups.[369] Abundant missiological research has shown that evangelistic efforts are more effective when converts are recruited for membership into groups that are culturally homogenous with the convert's culture.[370]

McGavran was the recipient of much ire and accusation because of the HUP. What many failed to understand was the fact that McGavran was endorsing an evangelistic tool. Further, most assumed that *homogenous* indicated only race and surmised that McGavran entertained a race agenda. Peter Wagner eloquently responds to this accusation:

> Homogenous congregations, when they are formed voluntarily and when they are open to all others who wish to become members, possess an intrinsic integrity as Christian communities. Rather than being denounced, they should be celebrated. Rather than being perceived as being the causes of racism and discrimination, they should be seen as one of the most viable institutions for healing social ills.[371]

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[368]Wagner, *Our Kind of People*, 11.

[369]Donald Hohensee, *Church Growth in Burundi* (South Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1977), 132.

[370]Japanese churches in Brazil (Mizuki, 1976 73, 131); Bolivian Aymaras (Nordyke, 1972, 141); Quichuas in Ecuador (Klassen, 1975); Hakka of Taiwan (Liao, 1972, 60, 96); Enga of New Guinea (Spruth, 1973, 351-352); Angamis of Nagaland (Cunville, 1975, 101); High caste Hindus of India (Subbama, 1970, 53-86); Caste churches in Madras (Cornelius, 1971, 136); Muslims in Pakistan (Winter, 1975, 224).

[371]C. Peter Wagner, "How Ethical is the Homogenous Unit Principle?," *Occaisional Bulletin* (January 1978): 12.

Foundational Narrative as Homogenizing Factor

Homogenous units are conventionally pictured as being bound by race, language, nationality, or culture. These divisions irrefutably produce homogenous units. The aforementioned homogenizing factors are effectual architects of self-recognized, idiosyncratic communities. Recognition of these demarcations is particularly valuable in the process of pre-evangelism and evangelism.

Homogenous groups, however, hinge upon more nuanced unifying factors as well. A vast number of factors exist that have the potential of producing common bonds between individuals, and some of these factors transcend culture, nationality, and race. One especially compelling begetter and sustainer of community is foundational narrative. Bruce Seymour states, "One way to think about culture is to think of it as a group of people who share similar stories."[372]

Definition of Foundational Narrative and Community

No society is without its foundational narrative. Foundational narrative examines beginnings, considered to be sacred, and seeks to answer questions of the existential sort. Questions about origin, purpose, suffering, and pain find their remedy in these narratives.[373]

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[372]D. Bruce Seymour, *Creating Stories that Connect* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Publishing, 2007), 29.

[373]A distinction is often made between "myth" and "folktale." The former deals with universal, existential questions, and are considered sacred. The latter are stories told by the common people for entertainment and value communication.

By providing answers to the fundamental questions of life the foundational narrative gives societies the means by which to make sense of the world. Bruce Bradshaw explains, "Narratives are both the templates through which we interpret reality and the means through which we seek continuity in our lives. They emerge from our history and we could not tolerate life without them."[374]

"Community" may be phrased in a number of ways. The terms "homogenous unit," "culture," or "people group" are commonly utilized. The terms "church" and "community" will be employed here to describe the sociological phenomenon in which a group of individuals band together, based on common characteristics.[375] Communities think of themselves as partaking in a common bond of unity, while concurrently being conscious of excluding outsiders.[376]

Foundational Narrative and Community

Stories create communities.[377] Gathering around foundational narrative through belief and retelling is a vehicle of relationship and community formation.[378] Shared myth homogenizes disparate individuals to form communities. Peter Feinman maintains:

> The venue may vary, the technology may change, the message evolves, but somehow, in some way, we will tell stories. They define who we are as

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[374]Bradshaw, *Change Across Culture*, 21.

[375]See McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth*, 85; and Kraft, "An Anthropological Apologetic," 121.

[376]Wagner, *Our Kind of People*, 164.

[377]Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry*, 33.

[378]Joseph Sobol, John S. Gentile, & Sunwolf, "Once Upon a Time: An Introduction to the Inaugural Issue" *Storytelling, Self, Society: An Interdisciplinary Journal of Storytelling Sudies*, 1.1 (2004): 3.

> individuals and as members of something larger than ourselves, a family, a community, a country, a state, a country, or a religion.[379]

Thomas Boomershine writes, "Storytelling creates community…And men and women who know the same stories deeply are bound together in special ways."[380] Moreover, Kendall Haven asserts that shared myth creates, "a sense of belonging, a personal commitment to the organization, and a feeling of community."[381] Bruce Seymour notes, "[I]t is almost always a story that binds us together and makes us one."[382]

Foundational narrative is patently important in the formation of religious communities. Tom Steffen observes, "Buddhism, Islam, Hinduism, Judaism, Christianity —all use stories to expand (and limit) membership, assure ongoing generational conversion, and bring disciples to maturation."[383] John Navone and Thomas Cooper argue, "There can be no community life, no consensus, and thus no common action without participation in a common understanding of the meaning of a common story and without a common commitment to that story's value."[384]

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[379]Peter Feinman, "Community Narratives: The Importance of Storytelling," on *The New York History Blog*. http://newyorkhistoryblog.org/2013/03/26/community-narratives-the-importance-of-story-telling/ (Accessed April 29, 2014).

[380]Thomas E. Boomershine, *Story Journey: An Invitation to Gospel as Storytelling* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1988), 18.

[381]Kendall Haven, *Story Proof: The Science Behind the Startling Power of Story* (Westport, CT: Libraries Unlimited, 2007), 111.

[382]Seymour, *Creating Stories that Connect*, 30.

[383]Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry*, 32.

[384]John Navone and Thomas Cooper, *Tellers of the Word* (New York: Le Jacq Publishing, 1981), 248.

Foundational narrative plays a fundamental and ongoing role in the formation of community. It is "a medium of connectivity and community."[385] Indeed, it is difficult to overstate the role of foundational narrative in the homogenization of individuals and preservation of communities. Why is myth such an indelible factor in community?

Foundational Narrative and the Formation of Community

Oral societies, according to Lovejoy, are "relational, group-oriented, face-to-face cultures."[386] Ong contends that primarily oral cultures have more robust communities, which is in large part due to the fact that oral cultures share, process, and preserve information through the telling of stories one to another. They homogenize because "oral communication unites people in groups."[387]

The very nature of human sound is community-producing. Ong explains, "Because in its physical constitution as sound, the spoken word proceeds from the human interior and manifests human beings to one another as conscious interiors, as persons, the spoken word forms human beings into close-knit groups."[388] Unity is achieved when a speaker is addressing an audience verbally, but that unity is shattered when the speaker directs the audience to read privately, only to be recaptured once verbal address recommences.

Oral communication engenders homogenization among more extensive groups also. Ong notes, "The spoken word forms unities on a large scale, too: countries with two

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[385]Sobol, "Once Upon a Time," 3.

[386]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of oral Learners*, 5.

[387]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 67.

[388]Ibid., 72.

or more different spoken languages are likely to have major problems in establishing or maintaining national unity, as today in Canada or Belgium or many developing countries."[389]

Thus, oral cultures are predisposed toward community due to the nature of oral communication. However, prevalent oral communication alone is not sufficient to produce enduring homogenization. A shared myth, on the other hand, is. A common foundational narrative works to form community by creating common identity, ensuring strength and survival, providing access to learning and knowing, and offering a mechanism for the interpretation and application of experience.

Identity

"People become the stories they tell," asserts Thomas Boomershine.[390] Human beings are storytelling creatures. This fundamental characteristic of humanity was expressed well by Fisher's appellation *homo narrans*.[391] The stories humans tell each other and themselves have an important function: to make meaning of our experience and existence. Humans shape their experience into significance through stories. As those stories accrue, individuals form a personal and communal identity. Jefferson Singer argues:

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[389]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 72.

[390]Boomershine, *Story Journey*, 19. Further, Clark and Rossiter contend, "Narrative is also how we craft our sense of self, our identity." See M. Carolyn Clark and Marsha Rossiter, "Narrative Learning in Adulthood," *New Directions for Adult and Continuing Education*, 119 (Fall 2009): 61-70.

[391]Walter R. Fisher, *Human Communication as Narration: Toward a Philosophy of Reason, Value, and Action* (Columbia, SC: University of South Carolina Press, 1989).

> To understand the identity formation process is to understand how individuals craft narratives from experiences, tell these stories internally and to others, and ultimately apply these stories to knowledge of self, other, and the world in general.[392]

People construct and lean into a personal story by which all of life is interpreted and maneuvered. These stories "provide the anchor with which we root our life."[393] This phenomenon transpires to form communities. Paul Hiebert states:

> Personal stories take on greater meaning when they become part of the larger stories of a community of people. For example, Genesis 12 marks the beginning of the people of Israel. Thereafter, Israelites found their identity in belonging to a particular tribe, and, above all, to God's chosen people. They told and retold the stories of great individuals, such as Abraham, Moses, Deborah, and David whose lives gave shape to their nation.[394]

Bruce Seymour contends, "One way to think about culture is to think of it as a group of people who share similar stories."[395] Americans, for example, share kindred narratives of immigration, hard work and achieving success, war for independence, and westward expansion. These national narratives aid Americans in interpreting life experiences in analogous manners.[396] Similarly, Gilbert Brown records, "Navajo children can find who they are through listening to and learning the stories of the sacred mountains of the Navajo Nation."[397] Richard Couto notes the important function of

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[392]Jefferson A. Singer, "Narrative Identity and Meaning Making Across the Adult Lifespan: An Introduction," *Journal of Personality* 72:3 (June 2004): 438.

[393]Feinman, "Community Narratives."

[394]Paul G. Hiebert, R. Daniel Shaw, and Tite Tienou, *Understanding Folk Religion* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2000).

[395]Seymour, *Creating Stories that Connect*, 29.

[396]Ibid.

[397]Gilbert Brown, "Finding Identity through Oral Stories," (Unpublished Document) http://www.u.arizona.edu/~tmw/gilbertsfinal.pdf (accessed April 29, 2014).

shared history among African-Americans in their struggle for justice. He states, "The more marginal and powerless a group is, the more important is its own history as self-definition."[398]

Indeed, stories shape identity of both individuals and communities simultaneously. Mechal Beth Dinkler affirms, "Stories are sites of contestation and negotiation, functioning within the discursive practices of communities to shape both the communities themselves and the individuals within them."[399] Story creates community because it is through story that communities, or "villages," establish identity. John Berger affirms, "A village's portrait of itself is constructed, not out of stone, but of words, spoken and remembered: out of opinions, stories, eyewitness reports, legends, comments and hearsay."[400] This identification through shared narrative hinges upon the storied-structure of worldviews. Identity and community are bound up in shared narrative.

Strength and Survival

Psychologists Marshall and Sarah Duke have conducted extensive research on the resilience of the most critical group embedded within cultures, namely the family. They aspired to determine the factor(s) that produced resilient families with the capacity to handle crises, both internal and external. They discovered the more children know about their family's history, or narrative, the stronger their locus of control, the higher their

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[398]Richard Couto, *Ain't Gonna Let Nobody Turn Me Round: The Pursuit of Racial Justice in the Rural South* (Philadelphia, PA: Temple University Press, 1992), 9.

[399]Mechal Beth Dinkler, "Telling Transformation: How We Redeem Narratives and Narratives Redeem Us," *Word & World* 31:3 (Summer 2011): 290.

[400]John Berger, "The Storyteller," in *The Sense of Sight*, ed. Lloyd Spencer (New York: Pantheon Books, 1985), 16.

self-esteem, and the more positively they view their family unit.[401] As family members cluster around a unified narrative, they grow stronger and have an enhanced chance of survival; so it is with larger communities. Feinman asserts, "A community with no narrative to tell doesn't survive as a community."[402] Feinman draws upon the military's realization that group narrative and group strength relate closely. He reports:

> The military not only focuses on communal activities, at West Point the plebes learn the history of their unit and service, visiting the cemeteries, seeing the historical artifacts, becoming part of the history of the organization which they have joined. The military knows the importance of telling a story."[403]

Shared community narrative maintains group solidarity, especially in times of difficulty in which cohesion of the group may be threatened. Couto notes:

> Human beings acquire and impart truth by stories. The people … are presented as narrators of stories about the truth of their conditions and their efforts … These stories, traditions, and values are the history of a group that hold them together and separates them from others. The more marginal and powerless a group is, the more important is its own history as self-definition.[404]

Feinman agrees, stating, "Whether it is through the dimension of our mind creating the stories…or the stories we tell breaking bread and matzoh on Easter and Passover, or the stories we observe on Thanksgiving and July 4th, they define us and make us strong enough to survive."[405] Even organizations utilize the sustaining power of shared narrative to fend off disunity and defection. Rob Gill states, "the use of storytelling as an employee

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[401]Bruce Feiler, "The Stories that Bind Us," *The New York Times* http://www.nytimes.com/2013/03/17/fashion/the-family-stories-that-bind-us-this-life.html?pagewanted=all&_r=0 (accessed April 29, 2014).

[402]Feinman, "Community Narratives."

[403]Ibid.

[404]Couto, *Ain't Gonna Let Nobody Turn Me Round*, 9.

[405]Feinman, "Community Narratives."

engagement strategy can more effectively contribute to maintaining staff loyalty beyond traditional internal communication, particularly during periods of organizational change."[406]

Learning and Knowing

Foundational narrative provides a powerful context for both learning and storing data. Information about the group's origin, history, purpose, and future is retained in its narrative. Gilbert Brown, speaking about the preservation of Navajo culture, notes, "Native stories have a purpose because it provides continuum of connections to place and ancestors. Native oral stories bring forth narratives of the ancestors and place."[407]

Learning takes place through the vicarious experience of hearing stories. Seymour remarks, "When we hear a story, the experience described in the story becomes part of our experience, and the meaning becomes part of our wisdom. Through a story, we can imaginatively enter into a very different world, shift to a different viewpoint, and begin to experience what someone else has experienced."[408] Tex Sample relates, "People learn to identify with the feelings of others by living through similar situations with them (sharing their story)."[409]

When an individual identifies with a story he empathetically experiences the events therein. Engaging in narrative is an experiential learning process that involves

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[406]Rob Gill, "Using Storytelling to Maintain Employee Loyalty during Change," *International Journal of Business and Social Science* 2, no. 15 (August 2011), 23.

[407]Brown, "Finding Identity through Oral Stories," 8.

[408]Seymour, *Creating Stories that Connect*, 31.

[409]Sample, *Ministry in an Oral Culture*, 36.

cognitive, affective, and behavioral functions of learning. When one reflects on story he creates meaning from them and acts upon them. Susan Shaw comments, "This experience creates space for the learners to learn from the story's experience as if they had actually participated in it — which they have, imaginatively, through the story."[410]

Interpretation and Application

Stories are not only remembered and retold within the context of community, but they are also interpreted and applied to human existence and experience in community.[411] Michal Beth Dinkler writes, "Stories draw people to face one another and enable us to structure, interpret, and reflect on the vagaries of human experience together."[412] Similarly, Justo Gonzalez explains his position concerning the proper context for interpretation of the Christian narrative:

> Without such a perspective, interpreters fall into I-hermeneutics, which fails, not merely because it misinterprets the text, but also because it misinterprets the task. The task of hermeneutics is not merely for an individual — or even for a

[410]Susan Shaw, *Storytelling in Religious Education* (Birmingham, AL: Religions Education Press, 1999), 54.

[411]Sarah Zielinski reports, "In 1921, a man named James M. Mitchell visited the Henbury site with an Aboriginal guide who refused to go near the depressions, saying the place was where a fire "debil-debil" (devil) had come out of the sky and killed everything. Thirteen years later, Mitchell returned. By then, the astronomical connection had been made—a prospector found iron slugs in the craters in 1931—but Mitchell's new Aboriginal guide again expressed fear of the site. He said that his people wouldn't camp within two miles of the depressions, get closer than half a mile or collect the water that filled some. A fire devil would fill them with iron should they dare. The guide knew this, he said, because his grandfather had seen the fire devil come from the sun. Hamacher found similar tales that other Aboriginal people told to visitors in the first half of the 20th century." See Sarah Zielinski, "To Find Meteorites, Listen to the Legends Australian Aborigenes," Smithsonian.com, http://www.smithsonianmag.com/science-nature/find-meteorites-listen-legends-australian-aborigines (accessed 11 November 2014).

[412]Dinkler, "Telling Transformation," 289.

> community — to understand a text, but it is even more for building the community.[413]

Thus, the interpretation of sacred narratives functions as a builder of community. Interpretation of the story upon which the community is built and gathered ought to be undertaken with the idea that the story belongs not to any individual but to the community itself, "and at the end no one knows who first proposed a particular idea."[414]

As the narrative is recalled within the community the listener is not a passive participant simply absorbing the story but rather the listener provides an alternative point of view, bringing to bear personal experience. The listeners' perspectives influence how the story is interpreted and applied.[415] In this way the foundational narrative of a community is retold, reinterpreted, and reapplied; and it is through this process that each new member of the community is grafted in. When one apprehends the community narrative, leans into it, and applies it to one's own experience, conversion is achieved.

Inherently Social

Bruce Seymour states, "Stories are intrinsically relational, because every story involves at least two people, a teller and a listener."[416] Telling and listening to oral stories engenders a shared experience.[417] The act of narrating stories creates an atmosphere

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[413]Justo L. Gonzalez, *Out of Every Tribe and Nation: Christian Theology at the Ethnic Roundtable* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1992), 54.

[414]Gonzalez, *Out of Every Tribe*, 53.

[415]Seymour, *Creating Stories that Connect*, 30.

[416]Ibid.

[417]Tracy Coskie, Heidi Trudel, and Rosemary Vohs, "Creating Community through Storytelling," *Talking Points* 22, no. 1 (October 2010): 4.

where the narrator shapes important relationships through the potency of words. Thus, in sharing stories, new relationships are forged.[418] Stories told necessitate an audience and people who share stories with each other become friends.[419] People who know the same stories are connected to each other in unique ways.[420]

Storytelling is different than reading a book, for it exhibits its own unique dynamics. "Storytelling is fun, engaging, spontaneous, and playful…Everyone loves a good story."[421] Tracy Coskie notes, "With storytelling, rather than the focus being on an external object (a book or prized possession), the focus becomes the speaking-listening relationship."[422]

When persons experience and identify with the same stories, new and powerful connections are established, "and the deeper the meaning of the story, the deeper are the relationships that are formed by the hearing."[423] Stories are naturally relational in that they have the ability to deepen relationships and create community through what Kevin Brandt refers to as, "the interdependent transaction of storying."[424]

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[418]A. H. Dyson and C. Genishi, *The Need for Story: Cultural Diversity in Classroom and Community* (Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English, 1994), 5.

[419]Feinman, "Community Narratives."

[420]Boomershine, *Story Journey*, 18.

[421]Ibid.

[422]Coskie, "Creating Community through Storytelling," 4.

[423]Boomershine, *Story Journey*, 19.

[424]Kevin M. Brandt, *Story as a Way of Knowing* (Kansas City, MO: Sheed & Ward, 1997), 11.

Church as Community Bound by Story

Religion, the quintessential expression of culture, is indelibly bound up in worldview. Further, narrative constitutes the core of every culture's worldview. N.T. Wright states, "[Stories] are, in fact, one key element within the total construction of worldview. Stories thus provide a vital framework for experiencing the world."[425] Similarly, Grant Lovejoy reports, "A culture houses its central convictions in its fundamental narrative, whether its narrative is implicit or explicit. The ancient mythologies that we find in cultures around the world are explicit examples of this."[426]

The religion, worldview, and mythology of a culture make up an entangled ravel. It is impossible to extract one without wrenching the others. Thus, the foundational narrative, or mythology, of a culture plays a fundamental role in its religion. Dinkler remarks, "Indeed, we might say that stories are a prerequisite for religion; most religious traditions can trace their origins to a rich repository of stories, parables, myths, and legends."[427]

The Nature and Purpose of the Church

The church is a community, a homogenous unit. Communities think of themselves as partaking in a common bond of unity, while concurrently being conscious of excluding outsiders.[428] Wright asserts, "The church is first and foremost a *community,*

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[425]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 39.

[426]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 33.

[427]Dinkler, "Telling Transformation," 287.

[428]Wagner, *Our Kind of People*, 164.

a collection of people who belong to one another because they belong to God, the God she knows in and through Jesus."[429]

The church is a community gathered in faith around the sacred story of God as revealed in the Old and New Testaments. Scott McClellan states, "The church is a "community rooted in the story of God and indwelled by His Spirit."[430] Though the church is constituted of unique individuals, it is coalesced by the gospel story and its transforming power. The church gathers together around the sacred story for the purpose of celebrating and worshiping the Author. Morality is not enough to unite it, and obligation is not enough to affect it. The community must be captivated by the sacred story. McClellan explains:

> As we are transformed by God's story, we gather around it, and as we gather around God's story, we are transformed by it. We celebrate the story and we mine it and we wrestle it. We tell it to each other and to our children and to our neighbors. The effect of this story community is a kind of slow, covert magic—a few years go by and you realize, you can't truly tell your own story without mentioning God and Jesus and all those people who walked with you. You realize that word—enjoined—has just happened somewhere along the way. You're in community.[431]

The church is a community of people reborn through story, and it exists to proclaim that story in order that others may be reborn into the community—the church. McClellan affirms, "In the church, the story of God fosters community, and community

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[429]N. T. Wright, *Simply Christian: Why Christianity Makes Sense* (New York: Harpers Collins, 2006), 210.

[430]McClellan, *Tell Me a Story*, 127.

[431]Ibid., 126.

bears witness to the story."[432] The church is a collective troupe of storyers who bear witness to the gospel story first and foremost through word, but also through deed.

Conversion, Limitation, and Maturation

Christian churches, as in homogenous units, not only share a common bond of unity through story, but they also see themselves as distinct from other groups as a result of the exclusivity of their story. Indeed, all major religions lean upon their foundational narrative to indoctrinate subsequent generations as well as mature converts. Steffen observes, "Buddhism, Islam, Hinduism, Judaism, Christianity —all use stories to expand (and limit) membership, assure ongoing generational conversion, and bring disciples to maturation."[433]

Christian communities employ stories to distinguish true members from false members, orthodoxy from heresy, and admissible behavior from inadmissible.[434] Navone and Cooper assert, "Every society has limits to its tolerance for the diversity of its members' interpretations of its common (foundational) story."[435] Reconcilable understandings or interpretations are tolerated and admitted within the Christian church. The church "acknowledges the legitimate variations in the interpretations of its story and

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[432]McClellan, *Tell Me a Story*, 124.

[433]Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry*, 32. Further, when Paul evangelized both Jews and Gentiles, he utilized relevant stories to explain the gospel and call for response. "Unbelieving Jews heard about cultural heroes such as Abraham, Moses, and David (Acts 13:13-43). Unbelieving Gentiles heard about the powerful God behind both the creation story and the final judgment (Acts 14:8-18; 17:16-34)."

[434]Ibid., 33.

[435]Navone, *Tellers of the Word*, 253.

repudiates those interpretations it judges to be a betrayal of its true meaning."[436] Limits of interpretation must be placed upon the church in regards to the foundational story in order to preserve homogeneity. Without conceded limits, the church's foundational story fails to retain meaning and the community ceases to exist.

That is why from very early in Christian history teachers have placed particular emphasis on an apprehension of the foundational story by adherents. Origen contended that those who desired to follow Christ must become familiar with the unfolding historical drama of Scripture immediately. Similarly, Augustine focused on imparting the unfolding narrative of Scripture. He made use of a comprehensive catechism that conveyed the comprehensive sweep of Scripture; this he referred to as "Salvation History."[437]

Myth, Symbol, and Ritual

Symbol and ritual hold important roles in the identification with and indoctrination into religious groups by reaffirming and retelling the foundational story. Steffen reports, "The Israelites were experts in the use of story, symbol, and ritual to maintain their distinctive identity in a very diverse and often oppositional world."[438]

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[436]Navone, *Tellers of the Word*, 254.

[437]Steffen, "The Sweeping Story of Scripture Taught Through Time," 317. Further, Augustine held that since the coming of Christ occurred on a timeline in history, the overarching narrative must be taught to new believers so that they may fully appreciate the gospel.

[438]Steffen, *Reconnecting God's Story to Ministry*, 33.

Bradshaw avers, "Rituals are symbolic actions through which people restore and maintain the non-discursive meanings of their symbols and relate to their agents of causation."[439]

Paul Hiebert explains, "Symbols are mental categories humans create and label to grasp and order the realities in which they live."[440] Symbols function in close harmony with the foundational stories from which they find their genesis.[441] As a group gathers around its myth, it extricates symbols—a sort of shorthand or abbreviated narrative—that become representations of the myth itself. Symbols embody the narrative.

The cross of Jesus of Nazareth came to be an important, non-discursive symbol within the Christian community. The significance of the symbol of the cross extends far beyond the immediate, historical significance of an instrument of capital punishment. Bradshaw comments, "The discursive meaning of the cross can be verified by the historical documents of the first century. However, its non-discursive meaning transcends historical verification; it depends on the affirmation of the community that organizes itself around this meaning."[442]

Jay Moon states, "Symbols are the building blocks…of rituals."[443] David Burnett defines rituals as the "visible demonstrations of the religious beliefs of a people."[444] A common conception is that people practice rituals for the sole purpose of manipulating

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[439]Bradshaw, *Change Across Cultures*, 223.

[440]Hiebert, *Understanding Folk Religion*, 306.

[441]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 365.

[442]Bradshaw, *Change Across Cultures*, 223.

[443]W. Jay Moon, "Rituals and Symbols in Community Development," *Missiology: An International Review* XL, no. 2 (April 2012): 145.

[444]David Burnett, *Unearthly Powers* (Nashville, TN: Oliver Nelson, 1992), 93.

power to achieve desired ends. This view is especially held in the context of primal and folk religions. Bradshaw, however, contends, "The efficacy of any ritual does not lie in the power to cause empirically verifiable changes."[445] Rather, the power of ritual is found it its ability to locate "the pains of life—such as fertility, illness, and misfortune—within the context of a community's narrative. In empowering people to cope with these pains, rituals absorb the struggles of life, restoring the harmony between the person, the community, and its narrative."[446]

Rituals fulfill their purpose when they effectively affirm the symbols that bring into the view the foundational story of the community. The foundational narrative provides answers to the questions that the community is asking. Through ritual, the community is able to integrate transition into the narrative of the community, affirming the redeeming value found therein. Bradshaw expounds:

> "[Rituals] serve three related functions that make them central in building community. First, they legitimize the nature of the symbols of any particular community; second, they establish the order that governs the relationship between the community and symbols; and third, they prescribe change. In serving these functions, rituals create a unified scheme where everything has a place; they integrate disparate symbols into a unified narrative.[447]

The Lord's Supper, a primary ritual in the Christian church, is an instructive example of ritual affirming symbols that recall core mythology. McClellan explains:

> Communion, or the Eucharist, is an inherently communal practice, at the center of which Jesus placed both His story and our mandate to be storytellers. First, there's His story: He explains the bread and the cup are His body and blood given for us. Then there's the storyteller imperative: we are to partake of the bread and the cup

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[445]Bradshaw, *Change Across Cultures*, 226.

[446]Ibid.

[447]Ibid., 223.

> in *remembrance* of Him. To remember is to tell, either out loud or in the quiet of our own hearts, the story that brings us to the table in the first place.[448]

Conclusion

Homogenous unit theory has broader application than evangelism. Christian churches are, in essence, homogenous units, and the specifications of what Christian churches should share in common is important. The foundational narrative of Scripture is uniquely suited to create community. Further, the very essence of church is a group of people who are homogenized by a common experience of redemption through Jesus Christ. This redemption has been handed down in the form of story, and it is a common belief and vestment in this story that creates healthy, vibrant, and enduring communities of faith. Churches are only as strong as their commitment to and memory of the gospel story. Thus, symbols and rituals are employed as a means to continually reinforce and retell the central faith story.

[448]McClellan, *Tell Me a Story*, 124.

Chapter 4

The Orality Framework in Context

In chapter three the extensive effect of orality, especially narrative, in the processes of evangelism, discipleship, and church formation was plainly presented. Insights into the orality framework, however, should not remain in the realm of scholarly reflection. If Lovejoy is correct in his estimation that 5.7 billion people in the world today live within an oral framework, then application of orality insights to mission philosophy, strategy, and methodology is simply due diligence. As Lovejoy relates, "Ministries who adjust their approach to the literacy level of their group, whatever that level may be, can expect improved communication, more learning, and more life change among the hearers."[449] Similarly, Jack Colgate reports, "Teams who understand the learning preferences (whether oral or literate) of their people group and incorporate this into team strategy were more fruitful (in terms of numbers of fellowships planted) by 340 percent!"[450] Regrettably, more than 90 percent of resources for evangelism, discipleship,

[449]Lovejoy, "Extent of Orality Update," 30. Further, Lovejoy reports, "Extensive research among Christian outreach in Muslim communities found that incorporating an oral communication strategy into their work with oral cultures was associated with seeing 4.4 times more churches established." See the technical data article on the CD that is included with J. Dudley Woodberry, ed., *From Seed to Fruit*, 2nd ed., (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Press, 2011).

[450]Jack Colgate, "Bible Storying and Oral Use of the Scriptures," in *From Seed to Fruit*, 2nd ed. J. Dudley Woodberry, ed. (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Press, 2011), 221.

and leadership development are produced by textual persons for textual persons, leaving little emphasis placed on the majority of the world's peoples.[451]

In this chapter case studies are presented for analysis in light of the orality framework. These case studies provide examples of seeing cultures through "oral eyes." The key to engaging oral cultures is to first comprehend oral characteristics, and then to tease out the forms that those characteristics take in any given oral context. Once these two important steps are taken, then the third step of contextualizing the gospel message can take place.[452]

Three oral milieus exist. Primary orality describes an oral context in which visual representation of spoken language is unknown.[453] Residual orality refers to societies where literacy has been introduced and integrated but where orality remains the primary framework in which people process and image information. Secondary orality labels traditionally textual societies that have transitioned into an oral framework due to the effects of pervasive communication technologies.

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[451]M. David Sills, *Reaching and Teaching the Highland Quichuas: Ministry in an Animistic Oral Context* (Louisville, KY: Reaching and Teaching International Ministries, 2012), 8.

[452]Darrell Whiteman explains, "Contextualization attempts to communicate the Gospel in word and deed and to establish the church in ways that make sense to people within their local context, presenting Christianity in such a way that it meets people's deepest needs and penetrates their worldview, thus allowing them to follow Christ and remain within their own culture. See Darrell Whiteman, "Contextualization: The Theory, The Gap, The Challenge," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 22, no. 1 (January 1997): 2-7.

[453]John D. Harvey reports, "The discussion of the transition from primary orality to primary literacy has been approached from at least three different perspectives…He approaches the question using the grid of literacy and proposes a continuum which begins with pre-literate culture and extends through craft-literacy, recitation-literacy, and script-literacy to type-literate culture." See Harvey, "Orality and its Implications for Biblical Studies: Recapturing an Ancient Paradigm."

Primary Orality: The Motilone Indians[454]

The current population of the Motilone Indians is 7,600, residing in Colombia, Venezuela, and the United States. The Joshua Project reports that they are 70.6 percent Christian and 19.6 percent evangelical.[455] Until the 1960s the Motilone tribe existed apart from the outside world, fiercely resisting foreign encroachment for the first half of the 20th century. Contact between the Motilone and outsiders came "in the form of arrows."[456] In fact no foreigner spoke the Motilone language, nor could anyone describe their physical culture with any detail.

This extreme resistance to outside contact was due, at least in part, to the fact that they harbored the memory of violence perpetrated by outsiders. In 1691 Capuchin priests sent by King Maracaibo began a concerted effort to convert the heathen tribe. They did manage to establish a community within Motilone borders, but their efforts were buttressed by sheer military force. In 1733 a Spanish force captured 26 Motilones. Their fate is unknown. In 1765, in response to Spanish oppression, the Motilones attacked the town of Maracaibo and were met by counterattacking priests and colonists. In 1767 a Spanish expeditionary attachment entered Motilone territory, triumphantly returning with

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[454]*Motilone* is a derivative of the Spanish world *motilar*, or "cut hair." Spanish settlers arriving in the early 1600s in Colombia and Venezuela began calling the tribe *Motilone* because of the their short hair. This word does not exist in the tribe's vocabulary. Rather, they know themselves as the *Barí*, which means "we the people." The tribe, however, is accepting of *Motilone* as well as the use of *Indian*. See the editor's note in Bruce Olson, *Bruchko and the Motilone Miracle* (Lake Mary, FL: Charisma House Publising, 2006), xi.

[455]Motilone, Joshua Project (http://joshuaproject.net/people_groups/13833).

[456]Bruce Olson, *Bruchko and the Motilone Miracle* (Lake Mary, FL: Charisma House Publishing, 2006), 4.

27 Motilone prisoners after a few months. Nikolas Kozlaff reports, "Though most of them perished within a few days, one young child survived. He was placed under the care of the Maracaibo's treasurer, José Sebastián Guillén."[457] Thus, when Bruce Olson stumbled into their territory in 1961, the Motilones had good reason to demonstrate fierce opposition.

The Motilone tribe was an isolated, animistic people. Their language had never been reduced to writing, and their exposure to the technologies of literacy was negligible; thus, they were a primary oral society. Primary oral folk are those who are "totally unfamiliar with writing," and "who have never 'seen' a word."[458] Olson's account of his work among the Motilone tribe provides an illuminating view into the orality framework of primary oral groups.

In 1961, a very young and inexperienced Bruce Olson made his way toward Motilone territory. After spending some time with the Yuko, a neighboring tribe, he sought a contingency of men from among them to guide him to the Motilone. "I began going from tribe to tribe, trying to get someone to take me…In each tribe it was always 'someone else' who might take me."[459] Finally, after promising a young Yuko man a zipper, Olson was able to gather a group to accompany him.

After six days of a grinding pace over mountain and jungle trails, the small group approached Motilone territory. As they approached the infamous tribe's territory the Yuko men became increasingly quiet. Olson tells what happened next:

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[457]Nikolas Kozlaff, "Venezuela State Policy Towards Motilón Indians: From Isolation to First Contact," *E.I.A.L* 17, no. 2 (2006), 8-9.

[458]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 119.

[459]Olson, *Bruchko*, 67.

> Suddenly all the Yukos stopped and raised their heads as if to sniff the wind. They stood like statues. I hadn't heard a sound, but stood still, too, listening to my breath come hard and loud—too loud, I thought. I heard nothing else.
>
> Then, as if in one motion, all the Yukos broke into a run, back the way we had come. I stood stunned for a moment, then, clumsily, ran after them, wondering what I was running for. I ran straight into some vines, tripped and fell flat on my face, scrambled up and got tangled in the vines again. Then a searing pain bit into my thigh, and my whole body went limp. I fell… I looked down at my thigh. A long shaft was sticking out of it, with a neat little punch-hole where the arrow had gone in.[460]

Despite a harrowing first contact Olson eventually became a valued member of the Motilone community. Olson's accounts offer an outsider's perspective (etic) of the worldview and culture of the tribe. Over time, though, as he became more entrenched in the culture, he developed an insider's perspective (emic), more than any outsider before.[461] His descriptions provide a glimpse into the orality framework of a primary society.[462]

Communal Lifestyle

One of Olson's first observations of the Motilone was of the communal nature of their living. He states, "[The] men would come back with their kill, and there would be a

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[460]Olson, *Bruchko*, 70.

[461]Anthropologists distinguish the viewpoints of research using the terminology *emic* view and *etic* view. The *emic* view denotes the mental categories and assumptions of the local people. The *etic* view refers to the technical and professional views of the outside observer. See Gary Ferraro, *Cultural Anthropology: An Applied Perspective*. 4th ed. (Belmont, CA: Wadsworth-Thomson Learning, 2001), 50.

[462]The following case study of Bruce Olson's work among the Motilone Indians is based on two primary sources. Bruce Olson's auto-biographical account, *Bruchko* (Lake Mary, FL: Charisma House), has been reprinted and updated five times since 1973. Most recently (2006) Olson wrote a sequel to *Bruchko* entitled *Bruchko and the Motilone Miracle* (Charisma House). Some have decried Olson as an ethnocentric colonizer. Andres Küng, in *Bruce Olson: Missionary or Colonizer?*, vindicates Olson's character, putting to rest much of the criticism Olson has received. See Andres Küng, *Bruce Olson: Missionary or Colonizer?* (Chappaqua, NY: Christian Herald Books, 1981).

meal, with everyone enjoying the aroma of the roasting meat, shouting back and forth across the center of the community home."[463] Oral folk tend to be more group-oriented, giving more weight to the value of belonging to community than the value of individualism. In many primary oral contexts, such as that of the Motilone, connectedness to the community helps ensure survival by placing the responsibility of providing basic necessities, such as food, on the community as a whole.

Ong states, "Primary orality fosters personality structures that in certain ways are more communal and externalized, and less introspective than those common among literates. Oral communication unites people in groups."[464] When a Motilone man reported an ominous sign he observed in the jungle, the response was immediate and corporate. Olson reports, "The whole house was in an uproar. All work stopped. Those who couldn't get close to Abacuriana stood on the perimeter of the crowd and talked and walked swiftly to the door and stared outside."[465] Madinger affirms, "Oral culture peoples place a high value on consensus and corporate action."[466]

For the Motilone, and oral folk in general, relational, group-oriented, face-to-face activities hold a preeminent place in life. Thus, special times are set aside to foster such interaction. For the Motilone, the Festival of Arrows, the most important event in Motilone culture, serves as a context in which the tribe strengthens community by recounting myths, telling stories, and relating news. Olson describes the beginning of this

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[463]Olson, *Bruchko*, 91.

[464]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 67.

[465]Olson, *Bruchko*, 129.

[466]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 207.

event, “People streamed into the home. There was a lot of noise and food. Old friends greeted each other and swapped stories.”[467] In fact, the communal nature of the Motilone tribe and especially the Festival of Arrows would serve as an important component of the initial dissemination of the gospel from the lone Motilone believer to the wider Motilone population.[468]

Mnemonics

In order to create a context in which he could begin language learning, Olson shared a few simple games and tricks with the Motilone. He relates, “They had unbelievable tolerance for seeing these acts again and again.”[469] One act consisted of Olson seemingly plucking out his eye, rinsing it, and returning it to the socket. “I gave the presentation for every Motilone in the home dozens of times, until it seemed that my eyes would turn black and blue.”[470] Olson found this surprising, but repetition is an important aspect of oral cognition.

Oral cultures are particularly primed for and prefer repetition and redundancy. In the oral world of communication the learner must keep internal focus on all the information that has been presented him. Thus, for any sort of analysis to take place in the oral mind, it must be buttressed by repeated exposure to the information. Voth relates,

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[467]Olson, *Bruchko*, 134.

[468]G. F. Vicedom’s account of Keysser’s sensitivity to the importance of community among the oral Papuans is an especially helpful example. See Vicedom, “An Example of Group Conversion.” Further, see Alan Tippett, “Conversion as a Dynamic Process in Christian Mission.”

[469]Olson, *Bruchko*, 92.

[470]Ibid.

"It seems that the repetition of certain key terms is characteristic of an oral style."[471] Ong affirms, "Redundancy, repetition of the just-said, keeps both speaker and hearer surely on track."[472] For this reason "repetition is a key feature of oral literature."[473]

Apprenticeship

Oral folk learn by doing.[474] In a culture in which written instruction manuals are either non-existent or unappreciated, apprenticeship becomes the primary mode of learning. Olson observed apprenticeship among the Motilones:

> One day I watched a mother weaving with her little girl in her lap. The girl put her hands into the cloth and tangled the thread until it was a complete mess. But the mother didn't even scold her. She merely put her to one side, patiently repaired the damage, then showed her how she could help card the yarn.[475]

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[471]Esteben Voth, "Orality and Writtenness in Ancient Near Eastern Prophecy," *The Bible Translator* 56, no. 3 (July 2005): 123.

[472]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 40. Further, Coogin reports, "Repetition organized the narratives for oral audiences, and it also provided a canvas for presenting occasional dramatic departure from expected norms of storytelling." See Michael David Coogin and Mark S. Smith, *Stories from Ancient Canaan* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2012), 11.

[473]Martin Parsons, "Unveiling God: Presenting Jesus to Muslims through a Confessional Recitation," *Missions Frontiers* (Nov-Dec 2006): 17. Despite its common usage the term "oral literature" is controversial. Ong considers it a "strictly preposterous term." His objection is based on the etymology of the word "literature," which may be traced by to the Latin *litera*, "letter of the alphabet." Given that so called "oral literature" is, by nature, devoid of written language, Ong argues that other nomenclature is in order. See Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 12; and, for a critique of Ong's objections, see Anthony K. Webster, "Keeping the Word: On Orality and Literacy (With a Sideways Glance at Navajo)," *Oral Tradition* 21, no. 2 (2006): 295-324.

[474]For example, Casey Davis reports, "In such societies, oral poets learn their craft through apprenticeship and the techniques are assimilated by the rest of the society." See Casey W. Davis, "Hebrews 6:4-6 From an Oral Critical Perspective."

[475]Olson, *Bruchko*, 93.

Ong relates that oral folk "learn by apprenticeship—hunting with experienced hunters for example—by discipleship…not by study in the strict sense." David Sills describes this characteristic among the primary oral Quichua of the Andean Highlands in Ecuador:

> The mothers train the daughters to tend the crops as they do, to make flour and bread as they do, and to care for the little ones as they do. Through hearing, watching, and doing, the young people learn to take over these tasks as they mature. Fathers teach the young men to farm, build houses, and perform other tasks through stories and on-the-job training. This has been the pattern for generations in such cultures.[476]

Apprenticeship becomes an especially important in the process of discipleship among oral societies. The first Motilone convert struggled to know how to follow Christ because no Motilone had done it before, so no one could show him how to do it. Olson reports, "The light flicked over him. His face was serious. 'How can I walk on Jesus' trail?' he asked. 'No Motilone has ever done it. It's a new thing. There is no other Motilone to tell how to do it.'"[477]

Symbol and Ritual

Jay Moon explains, "In addition to stories, oral cultures create oral art through the weaving of symbols, rituals, proverbs, music, dance, and drama."[478] Once Olson gained

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[476]Sills, *Reaching and Teaching the Highland Quichuas*, 116.

[477]Olson, *Bruchko*, 126. LaNette Thompson reports, "One researcher who investigated the apprenticeship system among tailors in contemporary Liberia noted that a master tailor usually has one or two apprentices at a time. Over a period of ten years, the master tailor may produce three or four masters of his own. Tailors teach their nonliterate apprentices traditional arithmetic methods that they use successfully." See LaNette Weiss Thompson, "The Nonliterate and the Transfer of Knowledge in West Africa" (Fort Worth, TX: Self-Published, 1998), 17.

[478]W. Jay Moon, "Using Rituals to Disciple Oral Learners: Part 1," *Orality Journal* 2, no. 1 (2013): 43.

rapport within the Motilone community he was invited to take part in rituals and ceremonies. Here he recounts a boy's initiation into manhood:

> We walked for about fifteen minutes, then stopped in a little clearing. Cobaydrá's father solemnly produced a loincloth, and I realized with a little chill of excitement that this was the ceremony for Cobaydrá to become a man…There was a short ceremony, then Cobaydrá slipped on the loincloth. He was smiling almost laughing—and really proud. His father turned to the three of us who were looking on. "His name is Bobaríshora." Then, turning to me, he said, "Now that he is a man, he will no longer be called Cobaydrá. He will be called Bobaríshora."[479]

This rite of passage revealed an important symbol in Motilone society—the loincloth. Loincloths symbolized manhood which carried with it connotations of strength, virility, provision, and security.

Rituals serve to locate the important events of life within the context of the community's foundational narrative. Further, rituals fulfill their purpose when they effectively affirm symbols that bring into view the foundational narratives of the community. Through ritual, the community is able to integrate transition into the narrative of the community.[480]

Another significant Motilone ritual is centered on the establishment of a pact between two parties. The Motilone social system is based on pacts between families. Parties that have formed pacts share food, shelter, and family. Olson decided to form a pact with a young man with whom he had developed a strong bond, Bobaríshora. Olson reports:

> I had seen pacts before. Part of the ceremony required that the people exchange arrows. I wanted to establish a pact with [Bobaríshora], and I felt that he wanted it, too.

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[479]Olson, *Bruchko*, 100.

[480]Bradshaw, *Change Across Cultures*, 236.

> I held out my arrows to [Bobaríshora], and he took them and made a show of carefully examining them. "These are beautiful arrows," he said solemnly. "I accept you as my brother."
>
> I took his arrows from him. They were long, heavy things, with beautiful markings. I could see that [Bobaríshora], who had been making arrows all his life, had taken extra care with these.
>
> We sang the traditional song of brotherhood, and my body relaxed. "We are brothers," I sang, looking at [Bobaríshora], my face breaking out into a smile that was as broad and free as his. "We are brothers, and there is nothing in the world that can take us apart."[481]

Rituals are often associated with the manipulation of power, usually spiritual, in order to achieve a desired result. This view is especially common in relation to primal and folk religions, such as Animism. However, Bradshaw contends, "The efficacy of any ritual does not lie in the power to cause empirically verifiable changes."[482] Rather, rituals' potency rests in their ability to affirm symbols that hearken to foundational narratives, all of which buttress community identity. Thus, rituals become especially important in the discipleship process. Moon comments, "Oral cultures in particular rely on rituals to deepen faith in ways that other genres simply cannot address."[483]

Words and Power

For the Motilone, oral utterance is dynamic and potent. That is why when an epidemic of pinkeye hit the village, "the witch doctor began to sing incantations day in and day out: up to twenty hours a day."[484] That is also why sacred ceremony is always

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[481]Olson, *Bruchko*, 100.

[482]Bradshaw, *Change Across Cultures*, 226.

[483]Moon, "Using Rituals to Disciple Oral Learners," 44. Further, Moon comments, "Even a short visit to the Rosebud Native American reservation, for example, reveals that rituals like the Sweat Lodge, Sun Dance, Vision Quest, etc. are at the heart of the religious experience for this largely oral culture."

[484]Olson, *Bruchko*, 113.

accompanied by sacred spoken language, such as the giving of a new name or the singing of traditional songs.[485]

Olson and Bobaríshora's relationship blossomed, occasioning deeper insight into the Motilone's view of spoken language. Olson reports a peculiar yet profound incident that occurred as he and Bobaríshora walked through the jungle. Olson recounts:

> I heard [Bobaríshora's] voice behind me. "Bruchko, I am named 'In the Heavens.'"
>
> I turned, puzzled. He was standing quite still, with his mouth open a little bit, as if he'd seen a ghost. I could see that whatever he meant was extremely important. But I didn't understand.
>
> "That's my name," he said.
>
> "But what about 'Bobaríshora'?"
>
> He shook his head. "No, my real name is 'In the Heavens.' That is my secret name."
>
> Then he explained that every Motilone Indian has a secret name that is his real identity. Only his father and sometimes a few others know it. It is secret because, if someone knows it, he has complete power over that person.[486]

It is common for oral societies to think of names as wielding power over that which is named. The Motilone had no sense of a name as a label for an object because they had no sense of words being visualized as markings. While textual folk see a clear distinction between the signs and the signified, oral folk do not. Thus, for those living in an oral framework, to possess the name of a person is to possess power over the person.[487]

Deeply textual people forget to think of words as primarily oral events.[488] They view words as objects to be manipulated, completely separate from the signified. Spoken language is simply codified symbols made audible. For the Motilone, however, spoken

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[485]Olson, *Bruchko*, 100-101.

[486]Moon, "Using Rituals to Disciple Oral Learners," 102.

[487]Ong, "Orality, Literacy, and Modern Media," 65.

[488]Ibid.

language is something much more dynamic. Olson reports an occurrence that demonstrates this:

> He explained that the brother of the man shouting into the hole had died in a region that was not his home. He had been bitten by a poisonous snake and had died before there was time to get him back. According to their traditions, that meant that his language, his spirit, his life, could never go to God beyond the horizon. Now the man was trying to look for God, to get Him to bring his brother's language back to life, to live in his body.[489]

The significance of spoken language within the Motilone's worldview became more apparent to Olson as he began to share basic biblical truths. Olson reports:

> "How do evil, death, and deception find power over the Motilone people?" I asked.
>
> "Through the ears," [Bobaríshora] answered, because language is so important to the Motilones. It is the essence of life. If evil language comes through the ears, it means death.[490]

Later, when Bobaríshora began to follow Jesus he described his new condition by saying, "Now I speak a new language."[491] Not long after the first conversion, the village received word that a bad omen had been given and that the spirits would come into the village that evening to kill. Bobaríshora explained to Olson that people die when the spirits come into the village "because the evil spirits tear their language away from them." Bobaríshora, with considerable anxiousness, asked Olson, "Can Jesus be taken out of my mouth?"[492]

As the village braced themselves for nightfall and for the spirits to walk, Olson was worried how Bobaríshora would react as a new believer. He reports:

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[489]Olson, *Bruchko*, 122.

[490]Ibid., 131.

[491]Ibid., 127.

[492]Ibid., 131.

> Inside, the fires cast an eerie glow. All the men, high up in their hammocks, were swinging and chanting to ward off the devil…I looked into Bobby's hammock. His eyes were open. He had a big smile on his face. The song he was singing was different:
>
> Jesus is in my mouth;
> I have a new speech.
> Jesus is in my mouth;
> No one can take Him from me.
> I speak Jesus' words.
> I walk in Jesus' steps.
> I am Jesus' boy;
> He has filled my stomach, and I am no longer hungry.[493]

Oral Tradition

The Motilones, like all oral cultures, preserve history, beliefs, values, and knowledge through oral tradition. Through these songs, parables, fables, and myths they preserve and maintain their identity, culture, and traditions. Paul Hiebert and Eloise Meneses detail, "Cultural information is stored in many ways. Many of us store it in writing…Other cultures store most of their information in stories, songs, riddles, and other forms of oral traditions that are easily remembered."[494]

The most important part of a primary oral culture's oral tradition is their foundational story, commonly known as "mythology." These stories of origin and destiny provide answers to the most fundamental questions of existence.[495] Olson reports the following concerning the creation of the Motilone people:

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[493]Olson, Bruchko, 133.

[494]Paul G. Hiebert and Eloise Heibert Meneses, *Incarnational Ministry: Planting Churches in Band, Tribal, Peasant, and Urban Societies* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1995), 39.

[495]For analysis, synthesis, and theory of mythologies of the primitive world see Josheph Campell's seminal work, *The Masks of God: Primitive Mythology* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1960). Jonah Sachs, in his recent work on secondary orality, *Story Wars*, draws heavily from Campbell.

> Motilone legends had taught them that God created the first Motilone family by cutting open a pineapple. They believed God defended them from His dwelling place in the heavens, and that is where they wanted to go when they died. Their hopelessness about following a false prophet revealed that they knew they were lost from God.[496]

Oral learners only know what they can remember, and what is most memorable is narrative in nature. Oral cultures tend toward concrete, tangible forms instead of abstractions or propositions in outline form. The Motilone, like other oral societies, prefer narrative because it "speaks in the idiom of the earth."[497] When oral learners are exposed to abstract proposition, their minds demand example—namely, a story.[498]

These narratives may serve as a warning, either mundane or prophetic. At one point Olson found himself on the wrong end of a prophetic warning. Olson reports:

> I was talking to Arabadoyca one day, lying in our hammocks, and it popped into my head to ask him about Abaratatura. "Why would he want to kill me? He must know by now that I'm not dangerous. Surely he's heard about me living here."
>
> "He thinks you're the cannibal with the magic flute," Arabadoyca said. "So, he'll kill you before you kill him."
>
> "What?" I said. "What do you mean?"
>
> Arabadoyca stretched. "The time will come, it's said, when a white man will come to the Motilones with a magic flute that he will play. He'll lead all the Motilones into a trap, and they'll be eaten alive." …
>
> "And that's why Abaratura hates me? He thinks I'm a cannibal?"
>
> "Well, you play the flute, don't you?"[499]

This oral tradition was passed from person to person, generation to generation serving as a vivid reminder to the Motilones to be wary of outsiders. Given that the Motilones had

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[496]Olson, *Bruchko and the Motilone Miracle*, 10.

[497]Fackre, "Narrative Theology: An Overview," 345.

[498]Avery T. Willis and Mark Snowden, *Truth That Sticks: How to Communicate Velcro Truth in a Teflon World* (Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2010), 35.

[499]Olson, *Bruchko*, 104-105.

suffered for hundreds of years at the hands of light-skinned people, good reason existed for such warnings.

Another Motilone legend foretold of reconciliation between the Motilone and God: "A tall prophet with yellow hair will come to us carrying banana stalks. Knowledge of life and God will come out of those stalks, and God will show us the way back to Him."[500] Arabadoyca explained how some of the Motilone connected Olson with this prophecy:

> "When no harm came to us because of you," Arabadoyca continued, "most of us believed that you were all right. In fact, some thought that you might be bringing God's banana stalk."
>
> "What's that?"
>
> "There is another prediction that a tall man with yellow hair will come with a banana stalk, and God will come out of the banana stalk."
>
> "And do you think that might be me?"
>
> He shrugged. "You don't carry a banana stalk, do you?"[501]

Here Olson finds a bridge by which to share the gospel. By positioning himself as the man in the prophecy, the Motilones would more readily receive his message. When Olson saw the type of banana stalk to which the prophecy referred, he realized that it closely represented the physical characteristics of a book. "Suddenly a word raced through my mind. 'Book! Book!'" He took out his Bible from his pack and held it toward them. "'This is it!' I said. 'I have it here! This is God's banana stalk.'"[502]

As Olson strove to explain the gospel to them, a story from the Motilone oral tradition occurred to him. It was a folktale that explained why ant homes physically resemble those of the Motilone. Olson recounts the story:

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[500]Olson, *Bruchko and the Motilone Miracle*, 1.

[501]Olson, *Bruchko*, 105.

[502]Ibid.

> [A man] had been sitting on the trail after a hunt and had noticed some ants trying to build a home. He'd wanted to help them make a good home, like the Motilone home, so he'd begun digging in the dirt. But because he was so big and so unknown, the ants had been afraid and had run away. Then, quite miraculously, he had become an ant. He thought like an ant, and spoke the language of an ant. He lived with the ants, and they came to trust him. He told them one day that he was not really an ant, but a Motilone, and that he had once tried to help them improve their home, but he had scared them.[503]

Through this Motilone story Olson began the slow process of contextualizing the gospel to the Motilone.

Movement Toward Christ

Olson's engagement of the Motilone and his initial explanation of the gospel was dependent upon his ability to work within the orality framework.[504] This complex task demanded more than putting the gospel into audible, narrative form. Beyond acquiring basic language and culture, Olson became acquainted with the oral tradition of the Motilone and used these stories to explain the gospel message. Olson's decision to reside within the Motilone communal society allowed him to develop face-to-face relationships. He was emotionally involved with the Motilones, as opposed to being intellectually detached from them. Like the Motilones, Olson began to place a high priority on group consensus and community action. It was within this orality framework that Olson was able to share the gospel in a way that the Motilone would hear and understand it.

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[503]Olson, *Bruchko*, 123-124.

[504]See *Table 3.2: Oralilty Versus Textuality* in chapter 3.

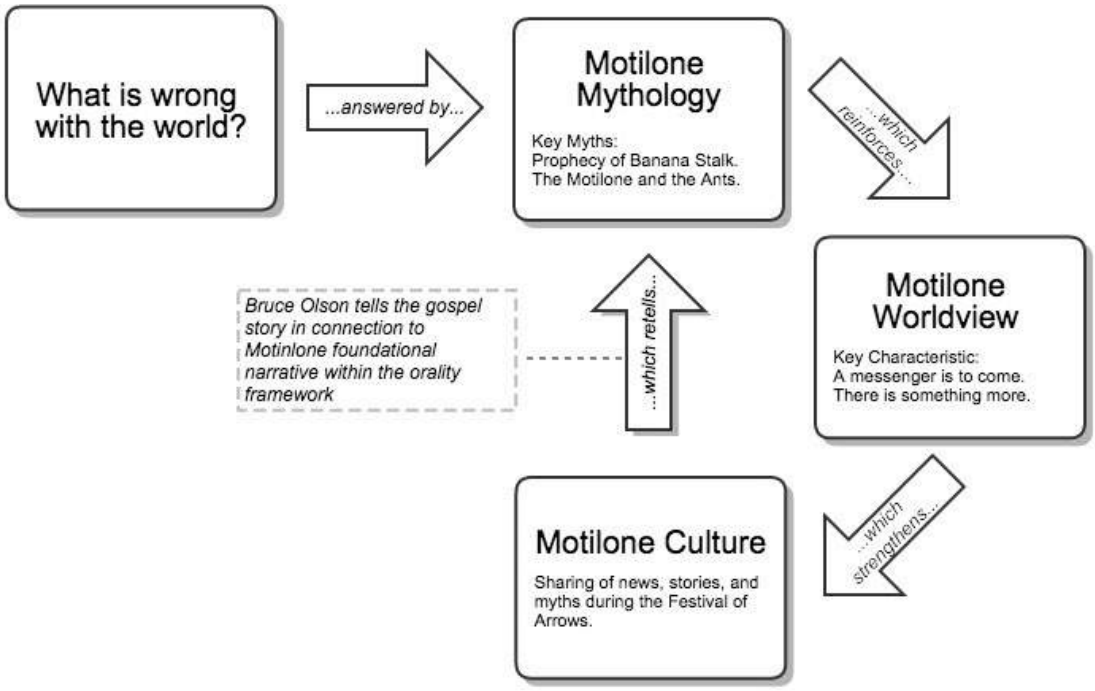

Figure 4.1: Bruce Olson's Point and Manner of Entry

After Bobaríshora became a follower of Jesus, Olson grew impatient with his apparent reluctance to share the gospel with other Motilones. This was due to the fact that Olson had slipped into textual, individualistic, Western modes of thinking. Among the Motilone, news that has lasting significance is given in a formal ceremony. Olson later realized that Bobaríshora was waiting to tell of Christ the Motilone way. He recounts:

> Word spread that there was to be another Festival of Arrows…Pacts would be formed. Arrows would be exchanged, and the men forming the pact would have a singing contest. They would climb into their hammocks and sing as long as they could, relating legends, stories, and news of recent events. Often their songs would last twelve hours, without interruption for food, water, or rest.
>
> People were looking at [Bobaríshora] in a new light. Word had spread about the night the spirits had walked and no one died. He was looked on with respect and some curiosity. He had married and was accepted as a man.
>
> An older chief named Adjibacbayra took special interest in [Bobaríshora]…and on the first day of the festival he challenged [him] to a song…They both climbed into a single hammock twenty feet off the ground and began to swing back and forth. [Bobaríshora] sang first, and Adjibacbayra imitated him, following him line for line. Other men also had challenged each other's songs and were singing.

> [Bobaríshora's] song was about the way the Motilones had been deceived and had lost God's trail. He told how they had once known God but had been greedy and had followed a false prophet. Then he began to sing about Jesus. As he did so, the other men who were singing stopped. Everyone became quiet in order to listen.
>
> "Jesus Christ was incarnated into man," [he] sang. "He has walked our trails. He is God, yet we can know Him."[505]

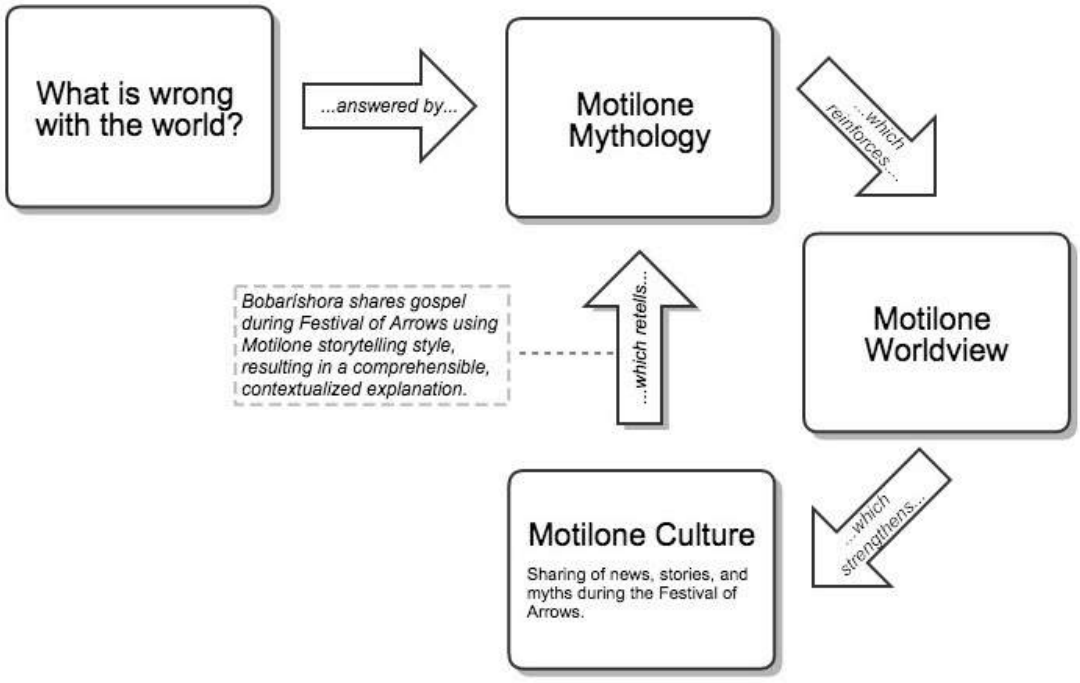

Figure 4.2: Bobaríshora's Indigenous Gospel Presentation

Because Bobaríshora was an insider, sharing this new message in a culturally appropriate way with his people came quite naturally. His witness was completely congruent with his tribe's oral milieu, and the results prove the effectiveness and importance of evangelizing within the orality framework.

Residual Orality: Late Medieval and the Reformation Period

The Reformation is often pictured as a movement carried along by the technology of printing. To focus solely on the printed word, however, directs attention too narrowly

[505]Olson, *Bruchko*, 134.

at the small, if growing, literate group. It ignores the vast quantity of illiterate and semi-literate people, a segment of the population that has been estimated at 90 percent.[506] The great majority of people in the late Medieval period were functionally illiterate.[507]

The Reformation period provides a helpful case study for modern cultures. Like the late Medieval and Reformation period, many cultures today are experiencing the advent of literacy within their society but continue to retain an oral framework.[508] This phenomenon is known as residual orality. Residual orality "describes those who have been exposed to literacy, even learned to read in school, but who retain a strong preference for learning by oral rather than literate means."[509]

The Printing Press

Luther's proposed discourse over his Ninety-Five Theses was not pioneering. Rather, it was customary for professors of theology to hold disputations over an issue

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[506]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 49.

[507] Freeman, "Orality Versus Textuality in the Reformation: The Origin and Influence of Textuality on Theological Perspectives in the Sixteenth Century," 1.

[508]For example, the Cia-Cia people of Buton Island, Indonesia recently adopted an alphabet for their language. Mark Hay comments, "An endangered language of some 79,000 speakers at the time, many feared that as global tongues and cultures became more locally popular, younger generations would be unable to engage with the knowledge and sense of identity stored within the Cia-Cia oral tradition. This new script would attempt to contain a 600-year-old cultural history, preserving their tongue and giving future generations all the benefits of literacy without the dislocation of language loss." See Mark Hay, "Reinventing the Alphabet," *GOOD*, http://magazine.good.is/articles/new-alphabets-for-oral-languages (accessed 01 December 2014).

[509]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 120. Because the Reformation yielded a religion of literate, Bible-reading laymen one may too quickly surmise that the religious revival took root principally by literate means. See Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 2.

such as indulgences.[510] The subsequent dissemination of the Ninety-Five Theses via print technology, however, was inconceivable. Luther himself confessed, "It is a mystery to me how my theses, more so than my other writings, indeed, those of other professors were spread to so many places."[511] Luther invited a public disputation and no one arrived to dispute. Then, all of a sudden, he found himself expounding to the whole world.[512] The reformation was the first religious struggle that had the assistance of the printing press.[513] A. G. Dickens comments, "Unlike the Wycliffite and Waldensian heresies, Lutheranism was from the first the child of the printed book, and through this vehicle Luther was able to make exact, standardized and ineradicable impressions on the mind of Europe."[514]

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[510]Elizabeth L. Eisenstein, *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979), 306; G.R. Elton, *Reformation Europe 1517-1559*, 3rd ed. (Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishers, 1999), 306.

[511]Martin Luther, Letter May 30, 1518 in Hans J. Hillerbrand, ed. *The World of the Reformation* (New York: Scribner, 1973), 54. Further, Bainton asserts that Luther neither took steps to disseminate the theses nor had it in mind when he wrote them. Luther may have been anxious about publicity, but he did not impede the printing of his theses. In March 1518 he wrote in a letter that he "had no wish nor plan to publicize these Theses," but that he would leave it up to his friends whether or not the theses were to be "suppressed or spread outside." See, Martin Luther, Letter to Scheurl, March 5, 1518, cited by Earnest C. Schweibert, "The Theses and Wittenberg," in *Luther for an Ecumenical Age: Essays*, ed. C. S. Meyer (St. Louis, MO: Concordia Publishing Co. 1967), 142; Roland H. Bainton, *Here I Stand: A Life of Martin Luther* (New York: Miridian, 1995), 63-64.

[512]Gordon Rupp, *Luther's Progress to the Diet of Worms* (Harper and Row, 1964), 54.

[513]Louise Holborn, "Printing and the Growth of a Protestant Movement in Germany from 1517-1524," *Church History XI* (June 1942): 1.

[514]A. G. Dickens, *Reformation and Society* (Thames and Hudson, 1971), 51. Before the beginning of the Reformation church officials had already extolled the new technology as a gift from God. The printing press, from their perspective, was a providential invention, which authenticated Western eminence over ignorant infidel groups. Further, the reformers were mindful of the usefulness of the printing press to their cause and they acknowledged its importance in their writings. See Geoffrey Atkinson,

Luther asserted printing was "God's highest and extremist act of grace, whereby the business of the Gospel is driven forward."[515] However, the effect of the printing press was not seen immediately. Literacy did expand, but only slightly and slowly. Scribner states, "Printing created the potential for mass literacy, but it was a long time before it lost its sense of novelty and became commonplace among the broader social classes."[516] Dependence upon oral communication held a prominent place throughout the Reformation movement. Scribner says, "Printing was, in fact, an addition to, not a replacement for, oral communication. Indeed, it was as likely as not that most people would have experienced the printed word only indirectly, by having it read aloud to them."[517]

With functional illiteracy rates as high as 90 percent, concentration on the printed word alone proffers only restricted access to the process by which the message circulated among the people. Thus print must be understood in relation to the oral milieu of the

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Les Nouveaux Horizons de la Renaissance Francias (Paris, 1935), 57; and Eisenstein, *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change*, 304.

[515]Luther's remarks, cited by M. H. Black, "The Printed Bible," in S. L. Greenslade, ed. *Cambridge History of the Bible*, Vol. 3, *The West from the Reformation to the Present Day* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1963), 432. Elizabeth Eisenstein echoes Luther's sentiment: "[Protestants] viewed printing as a providential device which ended forever a priestly monopoly of learning, overcame ignorance and superstition, pushed back the evil forces commanded by Italian popes, and, in general, brought Western Europe out of the dark ages." See Eisenstein, *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change*, 305.

[516]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 2. Goody and Watt report that more literate populations were concentrated in urban areas and the more culturally advanced southwest. The presence of schools provides a crude indicator. In Wuttemberg there were as many as eighty-nine schools by the 1520s. At least half the towns in Germany boasted a school. Saxony, by contrast, had no more than a handful of schools by the 1520s, and all of them urban. Goody and Watt, "The Consequences of Literacy," 36.

[517]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 2.

people.[518] In fact, one cannot obtain an accurate depiction of information dissemination in the Reformation period without accounting for the hybridization of media employed.[519]

Literacy during this period was highly socially stratified. Further, a sort of pragmatic literacy was abundantly more common than the erudite, reflective, or critical literacy and was viewed as a tool of trade, especially among craftsmen and merchants.[520] This type of literacy, however, was a great distance from popular literacy and what Erwin Panofsky described as "the use of writing as an autonomous mode of communication by the majority of members of a society."[521] Access to the printed word was likely restricted to an expanding but small educational elite.[522] To be illiterate, however, did not mean that

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[518]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk,* 3.

[519]Marshal McLuhan, *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man* (The MIT Press, 1994).

[520]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk,* 2. Eric Havelock, in *Preface to Plato,* described a phenomenon that occurs shortly after the introduction of writing known as "craft-literacy." During this stage writing is a trade practiced by craftsman. Just as one may hire a stonemason to build a wall, the writing of a letter may be contracted by a tradesman whose craft was writing. At this stage no need exists for every person to become literate. The demand for writing has not grown to a sufficient degree to necessitate widespread literacy. See Eric Havelock, *Preface to Plato,* (Cambridge, MA: The Belknap Press, 1963). This phenomenon is commonplace in modern times as well. Isak Denison reports, "For Kamante cannot write, and he does not know English. When he, or any other people, take it into their heads to send me their tidings they go to one of the professional Indian or Native letter-writers who are sitting with their writing desk, paper, pen and ink, outside the Post Offices, and explain to them what shall be in the letter. The professional writers do not know much English either, and can hardly be said to know how to write, but themselves believe they can. To show off their skill they enrich the letters with a number of flourishes, which makes them difficult to decipher." See Isak Dinesen, *Out of Africa and Shadows on the Grass* (New York: Vintage International, 1989), 75.

[521]Erwin Panofsky, *Meaning in the Visual Arts* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983), 53-57.

[522]Panofsky, *Meaning in the Visual Arts*, 53-57.

one was beyond the reach of the printed text. Clear evidence exists that most villages would have had at the very least one or two persons able to read and write who could share the Reformation message with non-readers.[523]

Dissemination of Information in the Reformation

In order to comprehend the diffusion of Reformation ideas, one must set the printed word in the context of the entire scope of information media available to and used by the people of that period. Apart from printed text there were visual forms such as woodcuts, participational forms such us festivals, and, above all, oral forms of communication such as the sermon, ballad and hymn, and mouth-to-ear transmission.[524]

Visual

Seeing was a salient element of religious devotion during the late Medieval period and certainly played an important role in the Reformation period, which was, as Scribner puts it, "intensely visual."[525] During the Reformation period there existed a powerful

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[523]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 50.

[524]Ibid., 50.

[525]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 3. A. L. Meyer evidenced three prevalent ways of "seeing" in the late-medieval devotion. The first, "mystical seeing," referred to seeing a vision or appearance that would give certainty of salvation. This was typically sought after through some sort of mystical piety, such as fasting. Although this form was inward, the desired outcome was nonetheless visual. The second was "seeing of mysteries." Here one desired to make visible a form of sacred action beyond earthly reality. For example, to see the host displayed at the moment of consecration. Finally, devotees sought after a "purely bodily seeing" which involved a sensual link to the object. This type of superstitious seeing often veered into magic. For example, it was customary to dip the holy lance used, allegedly, to pierce the side of Christ, into wine and then pierce illustrations of the heart of Christ. The visual representation became holy by contact with the holy lance. Thus, the one who made contact with the lance was bestowed with supernatural power. See Sarah Blick and Laura D. Gelfand, eds., *Push Me, Pull You:*

impulse for the mysteries of religion to be made visual. Thus, in popular devotion, Jesus—the Lord of the world and victorious Savior—was replaced by infant Jesus wrapped in swaddling clothes, Christ the Good Shepherd, or the suffering Christ on the cross. Moreover, theological concepts were often portrayed in strikingly visual manners. For instance, the incarnation was portrayed by statues of the Madonna whose stomach could be opened to reveal the Trinity inside.[526]

The use of visual stimuli to communicate in oral cultures is an ancient practice. Diane Smith reports that dissemination of information through drawings and visual designs predates written language. Moreover, humans from earliest times have cataloged that which is most important to them through visual representations. In fact, "Visual illustrations are some of the first and oldest communication methods predating written language."[527] This reality bears out in the Old and New Testaments. Paula Dubill signals:

> In the Bible, there were many instances where God spoke clearly in pictures or visual images (e.g., a burning bush and a pillar of cloud or fire). Jesus also used a variety of images to communicate clearly with His followers. Sometimes they were physical visuals such as the vine or the bread, or when He drew in the sand; sometimes they were word pictures frequently seen in His use of metaphors.[528]

Imaginative and Emotional Interaction in Late Medieval and Renaissance Art (Leiden, Netherlands: Brill, 2011), xlvii.

[526]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 3.

[527]Diane Smith, "Visual Art and Orality," *Dharma Deepika Magazine* (January 2007).

[528]Paula Dubill, "Living Out a Visual Story," in *Orality Breakouts: Using Heart Language to Transform Hearts* (Hong Kong: ION/LCWE, 2010), 39. Rick Brown asserts "Young or unsophisticated oral communicators are often puzzled by abstract pictures, whereas they readily accept and understand realistic ones. (Abstract images are ones in which the features are generalized so that specific features need to be imagined. Examples would be watercolors in which facial features are missing, line drawings in which features are missing or disconnected, and drawings of incomplete bodies.)" See Rick Brown, "How to Make Oral Communication More Effective," *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 21, no. 4 (Winter 2004): 176.

David Hesselgrave, in *Communicating Christ Cross-Culturally*, points out that spoken language is the foundation of communication, but it does not function alone. Rather, "Words are augmented by pictures, actions, sounds, silence, smells, and objects. Words can be spoken or written; pictures can be drawn on canvas or projected on a screen; and actions can be a part of sign language for the deaf or part of a stage play."[529] Hesselgrave, speaking directly about oral contexts, asserts:

> One of the most exciting challenges facing missionary communicators is the challenge to use indigenous simple media such as dramas, diagrams, and drawings more imaginatively and more often. Simple media are especially important in cultures where concrete-relational thinking predominates to reproduce and comprehend. For the missionary, simple media have great and largely untapped potential in most cultures and therefore should not be overlooked. [530]

The reformers understood the gravity of this reality and employed visual means to spread ideas. Through visual presentations, oral folk were able to understand lessons and were affected by messages. One particularly notable visual tool was woodcut images that were printed on broadsheets. Eisenstein reports these images were "designed to catch the attention and arouse the passions of sixteenth-century readers, their anti-papist cartoons still have a strong impact when encountered in history books today."[531]

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[529]David Hesselgrave, *Communication Christ Cross-Culturally*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Zondervan Publishing House, 1991), 537.

[530]Hesselgrave, *Communication Christ Cross-Culturally*, 537.

[531]Eisenstein, *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change*, 304. Barbara Griswold comments, "For a few pfennigs a person who could not read could purchase a virtual textbook of devotion…One could hold this in one's hand and venerate the image. One could study the mnemonic iconography in the border to meditate on the passion of the Lord. A parent could use it to recreate the story to instruct children beyond what they received as catechumens. Devotional imagery such as this permeated preGutenberg society, and grew in popularity with the new ability to add a few basic words and reproduce them cheaply." See Barbara Stone Griswold, "War in Words and Pictures:

Figure 4.3: The Origins of the Monks, anonymous broadsheet.[532]

Figure 4.4: The Pope as Antichrist in the Jaws of Hell, 1545.[533]

The reformers, however, were not pioneering a new methodology but rather were infusing an already time-tested mode of communication with a new message. For example, the Iona community and their mission to the oral Picts included the use of visuals.[534] Still extant in Iona is St. Martin's cross, a large stone sculpture formed between 750 and 800. Edward Smither describes it in this way:

> At the center of the cross, the birth of Christ is depicted with Mary holding the baby Jesus. Continuing down the cross, the stories of Daniel in the lions' den, Abraham raising his sword to sacrifice Isaac, David fighting Goliath, and David

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Printing, Propaganda, and the Protestant Reformation," *Fides et Historia* 34, no. 1 (Winter/Spring 2002): 63.

[532]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 280.

[533]Ibid., 298.

[534]Smither, "A Celtic Approach to Reaching Oral Learners."

> playing his harp are also communicated. The latter image seems especially contextual as David is joined by another musician playing triple pipes. In short, in viewing St. Martin's cross, Pictish visitors to Iona could contemplate the meaning of the cross and also engage in a visual Bible study.[535]

Lovejoy reports of progress made among the Santal people of South Asia when oral methods that included visual approaches were employed. He reports:

> A Christian outreach effort went to a Santal village and met Marandi, a man who had never been to school. They presented the gospel using oral methods, including stories, visual aids, dramas, songs, dances, and testimonies. Marandi trusted Christ and shared his testimony with his family, who also believed and were baptized. He then went to other relatives and shared his new faith with them, using many of the same oral methods.[536]

Oral learners are visual learners.[537] This is closely connected with their propensity to connect information to the concrete. J. O. Terry remarks:

> Also oral learners are visual learners. This means pictures, objects, references to physical things, and the use of concrete relational expressions. These are expressions that take the place of numbers and other descriptions that are abstract. Sometimes this means using expressions for a large crowd being something like, "We were packed in there like peas in a pod." Or other descriptive language they might use like "a herd of folks."[538]

Mouth-to-Ear

Despite the popularization of movable type printing, oral transmission of information continued to be the primary mode of communication in sixteenth-century Europe. Ideas were sent, received, and passed on by face-to-face contact within small

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[535]Smither, "A Celtic Approach to Reaching Oral Learners."

[536]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Learners*, 40-41.

[537]Leonard Sweet asserts that tendency toward visual is a universal human experience. He says that first, humans think in images, not words. Concerning post-modernity, he describes it as a *visualholic* culture. See Leonard Sweet, *Post-Modern Pilgrims* (Nashville: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 2000), 87.

[538]J. O. Terry, Email to the author, December 24, 2014.

communities.[539] Strauss comments, "When we consider the work of scholars who have dealt with the phenomenon of the spread of the Lutheran message, we find that the dissemination of Lutheran ideas was due largely to oral means of transmission and the orally manageable medium of the catechism."[540] Even the printed word was usually consigned to oral forms of dissemination by reading aloud to one's self and to others, or by the discussion of things in print.[541]

Oral proclamation maintained its position in the residual oral context of the late Medieval and Reformation periods. For example, according to Luther, the orally preached Word rather than the individual pondering in private was the legitimate arena in which faith was engendered. The general public shared Luther's preference for the oral sermon. Indeed, good preaching became the central measure for screening new pastors among protestant congregations.[542]

Like the use of visual media for dissemination of information, preaching was not an element unique to the Reformation period but rather the reformers inhabited an already effective, contextual oral media. Popular preaching in the vernacular had been common for at least the generation before, and oral discourse in religious settings was an ancient practice.[543]

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[539]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 50.

[540]Strauss, *Luther's House of Learning.*

[541]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 50.

[542]Freeman, "Orality Versus Textuality in the Reformation," 13.

[543]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 51.

Reformation preaching, however, differed in important ways. First, Reformation preaching was as common in public quarters as it was in the church. These informal circumstances had the ancillary effects of liberating preachers from traditional limits of the formal sermon and enhanced congregational responsiveness by creating an atmosphere primed for the exchange of ideas. By contrast, participants in Catholic services are pictured as detached, passive, and uninterested.[544]

Figure 4.5: Discussion during an evangelical sermon. Illustration to Cicero, De oficiis *(Steiner, Augsburg, 1530).*[545]

Figure 4.6: Popular preaching during the Reformation. Titlepage to Eberlin von Günzburg, Ain frantlich trostliche vermanung *(1522).*[546]

The two woodcuts represented above depict preachers operating outside the formal structure of the church. One of the most striking aspects of these images is the way the congregation is illustrated as a body of actively participating congregants. This is shown by the gestures of the participants who appear to be arguing with the preacher.[547]

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[544]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 52.

[545]Ibid., 70.

[546]Ibid., 242.

[547]Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk,* 196.

The content of Reformation preaching was shocking and scandalous when compared to what most participants would have been accustomed.[548] The feeling of disturbance engendered by such preaching was only magnified by an even more radical break from the traditional form of preaching—the practice of interrupting and answering back the preacher.[549]

Reformation sermons provided impetus for further engagement with religious ideas. The exchange of ideas during sermons was continued in informal conversation. This sort of dissemination of information invited far more active participation than the sermons, and it appears to have emerged spontaneously through the custom of reading

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[548]A clear example is Michael Reutter's preaching in the Lower Lusatian town of Sommerfeld in 1524 and 1525. Scribner writes that the Bishop of Meissen reported: "Reutter preached that no-one had been correctly baptized for four hundred years because total immersion had not been used; that the best form of absolution was when one person forgave another; that ten mortal sins were committed daily in the Mass; that priests should be whipped if they did not cease to blaspheme and 'crucify Christ' in this manner; that those who attended such Masses should be outlawed, because they 'martyred God'; that the Sacrament was not a sacrifice; but a sign, testament and pledge for those weak in faith; that the entire community should fall on its knees to pray for such weaklings (in this way, the report asserted, he effectively prohibited taking the Sacrament, and did not receive it himself); that the bishop was triply perjured, and that if one put a tonsure on an ass and anointed its paws (*sic*), it would be no less consecrated; that fasting was forbidden and meat-eating allowed; and that no feast days should be observed, not even Sunday, when on was permitted to work after the sermon, as on any other day." See Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 196.

[549]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 54. Most likely, this practice derived from two origins. On the one hand, an unacceptable preacher was contradicted either by heckling or a complete disruption of the sermon. In the year 1524 in Ulm a Catholic preacher was driven from the pulpit and abused as a carnival pulpit by the congregation. His crime was opening the sermon with a prayer to the Virgin. On the other hand, participants simply became used to interrupting, or in their view, participating in evangelical sermons. The practice was so prevalent that in some areas where the Reformation was officially adopted authorities sought to reimpose the discipline of the passive congregation.

aloud. Scribner reports, “Reading aloud, rather than silent scanning of the text, seems to have been the more usual form of reading for the sixteenth century.”[550]

It was common for people to share and acquire new information about religious ideas through the discussion of books.[551] Pamphlets frequently depicted situations in which several persons discuss the contents of a printed work. Some pamphlets encouraged their readers to discuss the contents with others. The printed word was part of a wider communication process, mediated through personal contacts and the spoken word. Further, personal encounters in which religious ideas were discussed were as important as printed text or sermons in the process of information dissemination in the Reformation. They often occurred in conjunction with written text or formal sermons and served to make space for people to internalize and sift ideas, allowing for loosened tongues and freer flowing discussion.[552]

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[550]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 54. Numerous extant accounts attest to this reality. A collection of passages from prophecies published in 1522 comprises a directive to pass the pamphlet on to another reader and to discuss it with them. Another pamphlet conveys the opinion that if one desires to understand the nature of the Antichrist, one should go to a brother who can read, who could then read out the Epistles of Paul. In Nuremberg in 1524 a clerk named Erasmus Wisperger was arrested for reading one of Karlstadt’s works aloud in the marketplace. See Scribner, *For the Sake of the Simple Folk*, 6.

[551]Jean-François Valée asserts, “Hence, the immense popularity of the dialogue in the Renaissance could be seen as a symptom of the ‘residual orality’ left over from the still omnipresent oral-aural perspective before the true domination of print culture and the impending ‘decay of dialogue.’” See Jean-François Valée, “Paradoxes of Orality and Literacy: The Curious Case of the Renaissance Dialogue,” *Proceedings of the Media Ecology Association* 10 (2009): 72-73.

[552]The most common place for this type of discussion was the inn. Heinrich von Kettenbach commented in 1523 that better sermons were preached in the inns of Ulm than in the pulpit. It appears that this was literally true in Basel, for in 1524 there were complaints of persons who preached out of books in inns. Further, inns appear to have been a favorite meeting place of Anabaptists. Probably, an inn was less suspicious than meeting in private homes where they would appear as a treacherous coterie. Inns served

An additional context in which ideas could be passed along through discussion was circles of friendship and kinship. The importance of sphere of influence between those with close personal ties, such as husband and wife, close relatives, or household members was critical. Oral folk's sense of identity is not determined by individual autonomy, but is granted to them by the group. Belonging supersedes personal choice.[553] Madinger affirms, "Oral culture peoples place a high value on consensus and corporate action, raising the expectation for collective conformity and accountability."[554]

This is exemplified in the case of Klaus Hofman of Erfurt. Reportedly, Hofman convinced his wife to be re-baptized, to which she agreed on the condition that it was not a deception. Hofman, his wife, and servant were re-baptized. Further, reported cases exist in which relatives sought to dissuade each other from rebaptism.[555] Similarly, Christian Keysser and Alan Tippett, each in their respective contexts, observed and verified the reality of group-oriented thought in which multi-individual deliberation in order to bring about unanimity was an important part of the acceptance or rejection of new information.[556] The reality of collective conformity was no less puissant in the Reformation period. Thus, as the teaching of the reformers spread through from town to

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not only as a place for discussions among those already committed, but also as a place where casual encounters occurred in which people were exposed to religious ideas not yet confronted. See Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 56.

[553]Choi, "How Cultures around the World Make Choices."

[554]Madinger, "Coming to Terms with Orality," 207.

[555]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 60.

[556]See Vicedom, "An Example of Group Conversion." Further, see Tippett, "Conversion as a Dynamic Process in Christian Mission."

town each individual calculated their response according not only to their personal convictions, but to the convictions of the community to which they belonged.

Music

Music was instrumental in both the dissemination of Reformation ideas and the subversion of Catholicism among a largely oral population. Ballads and hymns were widely used as a comfortable mode by which to present new information and foster a sense of identity and belonging.[557]

The ballad, in particular, served several important functions in the diffusion of Reformation ideas. First, it spread news about recent events. Several ballads dated around 1520 recounted Luther's progress since his initial condemnation of indulgences. Second, ballads were used to ridicule and pillory the orthodox clergy. In fact, many towns resorted to prohibiting the singing of offensive songs against clergy due to the pervasiveness of the practice. The third use of the ballad was as a form of evangelical belief. Hymn-singing both helped form the community around a common set of beliefs and shaped its sense of evangelical solidarity.[558]

Finally, the ballad was utilized to impede Catholic services and mock church music. In Wittenberg, on Christmas Eve 1521, a crowd forced their way into the parish church, extinguished the lights, and began singing secular ballads to disrupt the service.

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[557]Rebecca Oettinger argues that music played a key role in both the dissemination of Luther's teachings and also the subversion of Catholicism to a largely oral population. Further, this music formed an intersection for the forces of the comfortable familiarity of popular music and the need for a sense of community and belonging in tumultuous times. See Rebecca Wagner Oettinger, *Music as Propaganda in the German Reformation* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2001).

[558]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements*, 61.

In Göttingen in 1529 a group of Lutheran weavers disrupted a procession held to beseech divine intervention against the sweating sickness. They first attempted to drown out the chants of the Catholic clergy with a German Psalm. Then they turned to a parody of the liturgical chant *Ora pro nobis,* by chanting *Ohr ab, sum Thor aus,* loosely translated "Shut up and clear out!"[559]

Music continues to be a powerful mode of communication and transformation in modern contexts that function within a residual orality framework.[560] In Monrovia, Liberia, for example, Elliot Adekoya, a DJ at Monrovia's Sky FM radio station, has contributed to the decline of Ebola through an education campaign via music. Jason Beaubien, reporter for National Public Radio, describes, "Radio remains an incredibly powerful medium in West Africa. It blasts from shops and young men crank it up in rust-bucket taxis. You hear it playing from simple shacks and tidy stucco homes."[561]

Many artists have contributed to a catalog of Ebola education songs. Adekoya says one of the most popular was written by F.A. and Soul Fresh, called "Ebola is

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[559]Scribner, *Popular Culture and Popular Movements,* 61.

[560]John Wilson relates "An additional mnemonic device not specifically mentioned by Ong in his otherwise fairly comprehensive list (above) is music, whether vocal or instrumental. He does acknowledge the control exercised by music over variation of the text: 'Music may act as a constraint to fix a verbatim oral narrative,' but as far as that goes, laws of scansion, rhyme, tone, morphology and syntax are inbuilt textual controls." See John D. Wilson, "Scripture in an Oral Culture: The Yali of Irian Jaya," Ph.D. diss., University of Edinburgh, 1988.

[561]Jason Beaubien, "Liberian Singers Use the Power of Music to Raise Ebola Awareness," *NPR* http://www.npr.org/2014/10/12/355427316/liberian-singers-use-the-power-of-music-to-raise-ebola-awareness (Accessed 01 December 2014).

Real."[562] Adekoya relates that the phrases "The thing, Ebola, now come" and "The thing now show face" have most impacted people. Beaubien reports:

> "'The thing now come, the thing now show face.' That's the thing that the children enjoy," [Adekoya] says. "People go around, people be like 'No shaking hands my man.' In the Liberian way when they say, 'The thing now come,' it means the thing is here. Now we know it's here and it has shown its face. So we all understand that's in our midst now; we gotta be careful."[563]

While music is a universal mode of information dissemination among oral cultures, style of music is not. For music to be an effective medium of message the style must be contextualized to the culture. Like the reformers and Adekoya, messengers encounter contextualized forms already present in the culture. Rick Brown relates:

> A common mistake made by some cross-cultural broadcasters and producers is to assume that music is a universal language. This is simply not true. For one thing, rhythms and melodies usually reflect the metrical and intonational patterns of each language, and these are not universal.[564]

A New Message in Old Forms

Though the growth of literacy during the Middle Ages and Reformation Period fostered textual cognition, orality continued to be the dominant framework by which information spread. The advent of mass-production print did not usurp oral media; rather, it was apprehended by the oral milieu and made to enhance the orality framework. Broadsheets, sermons, dialogue, ballads, and hymns continued to be the primary means

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[562]F.A. and Soul Fresh, "Ebola is Real," https://soundcloud.com/unicef-liberia/hott-fm-ebola-song (accessed 01 December 2014).

[563]Beaubien, "Liberian Singers Use the Power of Music to Raise Ebola Awareness."

[564]Brown, "How to Make Oral Communication More Effective," 175. Interestingly, Voth contends that rap music is a medium that is thoroughly "oral." See Voth, "Orality and Writtenness in Ancient Near Eastern Philosophy," 115, 127.

by which Reformation ideas spread. The Reformers offered a new message, but they did not reinvent the media.

They continued to use traditional, oral forms of communication to communicate new doctrine, and they labored within the orality framework with which they themselves were well acquainted, having been reared therein. Thus, communication within this context came quite naturally to them.

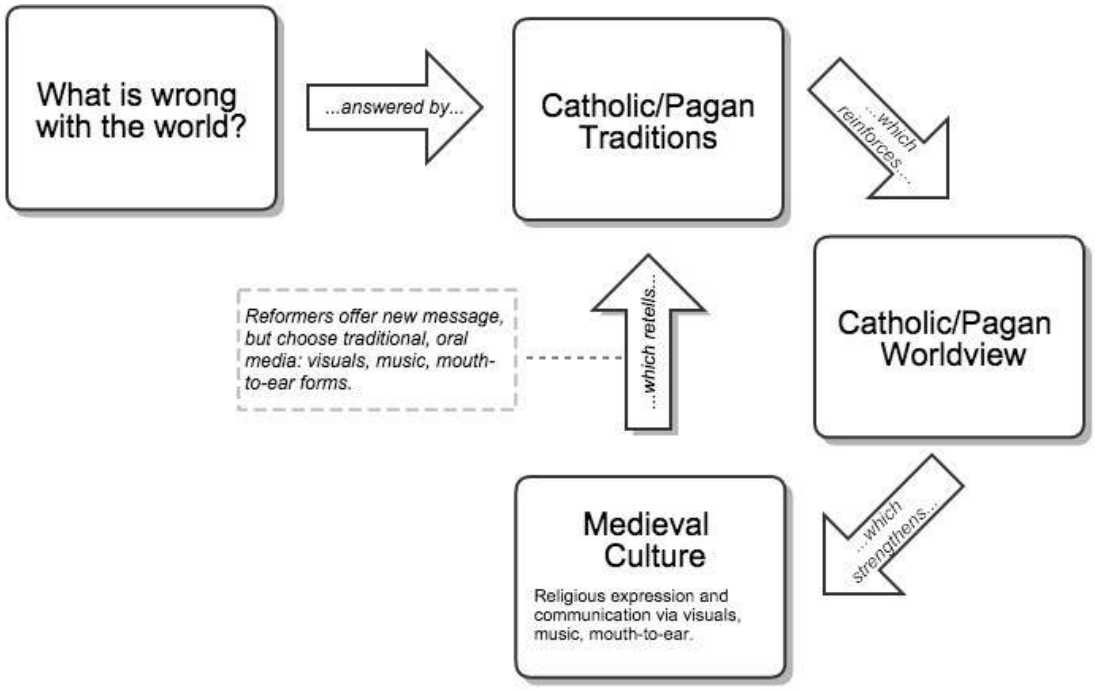

Figure 4.7: Contextualization of Reformation Message

Secondary Orality: Campus Crusade for Christ

Orality is gaining ground in traditionally textual contexts. This phenomenon is known as "secondary orality," a term coined by Ong in *Orality and Literacy* in 1982. He states:

> I style the orality of a culture totally untouched by any knowledge of writing or print, "primary orality." It is "primary" by contrast with the "secondary orality" of present-day high-technology culture, in which a new orality is sustained by

> telephone, radio, television, and other electronic devices that depend for their existence and functioning on writing and print.[565]

Moon observes, "Ong, however, had no idea that the explosion of digital media was just around the corner. The small flame of secondary oral learning has blazed into a brush fire."[566] Ong could have never imagined the flood of technology that would ensue, ushering in what Jonah Sachs calls the "digitoral" age and effectively closing the "Gutenberg Parenthesis."[567] Rick Brown succinctly explains this movement:

> A general trend in history has been the progress from primary orality to some literacy with residual orality, and from then in some cases [e.g. U.S. academia] to print-oriented culture. The modern trend is to move on to secondary orality, to a post-literate or multi-media culture.[568]

This multi-media culture, which is dependent upon literacy technologies, has actually paved the way for a resurgence of the orality framework. Zeynep Tufecki, assistant professor at the University of North Carolina at the School of Information and Library Science, explains the oral nature of Twitter, stating:

> This distinction is probably a bit harder to observe in the English Twitter-verse since English is so thoroughly colonized by writing. Whenever I dive into the Turkish Twitter, I notice tweets employing many forms of Turkish which are solely found in oral Turkish and almost never written down in literate culture. I think this distinction may be more visible in other societies where oral culture was

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[565]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 11.

[566]Jay W. Moon, "I Love to Learn but I Don't Like to Read: The Rise of Secondary Oral Learning," *Orality Journal* 2, no. 2 (2013): 63.

[567]Chiang comments, "Academicians are now labeling the time span from the fifteenth to the twentieth century the Gutenberg Parenthesis as a period when the left side of the brain took over and gave birth to sciences, inventions, and philosophies, but in so doing relieved the right-side brain of its active engagement in creativity." Samuel Chiang, "Post Gutenberg: Oral Preference Learners Welcome the 'Digitoral Era' Era," *Mission Frontiers* (Nov-Dec 2013), 10.

[568]Brown, "Communicating God's Message in Oral Cultures," 27.

> not as decisively beaten back as in the English speaking world — this makes it harder to explain the issue in English.[569]

Characteristics of Secondary Orality

Jonathan Sterne states that secondary orality "depends on the powers of externalization first developed in literature culture, but it returns to a kind of oral mindset of an expansive present and universal interconnectedness."[570] Secondary oral learners have acquired literacy skills and are dependent upon writing technologies, but they prefer to process and image information within an oral framework.[571]

While there are differences between primary, residual, and secondary orality, the same fundamental characteristics undergird them all. Those that fall within the category of secondary orality, however, may be difficult to identify due to the highly textual milieu in which they reside. The advancement of the West is in large partly due to the opportunities literacy has occasioned. Moreover, educational attainment and literacy levels far out-pace those of the developing world. Yet, secondary orality is increasingly prevalent among these literate, educated contexts.[572]

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[569]Zeynep Tufecki, "Why Twitter's Oral Culture Irritates Bill Keller (and why this is an important issue)," Technosociology, http://technosociology.org/?p=431 (accessed 20 November 2014).

[570]Jonathan Sterne, "The Theology of Sound: A Critique of Orality," *Candadian Journal of Communication* 36 (2011): 207.

[571]Moon, "I Love to Learn but I Don't Like to Read," 56.

[572]Lovejoy reports, "The National Adult Literacy Survey (NALS) administered by the U.S. Department of Education in the early 1990s found that 48-51% of adults in the U. S. scored at the two lowest literacy levels (out of five levels)." See Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," 22. Zeynep makes the point that "Europe and the United states are thoroughly dominated by the written culture even though oral culture is still with us because orality is deeply and intrinsically human; all human societies are also oral cultures." See Tufecki, "Why Twitter's Oral Culture Irritates Bill Keller (and why

Secondary oral learners not only depend heavily upon non-print media, but they also manifest the deeper structures of the orality framework that are present in primary and residual orality contexts. Sachs points out that like primary oral societies, "messages move through social networks" and that "stories dominate" likewise in secondary oral societies.[573]

Ong states, "This new orality has striking resemblance to the old in its participatory mystique, its fostering of a communal sense, its concentration on the present moment, and even its use of formulas."[574] Chiang describes how characteristics of orality are borne among secondary oral learners in the Western context. He explains:

> Thus, the period that commenced with the Gutenberg press and closed with the development of digital platforms has been labeled the Gutenberg Parenthesis. The result is once again a more holistic approach to society and tasks, thereby recapturing creativity, collaboration, and community. In oral cultures, the information is local and always rooted in context and history, so that there is meaning with coherence to the community. In digital culture, like that of Facebook postings, the emphasis is on morphing the private and individual into open, specific, contextual, and communal experiences, albeit at a distance…So pervasive is this practice that we often discover products and services by relying on our social networks. We are conscious of how our postings will be rated. We are constantly seeking feedback both to improve and validate decisions. Our social networks (communities) are often buying together, and our digital communities are themselves becoming products and services.[575]

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this is an important issue)."

[573]Sachs, *Winning the Story Wars*, Preview Booklet.

[574]Ong, *Orality and Literacy*, 133. Ong, however, goes on to give a more nuanced comparison. He states, "Secondary orality is both remarkably like and remarkably unlike primary orality. Like primary orality, secondary orality has generated a strong group sense, for listening to spoken words forms hearers into a group, a true audience, just as reading written or printed texts turns individuals into themselves. But secondary orality generates a sense for groups immeasurably larger than those of primary oral culture."

[575]Chiang, "Post Gutenberg!," 10.

Secondary Orality Research

Mark Snowden and Avery Willis report that fewer than half of all adults in the U.S. read prose literature. Further, two-thirds of college graduates cannot read with proficiency. The U.S., as well as other traditionally textual contexts, is experiencing a dramatic shift "toward non-print media for entertainment, information gathering, and education."[576]

Jay Moon, Professor at Asbury Theological Seminary and former SIM missionary in Ghana, took note of many conversations with students that seemed to betray an underlying orality framework. Despite the fact that these students had earned undergraduate degrees and were now pursuing further education, it seemed to Moon they were not thoroughly textual. Moon embarked on a nine-year exploration of the prevalence of secondary orality among seminary students. The results are arresting.[577]

Over the nine-year study 281 seminary students were assessed using the "Learning Preference Assessment." Moon found the total number of students with an oral learning preference was 53.5 percent. Further, Moon assessed 23 seminary professors and found that 21.5 percent exhibited an oral preference. Finally, Moon assessed 32

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[576]Mark Snowden and Avery Willis, "What God hath Wrought: The Electronic Breakthrough that Revived Orality," in *Orality Breakouts: Using Heart Language to Transform Hearts,* Samuel E. Chiang, ed. (Hong Kong: ION/LCWE, 2010), 19.

[577]Moon's research is published in both *Missions Frontiers* and *William Carey International Development Journal* in two separate articles. See W. Jay Moon, "I Love to Learn but I Don't Like to Read: The Rise of Secondary Oral Learning," *Orality Journal* 2, no. 2 (2013): 55-65; and Jay Moon, "Encouraging Ducks to Swim: Suggestions for Seminary Professors Teaching Oral Learners," *William Carey International Development Journal* 2, no. 2 (Spring 2013): 3-10.

undergraduate students, finding 78 percent leaning toward an oral learning preference.[578] Moon's research confirms that a learning shift is occurring in the textual West. Though the focus on Moon's research was teaching seminary students more effectively, it raises the question of how might secondary orality effect the way evangelism and discipleship are done in traditionally textual societies?

Steve Douglass' Experiment

Steve Douglass, President of Campus Crusade for Christ International (CCCI), had a startling realization after he was exposed to the issue of orality in the task of global evangelization. "It dawned on me that students in colleges thought like this, too."[579] Mark Snowden and Avery Willis report:

> In 2005, Douglass began discipling a small group at the University of Central Florida by using oral methods, particularly storying. He began a pilot project to see firsthand if storying would work among proficient readers. The original two small groups branched into eight within four months. Douglass agreed to work beyond the initial dozen lessons and created a new set plus a one-page leader guide for each session. He encouraged the original two groups to begin their own groups. By February 2007, there were 35 groups involving 290 students. Today, these groups have spread to more than forty campuses.[580]

In 2010 Douglass stated:

> Avery Willis has been an inspiration and source of wisdom for me in understanding how to communicate with Americans who prefer to learn by visual and oral means. As I applied some of the principles Avery teaches, I discovered more effective ways to communicate biblical truths to college students.[581]

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[578]Moon, "I Love to Learn but I Don't Like to Read," 58-60.

[579]Quoted in Mark Snowden and Avery Willis, "What God hath Wrought: The Electronic Breakthrough that Revived Orality," 18.

[580]Snowden and Willis, "What God hath Wrought," 18.

[581] Willis and Snowden, *Truth that Sticks*, Front Matter.

Douglass and CCCI engaged with secondary oral learners by operating within the orality framework. He began by employing the discipline of storying in a small group. He saw positive results because oral learners prefer truth that is embedded in concrete, real-life contexts, like stories. Secondary orality, however, differs from primary orality contexts in that the media available for communication is greatly enhanced by technology. Primary oral cultures are limited to live mouth-to-ear modes. Present-day secondary orality societies have many modes at their disposal.

CCCI developed +Essentials24.org, a tool geared for secondary oral learners. Here one can find an online or local community to join. The Bible study lessons are a combination of literate, video, and audio media. Moreover, CCCI launched the Global Shortfilm Network, which uses media to engage oral preference learners.[582]

Resistance to the Oral Resurgence

Predictably, some resist the onslaught of technology and its accompanying effects. This kind of anxiety, of course, is not new. The technology of writing was not without its critics. Plato's Socrates in the *Phaedrus* warns:

> You offer your pupils the appearance of wisdom, not true wisdom, for they will read many things without instruction and will therefore seem to know many things, when they are for the most part ignorant and hard to get along with, since they are not wise, but only appear wise.[583]

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[582]See http://globalshortfilmnetwork.com/.

[583]Plato, *Plato in Twelve Volumes*, 275a-b.

He was not alone in his reservations about this new technology. In 1477, Hieronimo Squarciafico insisted that an abundance of books impedes study, impairs memory, and weakens the mind by depriving it of necessary exercise.[584]

Similarly, Bill Keller, executive editor of the *New York Times*, laments the effects of digital communications that, in his view, are eroding crucial human characteristics. He expresses his sentiment with this quip: "Last week my wife and I told our 13-year-old daughter she could join Facebook. Within a few hours she had accumulated 171 friends, and I felt a little as if I had passed my child a pipe of crystal meth."[585]

Keller makes three main arguments against these technologies. First, humans no longer have to remember anything, and this diminishes cognitive abilities resulting in a stupider race. Second, he asserts "There is something decidedly faux about the camaraderie of Facebook, something illusory about the connectedness of Twitter."[586]

The third argument is the most intriguing and pertinent here. Keller states, "Then along came the Mark Zuckerberg of his day, Johannes Gutenberg. As we became accustomed to relying on the printed page, the work of remembering gradually fell into disuse."[587] Zeynep Tufecki observes:

> But this comparison between Gutenberg and Zuckerberg makes little sense unless you realize that Keller is actually trying to complain about the reemergence of oral psychodynamics in the public sphere rather than about memory falling out of

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[584]Martin Lowry, *The World of Aldus Manutius: Business and Scholarship in Renaissance Venice.* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1979), 29-32.

[585]Bill Keller, "The Twitter Trap," NYTimes.com, http://www.nytimes.com/2011/05/22/magazine/the-twitter-trap.html (Published May 18, 2011).

[586]Keller, "The Twitter Trap."

[587]Ibid.

> favor. If the latter were the case, his ire would be more about Google; instead, most of his frustration is directed against social media, and mostly Twitter, the most conversational, and thus most oral of these mediums.[588]

Conclusion

Sachs, referring to the Western context, asserts, "The oral tradition that dominated human experience for all but the last few hundred years is returning with a vengeance."[589] Thus, principles of the orality framework are not limited to isolated tribes or developing nations. Orality is a key issue within the most developed nations of the world. William Bjoraker states:

> We may be rightly disconcerted about the loss of literacy in America, but this turn also offers opportunities. Oral cultures have always been characterized by relational face-to-face communication using stories, proverbs, songs, chants, drama, poetry, and other forms of communal and interactive events. Western literate people are hungering for these elements in an increasing way. When a wave like this arises in our culture, we advance Messiah's mission should get out our "surfboards" and ride it for Kingdom purposes.[590]

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[588]Tufecki, "Why Twitter's Oral Culture Irritates Bill Keller."

[589]Sachs, *Winning the Story Wars*, 20.

[590]William Bjoraker, "The 'People of the Book' are the People of the Story: Storytelling in Contemporary Jewish Ministry," *William Carey International Development Journal* 2, no. 2 (Spring 2013): 29.

Chapter 5

Summary and Conclusion

Jesus' defining mode of teaching was storytelling.[591] His stories were not mere illustrations to illumine the main point of a sermon—they were the point. Jesus endeavored to challenge the existing Jewish worldview and furnish an alternative picture of reality through these stories. Wright comments:

> They were ways of cracking open the worldview of Jesus' hearers, so that it could be remoulded into the worldview which he, Jesus, was commending. His stories, like all stories, invited his hearers into a new world, making the implicit suggestion that the new worldview be tried on for size with a view to permanent purchase.[592]

On a practical level, stories are generally better received than propositional teaching. Through stories missionaries are able to challenge worldviews without being perceived as confrontational.[593] Wright contends:

> Stories are, actually, particularly good at modifying or subverting other stories and their worldviews. Where head-on attack would certainly fail, the parable hides the wisdom of the serpent behind the innocence of the dove, gaining entrance and favor which can then be used to change assumptions which the hearer would otherwise keep hidden away for safety.[594]

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[591]Peterson, *Stories of Jesus*, 7.

[592]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

[593] Thompson, "Tell His Story so that All Might Worship," 395.

[594]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 40.

This *sub rosa* reconstruction takes place over time as the comprehensive biblical worldview comes into focus with each story told. As the stories coalesce into a unified narrative of God's saving work, the hearer has the opportunity to embrace a new foundational narrative, which is, in fact, worldview transformation.[595]

Stories create and embody the quintessence of worldview. Creeds, systematic theologies, and propositional statements emerge from these stories. Consequently, evangelistic and discipleship approaches that proffer only theological abstractions, much like treating pneumonia with cough syrup, reaches not to the subterranean core of individuals and societies. The missionary who does not challenge worldview by supplanting existing foundational story with an alternative narrative invites syncretism, and ultimately apostasy.

Worldview, beliefs, values, and behaviors receive their life-sustaining nourishment from foundational narrative. Abstractions taught by missionaries that are not connected to a deeper reality, namely a story that satisfactorily answers the existential questions, will wither and succumb to the essential worldview and value system that is deeply tied to worldview stories.[596] Recall Wright's assertion:

> To "boil off" an abstract set of propositions as though one were thereby getting to a more foundational statement would actually be to falsify the worldview at a basic point. This is not to say that we cannot use shorthand phrases and words to refer, in a few syllables, to a complex story-form worldview which it would be tedious to spell out each time. Thus the phrase "monotheism and election" does not refer to two abstracted entities existing outside space and time. It is a way of summoning into the mind's eye an entire worldview.[597]

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[595]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Leaners*, 35.

[596]Ibid.

[597]Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77. One may contend that Paul eschewed the story-form electing to convey spiritual truths via distilled abstractions exclusively. In point of fact, Paul's most forceful arguments are articulations of the

Christians today can invite others into God's sacred story by telling it to them. The most productive activity to unseat existing narratives is to tell a story that more satisfactorily answers the existential questions, and the story of the Bible provides unparalleled answers.[598] Effective Bible storying, however, occurs only when it takes place in congruence with the orality framework. The presentation of the sacred narrative must be contextualized into the oral milieu of the culture.

Summary

History

In recent years evangelicals have increasingly employed oral forms of communication as a primary methodology. However, neither orality nor the elements of CBS are new. Orality, especially the oral and chronological communication of the Scriptures, pervades the composition and content of the Scriptures and characterizes the experience of followers of Jesus throughout history. Moreover, orality has come to light as a crucial issue in cross-cultural communication since the beginning of the modern missions era.[599]

"essentially Jewish story now redrawn around Jesus." Paul, in his numerous statements about the cross and resurrection of Jesus, is in reality retelling the full story of God, Israel, and the world in the story of Jesus. See Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, 77.

[598]Lovejoy, *Making Disciples of Oral Leaners*, 33.

[599]Lovejoy, "Chronological Bible Storying," 2.

Jonathan Gottschall asserts, “Thousands of years ago, when the human mind was young and our numbers were few, we were telling one another stories.”[600] Throughout history cultures have valued, invented, repeated, and preserved stories; and, although renewed emphasis on orality and oral methodologies exists, the use of stories and parables deployed within oral frameworks is ubiquitous throughout history, especially in the Old and New Testaments.[601]

Due to the popularization of the moveable type printing press, textuality gained slight ground on orality. Those who live within the orality framework, however, continue to comprise the vast majority of the world’s population. Judeo-Christian history is no exception. The Old Testament is rife with glimpses of the orality framework. Jesus himself is best characterized as a storyteller. The early church is teeming with accounts of Christians adjusting their teaching to fit the orality framework. Recently, the issue of orality in missions has surfaced with renewed vigor beginning in the early 1980s as Trevor McIlwain’s chronological methodology spread from NTM to the IMB, eventually finding applications in sundry ministry contexts.

The Orality Framework

Walter J. Ong, among others, pioneered modern research in the field of orality. Inauspiciously, their groundbreaking research did not set the trajectory for evangelical engagement with oral cultures. Attention to the reality that literacy technologies profoundly affect the cognition of societies has been parenthetical at best. Effective

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[600]Gottschell, *The Storytelling Animal*, xiii.

[601]Terry, “Roots of CBS,” 3.

engagement of oral peoples requires a wide view of the complexity of orality and the profundity of narrative in conversion, discipleship, and church formation processes.

This research project sought to allay these limitations by answering compulsory questions concerning orality. What is the nature of the oral framework in which narrative becomes effective? How does narrative relate to the process of conversion and discipleship? And, what is the role of narrative in church formation?

As Charles Madinger comments:

> The framework for our communication strategies must take on everything you think of when "oral" comes to mind…Every message, lesson, curriculum program and strategy will succeed partly to the degree it takes this framework into account.[602]

The orality framework includes the use of narrative, but also encompasses cognitive processes, media selection, relational networks, and content structure. Orality is a comprehensive framework, which provides a means by which one may apply narrative-based methodologies within oral societies.

In the past, missionaries measured conversion and discipleship solely in terms of orthopraxy. That standard of measurement, nonetheless, was lacking. Many missionaries turned to orthodoxy for a more dependable indicator. Still, neither of these components comprises the core of culture. Hiebert likens culture to an iceberg. While behavior and beliefs manifest themselves above the surface, it is the hidden mass beneath that holds the whole iceberg up. The hidden mass is worldview.[603] In time, worldview will take any altered beliefs or behaviors captive. Thus, worldview transformation is critical in conversion and discipleship.

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[602]Mandinger, "Applied Orality: More than Methods," 6.

[603]Hiebert, "Conversion and Worldview Transformation," 84.

The key here is the fact that worldview cannot be set upon directly because it is the reflection of a still deeper reality—foundational narrative. The missionary must seek to remake worldview through the telling of a new and better story that more satisfactorily answers the existential questions to which all people seek answers. Christian conversion implies an exchange of worldview. How one may go about this exchange is fundamental. This exchange is not accomplished by teaching Christian values, building Christian institutions, stressing Christian behavior. Rather, "Worldview change is best accomplished by studying and telling or retelling the biblical 'big story' that enshrines Christian worldview."[604] Hence, the function and purpose of narrative in conversion and discipleship is more complex than a mere issue of "preference."

But, what of church formation? How does the foundational narrative relate to the creation and preservation of homogenous units under the banner of the gospel? Homogenous unit theory, pioneered by Donald McGavran, may be applied more broadly than only to the area of evangelism. Christian churches are essentially homogenous units. Moreover, the specifications of what Christian churches should share in common is significant. Unquestionably, the foundational narrative of Scripture is uniquely suited to create, strengthen, and preserve community.

The very essence of church is a unit that is homogenized by a common experience of redemption through Jesus Christ. This redemption has been preserved in the form of narrative, and it is a common belief and vestment in this story that creates healthy, vibrant, and enduring communities of faith. These faith communities, or churches, are only as durable as their recollection of and allegiance to the gospel story. Thus, symbols and rituals are utilized to continually reinforce and recount the foundational narrative.

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[604]Hesselgrave, *Scripture and Strategy*, 50.

Orality in Context

Insights into the orality framework ought not remain in the realm of scholarly rumination. If 5.7 billion people in the world today function within the orality framework, then application of orality principles to mission philosophy, strategy, and methodology is critical. Grant Lovejoy agrees, "Ministries who adjust their approach to the literacy level of their group, whatever that level may be, can expect improved communication, more learning, and more life change among the hearers."[605] David Sill reports, however, that at least 90 percent of resources for evangelism, discipleship, and leadership development are textual in nature.[606]

Several case studies were considered for analysis in light of the orality framework. These case studies presented examples of seeing cultures through "oral eyes," even when the missionary about whom the study was written did not. In order to engage oral cultures one must first apprehend the orality framework and then tease out the forms that those principles inhabit in a given oral context, then the task of contextualizing the gospel message may commence.

The case studies centered around three predominant oral milieus: primary orality, residual orality, and secondary orality. Bruce Olson's engagement of the Motilone tribe hinged upon his ability to function within the orality framework of this primary oral tribe. The undertaking required more than putting the gospel into audible, narrative form.

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[605]Lovejoy, "Extent of Orality Update," 30; J. Dudley Woodberry, ed., *From Seed to Fruit*, 2nd ed., (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Press, 2011). Similarly, Jack Colgate asserts, "Teams who understand the learning preferences (whether oral or literate) of their people group and incorporate this into team strategy were more fruitful (in terms of numbers of fellowships planted) by 340 percent!" Colgate, "Bible Storying and Oral Use of the Scriptures," 221.

Beyond obtaining language and culture, Olson became familiar with the oral tradition of the Motilone and employed these ancient narratives to spell out the gospel. Olson's determination to reside with the Motilone community permitted him to establish deep, personal relationships. He was emotionally connected with the Motilones, as opposed to being intellectually detached from them. Like the Motilones, Olson learned to place a premium on group consensus and community exploits, and it was within this oral framework that Olson was able to share the gospel in a way that was comprehensible to the Motilone Indians.

The printing press and vitalizing force of the Reformation produced a context in which residual orality was prevalent. Though the growth of literacy during the late Medieval and Reformation periods fostered textual cognition, orality continued to be the dominant framework by which information spread. The advent of mass-production print did not usurp oral media; rather, it was apprehended by the oral milieu and made to enhance oral framework. Broadsheets, sermons, dialogue, ballads, and hymns continued to be the primary means by which Reformation ideas spread. The Reformers offered a new message, but they did not reinvent the media. They continued to use traditional, oral forms of communication to communicate new doctrine, and they labored within the oral framework in which they themselves were well acquainted, having been reared therein. Thus, communication within this context came quite naturally to them.

Secondary orality is a reality increasingly apparent in traditionally textual societies. The oral milieu that dominated human cognition for millennia is retaking textual territory. That being so, tendencies and affordances of orality are now present in societies that have been traditionally textual for the past few hundred years. Though this

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[606]Sills, *Reaching and Teaching the Highland Quichuas*, 8.

shift is met with disdain by many, it is an opportunity followers of Christ to return to modes of communication that pervade the Scriptures – parable, proverb, song, poetry, and narrative.[607]

Orality Fluency

On Friday, December 5, 2014 at 7:05 a.m. EST the United Launch Alliance Delta IV Heavy rocket lifted off from Cape Canaveral Air Force Station's Space Launch Complex 37. Sealed atop the rocket was NASA's Orion spacecraft.[608] The United Launch Alliance Delta IV Heavy rocket's boosters produced 660,000 pounds of thrust, elevating Orion to an altitude of approximately 3,600 miles above the Earth's surface, fifteen times farther than the orbital position of the International Space Station. Tony Taliancich, United Launch Alliance's director of East Coast Launch Operations stated, "The Delta IV Heavy is the world's most powerful launch vehicle flying today."[609]

Despite the crucial role played by Delta IV, news headlines all but ignored it. "NASA's Orion Completes First Test Flight," "Textbook launch for NASA's Orion spacecraft," "Splashdown! Orion Spaceship Aces First Flight Test on Road to Mars," "NASA spaceship Orion successfully completes debut test run," and a multitude of similar announcements heralded the mission, but they failed to mention the elements

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[607]Bjoraker, "The 'People of the Book' are the People of the Story," 29.

[608]Steven Siceloff, "Successful Launch of Orion Heralds First Step on Journey to Mars," NASA, http://nasa.gov/content/successful-launch-of-orion-heralds-first-step-on-journey-to-mars/#.VIXsrKZOLCR (Accessed 05 December 2014).

[609]"United Launch Alliance Moves Delta IV Heavy Rocket to Launch Pad for Orion's Exploration Flight Test," http://ulalaunch.com/lua-moves-eft-1-delta-iv-heavy-to-launch-pad.aspx (Accessed 05 December 2014).

essential to Orion's success.[610] Orion, after all, is the spacecraft that NASA anticipates being the first vehicle capable of taking humans into deep space and providing safe re-entry amidst deep space return velocities. Yet, Orion's capabilities and benefits cannot be accessed without the framework that places it in contexts in which it can accomplish that for which it was crafted.

Like Orion, Bible storying commands most of the headlines in the evangelical orality movement. Yet, the effect and usefulness of Bible storying is wholly dependent upon the orality framework. Just as Delta IV played a crucial role in Orion's success, there exists a wider framework that must be considered in the engagement of oral peoples that is much more pervasive and profound than simply a preference for narrative. Efficacious engagement of oral learners reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

If missionaries are serious about the monumental task of contextualizing the gospel for oral peoples (80 percent of the world[611]) they must expend time and energy to become fluent in orality. In fact, orality fluency, practically speaking, is the primary

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[610]NPR, http://www.npr.org/2014/12/06/369008753/mars-or-bust-nasas-orion-completes-first-test-flight; CBSNEWS, http://www.cbsnews.com/news/nasa-to-try-orion-rocket-launch-again; NBCNEWS, http://www.nbcnews.com/science/space/splashdown-orion-spaceship-aces-first-flight-test-road-mars-n262146; AlJazeera America, http://america.aljazeera.com/articles/2014/12/5/nasa-unmanned-spaceshipblastsofffortrialrun.html.

[611]Grant Lovejoy, in "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," estimated that, "5.7 billion people in the world are oral communicators because they are either illiterate or their reading comprehension in inadequate. That is over 80% of the world's population." See Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," 29.

factor that separates run-of-the-mill narrators of the gospel from highly effective communicators of the gospel.

Achieving fluency in orality includes becoming a proficient storyer, but proficiency in storying is achieved only when the storyteller learns to narrate within the context of cognitive processes, media preferences, community dynamics, and content structures that are often foreign to the textual messenger. Consider Elizabeth Wilson's experience:

> It was about midday. I sat on our shaded concrete porch and watched determined villagers, wearing worn flip flops, trek along dusty paths that crisscrossed the surrounding foothills of the majestic Himalayan Mountains. At the other end of the porch, I listened as my colleague asked our language helper for the equivalent of three pictures (a square, a circle, and a triangle) in the local Kahani language. After taking a long look at the shapes, our language helper responded with these words:
>
> *"Handkerchief" for square*
> *"Chapatti" (round flat bread) for circle*
> *"Mountain" for triangle*
>
> It was at that moment that I first realized I was living among an oral people group tucked away in the mountains of South Asia.[612]

Wilson glimpsed the profound difference in how she and those she wished to reach with the gospel imaged the world all around. The disparity between textual and oral folk cannot be overstated.

In studying Keysser's efforts, G. F. Vicedom states:

> If they asked people why they were unwilling to become Christians, the answer would be, "Your God is a foreign God...Christianity is contrary to our customs...Our ancestors were not Christians; we cannot be Christians either...Our clan does not permit it." These answers reveal the extent to which a Papuan always thinks and acts as a member of a community.[613]

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[612]Elizabeth Wilson, "Breakthroughs," in *Orality Breakouts: Using Heart Language to Transform Hearts,* Samuel E. Chiang, ed. Hong Kong: ION/LCWE, 2010) 27.

[613]Vicedom, "An Example of Group Conversion," 124.

Vicedom confronted the reality of profound difference in community dynamic among oral folk.

There is no doubting the importance of narrative in the endeavor to communicate the gospel to oral cultures. However, Western missionaries, in their quest for a methodological key, have rushed to replace their abstract forms of teaching with narrative, all the while turning a blind eye to the wider reality of orality. They have placed the cart before the horse, as it were, and have ended up with a partial contextualization. Deep and enduring contextualization requires a more extensive assessment and application of orality. Efficacious engagement of oral learners reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

Sustainability and reproducibility is of primary concern in this discussion. How will oral peoples who are evangelized and discipled within a textual framework be able to reach their own oral people? J. O. Terry commented:

> I will say that building on McIlwain's discovery of the need for a chronological theological foundation, what we are discovering through personal experience (mostly trial and error making intuitive adaptation) has plunged most of us into a new world of Orality. Many still revert to literate means that they are comfortable with. This allows them to carry out their strategies of teaching knowledge, but does not always lead to empowering oral learners to understand, remember and be able (or motivated) to recall and retell.[614]

David Sills agrees, stating:

> Even when some oral learners embrace the truth taught through inappropriate methods, a vicious cycle begins that results in newly trained teachers in the host

[614]J. O. Terry, e-mail message to author, December 24, 2014.

> culture who only know how to teach their own people using foreign methods and, inevitably, a foreign language.[615]

Jay Moon relates the sentiments of one of his seminary students who emanated from an oral milieu:

> I grew up in an oral culture but in school we were discouraged from using oral methods to communicate; rather, we are rewarded with good grades for writing fine research papers and other print assessment methods. Unfortunately, when I go back to my home in Korea, they do not understand me any more. I forgot how to communicate using the oral methods that the local people appreciate! I feel like a duck out of water.[616]

A critical question for textual missionaries moving forward is how to become fluent in orality. Much research and monitored experience has gone into understanding the process of learning language and culture, and this sort of focus is needed in adaption to the orality framework.

Conclusion

Communicating the gospel across cultural barriers is implicit in the Great Commission. Jesus mandated that his followers should go and make disciples πάντα τὰ ἔθνη (Matt. 28:19a). The gospel was not limited to Israel, but it was good news for all peoples in all lands. Thus, beginning with Paul, Christians continue to take the gospel to πάντα τὰ ἔθνη.

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[615]Sills, *Reaching and Teaching the Quichua*, 107. Sills comments, "Indeed, traditional seminary education and TEE by their very nature require that the student be able to read, write, critically reflect, and engage in self-study. In cultures where these ways of learning are not traditionally valued as they are in Western cultures, the results have been disappointing (107).

[616]Moon, "Encouraging Ducks to Swim," 3.

Fluency in language and culture traditionally have been the benchmarks of effectively engaging cultures in the task of διδάσκοντες αὐτοὺς τηρεῖν πάντα ὅσα ἐνετειλάμην ὑμῖν (Matt. 28:20a). Missionaries have endeavored to inhabit the milieus in which they labor in order to transpose the message of the gospel in such a way that indigenous Christianity resulted with minimal levels of syncretism and apostasy. In recent decades, however, missionaries have been confronted with a third component of putting the gospel into a culture.

More than 80 percent of the world's population function within the orality framework.[617] The prevalence of oral learners alone is sufficient stimulus to analyze the nature of orality. However, when one apprehends the extensive effect orality possesses in evangelization, discipleship, and church planting, impetus to address this issue becomes critical. Orality's sweeping implications for missions cannot be ignored. Efficacious engagement of oral learners reaches beyond Bible storying to include an embodiment of the oral framework through deliberate adjustment of cognitive process, media selection, relational emphasis, and content structure.

[617]Lovejoy, "The Extent of Orality: 2012 Update," 29.

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